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NEW DELHI/METRO
Thursday, April 09, 2026
■ VOL. CII NO. 84



Hindustan Times

RBI cuts growth forecast, in 'wait-and-watch' mode

Roshan Kishore

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) projections for growth and inflation suggest that the Indian economy, thanks to the war in West Asia, has gone from a Goldilocks — low-inflation and high-growth — environment towards potential stagflation — high-inflation and low-growth.

RBI now expects the Indian economy to grow at 6.9% in 2026-27 with risks tilted to the downside. In the current GDP

Calibrated outlook

RBI base-case and scenario projections

BASELINE PROJECTIONS	UNIT	FY26(f)	FY27(f)	FY28(f)
Crude price assumptions	\$/bbl		85	75
Growth	% y-o-y	7.6	6.9	6.6
Inflation	% y-o-y	1.9	4.6	4.6
SCENARIO PROJECTIONS	UNIT	FY26(f)	FY27(f)	FY28(f)
Crude price assumptions	\$/bbl		95	85
Growth	% y-o-y	7.6	6.7	6.4
Inflation	% y-o-y	1.9	5	5.1

Source: RBI, HSBC

(f): Forecast

policy stance unchanged at 5.25% and neutral. And the signalling which could have been seen in changes in RBI's annual growth and inflation forecasts is missing because the February MPC meeting postponed releasing full-year forecasts for 2026-27 before the government released growth and inflation data under the new series. RBI's Monetary Policy Report issued on Wednesday, projects a 6.6% GDP growth for 2027-28 assuming crude oil at \$75/barrel.

World Bank's South Asia Regional Outlook released on

series, which has annual GDP growth data till 2023-24, this is the lowest and the first sub-7% growth. Inflation projection for 2026-27 now stands at 4.6% and inflation risks for 2026-27, according to RBI, are tilted to the upside.

With the situation still fluid

— it remains to be seen whether the two-week ceasefire in the US-Israel war on Iran announced early Wednesday morning holds and how long does it take to normalise production and shipping of oil and gas from West Asia — RBI has

chosen to wait and watch rather than make tangible changes to the key policy tools at its disposal. Its April Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting, which ended on Wednesday, decided to leave the policy rate and monetary

regional Outlook released on Wednesday projects a GDP growth of 6.6% and 7% for India in 2026-27 and 2027-28.

"RBI kept repo rate and stance unchanged, and the tone of statement was very balanced...While the statement

continued on → 11

CANADA MOVES TO VET DOCUS OF INT'L STUDENTS

Anirudh Bhattacharyya

letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: Canada's immigration department has started sending letters to international students, including many from India, enrolled at higher education institutions to verify their compliance with study permit norms, days after the country's Auditor General flagged fraud in the international student program in a report submitted to Parliament. "Failing to provide the required documents within 21 days could result in the loss of your temporary resident status in Canada," the letter said. →P10

Cabinet hikes fertiliser subsidy to keep costs down for farmers

Zia Haq

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Wednesday cleared ₹41,533 crore towards nutrient-based fertiliser subsidy for Kharif crops, raising it by nearly 12% from the previous cycle, a move to make up for higher costs and cushion farmers amid supply disruptions due to the West Asian conflict. "The West Asian conflict has had an impact on fertilisers. There's no problem of availability in India," Union I&B minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said. →P10

Cabinet nod for women's quota bills to be laid in House session

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Wednesday gave its approval for the introduction of two bills in the upcoming sitting of Parliament that will pave the way for the implementation of

33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, and the setting up of a delimitation commission, a person aware of the details said.

According to the person, the Cabinet's sanction came ahead of the sitting of Parliament.

continued on → 11

DELHI, DHAKA AGREE TO TAKE TIES FORWARD

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India and Bangladesh on Wednesday agreed to take forward the normalising of ties, including resuming existing mechanisms to address differences and bolster trade and energy cooperation, as Bangladesh foreign minister Khalilur Rahman met his counterpart S Jaishankar in Delhi. The two sides decided to address contentious issues such as former PM Sheikh Hasina's presence in India in a manner that they do not impede progress in other aspects of the relationship. →P10

TMC counters after EC's 'straight-talk'

Harsh Yadav

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A meeting between a four-member Trinamool Congress (TMC) delegation with chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi on Wednesday sparked a charged confrontation with an unprecedented attack by the poll panel and a sharp response by the political party.

"EC's Straight-talk to Trinamool Congress. This time, the

Elections in West Bengal would surely be: Fear-free, Violence-free, Intimidation-free, Inducement-free and without any Raid, Booth Jamming and Source Jamming," the poll body said on X.

The TMC hit back. "Our straight-talk to @ECISVEEP. This time, the Elections must be: Free from Delhi's control. Free from political bias, Free from selective targeting, And free from double standards," it said. →P8

→2 STATES, 1 UT TO VOTE TODAY, P8

NIRAV MODI MOVES EUROPE HUMAN RIGHTS COURT IN EXTRADITION CASE

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Fugitive diamondaire Nirav Modi has approached the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR) in a last-ditch bid against his extradition, two weeks after the High Court of Justice in London refused to reopen his case, effectively exhausting his legal options in the UK, people aware of the matter said. →P9



Lodhi Garden turns 90



ANDHRA MAY BAN PVT SLEEPER BUSES AFTER SPATE OF DEADLY ACCIDENTS

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

letters@hindustantimes.com

COLLEGE STUDENT DROWNS IN NOIDA PIT; WENT THERE TO DRINK LIQUOR: COPS

Arun Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh government is considering a ban on private sleeper buses, citing lax compliance with structural and safety norms after a spate of fatal accidents, officials said. The issue was discussed during a meeting of the cabinet sub-committee formed to review measures to prevent bus accidents. →P9



Lodhi Garden on Wednesday. A favourite among morning walkers and solitary seekers, one of Delhi's most beloved green spaces turns 90 on Thursday. >RELATED REPORT ON P4 SANJEEV VERMA/HT

{ CRACKING THE CODE }

Decrypted? Bitcoin creator Satoshi Nakamoto unmasked, says report

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The mystery surrounding Bitcoin's creator may have edged closer to resolution, with a news report identifying British cryptographer Adam Back as the most likely person behind the pseudonym Satoshi Nakamoto — a claim he has denied.

A report in *The New York Times* argues that Back had developed nearly all the core ideas behind Bitcoin at least a decade before Nakamoto published the cryptocurrency's white paper in 2008, citing simi-



Adam Back WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

larities in technical thinking, writing style and online behaviour.

Back rejected the claim, calling the investigation a case of

"confirmation bias" built on coincidences. In a post on X, he said he was involved in early discussions on digital money, but did not create Bitcoin. "I'm not Satoshi... I also don't know who Satoshi is, and I think it is good for Bitcoin that this is the case," he said.

The investigation rests on four key strands: Back's early articulation of Bitcoin-like ideas; parallels between his work and Nakamoto's; a pattern in his online activity that appears to mirror Nakamoto's emergence and disappearance; and similarities in their writing styles.

continued on → 11

NOIDA: A 23-year-old college student drowned on Wednesday after he entered a 20-foot-deep water-filled pit inside a vacant plot owned by Noida authority in Sector 94, where he had allegedly gone to drink alcohol with three friends, officials said. Police identified the victim as Harshit Bhatt, a resident of Ghaziabad. He was a third-year student of physical education at a private university in Noida, officials said. →P4

NHAI NOD FOR CONSTRUCTION OF 2-WAY FLYOVER AT KALINDI KUNJ

Hemani Bhandari

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has approved a long-pending proposal to construct a two-way flyover at Kalindi Kunj, near Delhi-Noida border, aimed at making the chronically congested intersection signal-free, according to documents accessed by HT. The proposed flyover will connect the Khadar Puliya intersection to Noida. →P3

Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

NUMBER THEORY

Younger, polarised: How Assam differs from Kerala

By Abhishek Jha and Roshan Kishore

All of Assam and Kerala will vote to elect a new assembly today. In Assam, the primary contest is between the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress. In Kerala, it is the Communist Party of India (Marxist) or CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) versus the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF). These pages, in the run-up to the elections, have discussed in detail the social, economic and political dynamics of these two states. On polling day, here are four charts which underline key differences in the nature of the electorate and political contest in these two states.

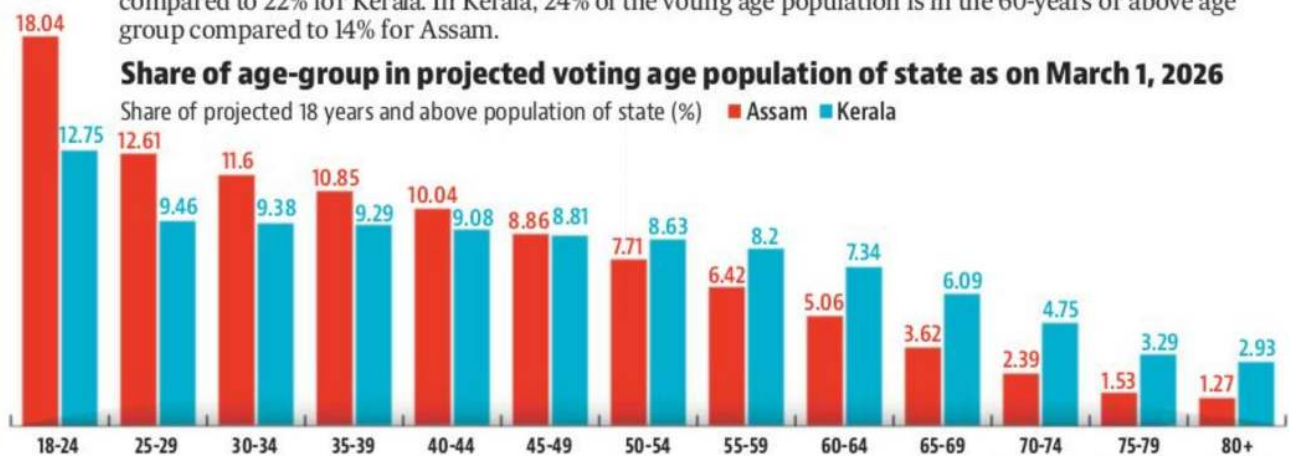


1 Assam's electorate is younger than Kerala's

The Election Commission of India (ECI) does not give a granular break-up of electors by age. Census figures in India are significantly dated. However, it is possible to get an idea of the age-composition of the electorate using government's population projections. Assam's voting age population is significantly younger than Kerala's in this comparison. Almost 31% of Assam's voting age population is below 30-years compared to 22% for Kerala. In Kerala, 24% of the voting age population is in the 60-years or above age group compared to 14% for Assam.

Share of age-group in projected voting age population of state as on March 1, 2026

Share of projected 18 years and above population of state (%) ■ Assam ■ Kerala



Source: National Commission on Population

2 Assam has seen a large increase in voter turnout in the last decade

Assam and Kerala have gone to polls in the same election cycle since 1991. Until 2011, they were largely in sync in terms of voter turnout. This seems to have changed since 2016 thanks to an increase in voter turnout in Assam, with the number going above 80% in both 2016 and 2021. Given the fact that both Assam and Kerala have not seen a significant deletion in elector counts under the Special Revision (for Assam) and Special Intensive Revision (for Kerala), it is unlikely that these states will see a large statistical bump in voter turnout in these elections, as was the case in Bihar.

Turnout in state assembly elections

Valid votes cast as a share of electors (%) ■ Assam ■ Kerala



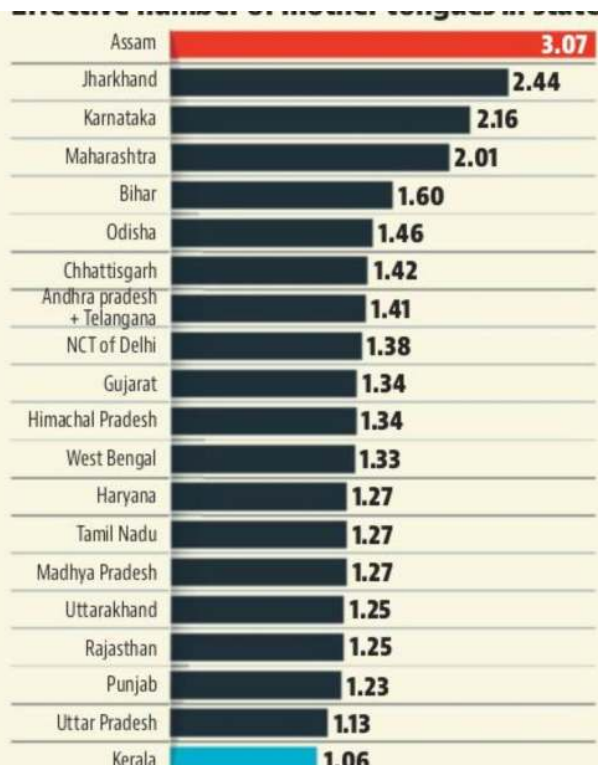
3 Assam and Kerala are at the extreme ends of linguistic diversity in India

This is an under-appreciated fact about the two states. While both Assam and Kerala — the latter more than former — have significant religious diversity, they are very different when it comes to the diversity or lack of it in the mother tongue of their populations. Assam has a large number of people who speak Bengali (29%), in addition to a large Assamese-speaking population (48.4%), and many other indigenous groups which speak another language. Kerala, on the other hand, is a state with the highest homogeneity in terms of mother tongue of its population (97% speak Malayalam). This is best seen in the effective number of mother tongues spoken in major states, as seen in the 2011 Census. It has been calculated by taking the reciprocal of sum of squares of the share of speakers of each mother tongue in the state's population.

Effective number of mother tongues in state



Source: ECI, TCPD-IED



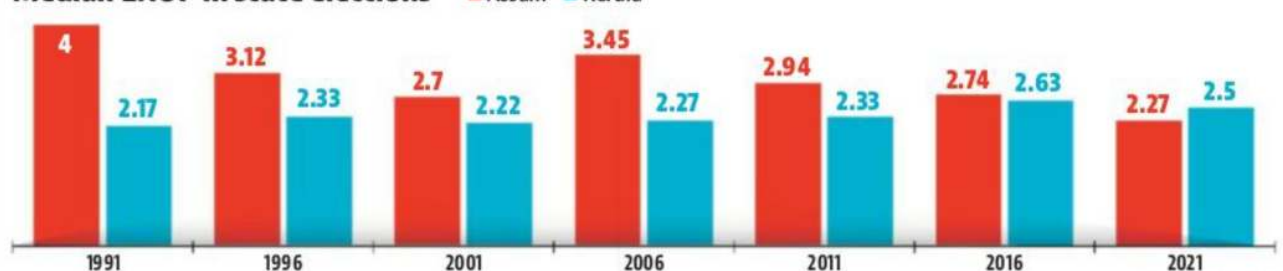
Source: Census 2011

4 Assam's politics has seen growing polarisation in the last decade

While Kerala has been a largely bipolar contest between the LDF and the UDF for a long time, the BJP-Congress binary in Assam is a relatively recent development. This also shows in a recent fall in the median – it is the middle value in an arranged list of numbers – value of Effective Number of Participants (ENOP) in Assam, so much so that it fell below Kerala's in the 2021 elections. ENOP is the reciprocal of the sum

of squares of the vote share of individual candidates in a constituency and a higher value denotes a fragmentation of political support. For example, if a constituency has four candidates and each candidate polls 25% of the votes, the ENOP for the constituency will be four. If two candidates get 50% votes each and the other two candidates get zero votes, the ENOP for the constituency will drop to two.

Median ENOP in state elections



Source: ECI, TCPD-IED

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NEW DELHI/METRO

Thursday, April 09, 2026



Hindustan Times

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Conflicting claims cloud nth-hour ceasefire

Iran closes Strait of Hormuz again in response to Israeli attacks against Hezbollah in Lebanon

Iran accuses US of violating three deal clauses, White House contests Tehran's 10-point plan

Vance to lead US team to Pakistan on Saturday to hold talks on a lasting agreement with Iran

Oil declines to \$95 per barrel, Sensex zooms 4%, tracking a worldwide stock market surge

Associated Press

letters@hindustantimes.com

TEHRAN: Hours after a last-minute ceasefire was announced, the United States demanded Wednesday that Iran immediately reopen the Strait of Hormuz after the Islamic Republic closed the waterway in response to Israeli attacks against the Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon.

Iran, on the other hand, accused the US of violating three clauses of the framework for a deal, saying the ceasefire and negotiations with US are 'unreasonable'.

The statements cast doubt over whether the nascent ceasefire to end 40 days of war would hold.

The US and Iran both claimed victory after reaching the agreement, mediated by Pakistan, and world leaders expressed relief, even as more drones and missiles hit Iran and Gulf Arab countries. Israel also intensified its attacks in Lebanon, hitting several commercial and residential areas in Beirut without warning. At least 112

people were killed and hundreds were wounded in one of the deadliest days in the latest Israel-Hezbollah war.

The fresh violence threatened to scuttle what US Vice President JD Vance called a "fragile" deal.

"Aggression towards Lebanon is aggression towards Iran," Gen. Seyyed Majid Mousavi, aerospace commander of Iran's Revolutionary Guard, wrote on X. He warned that Iranian forces were preparing a "heavy response" without revealing details.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi insisted that an end to the war in Lebanon was part of the ceasefire agreement with the US.

"The world sees the massacres in Lebanon," he said in a post on X. "The ball is in the U.S. court, and the world is watching whether it will act on its commitments."

US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said American and Israeli forces had achieved a "capital V military victory" and that the Iranian military no

FROM DESTRUCTION TO HALT: TRUMP'S U-TURN

The shift in Trump's tenor came as intermediaries, led by Pakistan, worked to head off a further escalation of the conflict. Even China — Iran's biggest trading partner and the US most significant economic competitor — pulled strings to find a path to a truce. —PT

IRAN SHOULD PAY FOR DAMAGES: UAE

The UAE on Wednesday said that Iran should pay for damage caused by its Gulf attacks, adding that the country was seeking clarification on how the ceasefire will ensure Tehran ceases hostilities and reopens the Strait of Hormuz. —AFP

INDIA LAUDS PAUSE, CALLS FOR OPEN STRAIT

India welcomed the two-week ceasefire between Iran and the US and called for the unhindered movement of global commerce through the Strait of Hormuz while expressing hope that the developments will encourage peace efforts in Ukraine. —PT

A fragile peace

Subject to Iran agreeing to the COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz, I agree to suspend the bombing and attack of Iran for a period of two weeks... We have already met and exceeded all Military objectives...

—DONALD TRUMP, US President

If attacks against Iran are halted, our powerful armed forces will cease their defensive operations. For two weeks, safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz will be possible via coordination with Iran's armed forces and with due consideration of technical limitations.

—SEYED ABBAS ARAGHCHI, Iranian foreign minister

Israel supports President Trump's decision to suspend strikes against Iran for two weeks, subject to Iran immediately opening the straits and stopping all attacks on the US, Israel and countries in the region... The two-week ceasefire does not include Lebanon. —Israeli PM's office

THE WAR TOLL	IRAN	LEBANON	IRAQ	ISRAEL	USA	UAE	INDIA	QATAR
	1,900	1,530	117	35	13	12	8	7

IRAN'S PROPOSAL

Iranian state media and the Iranian embassy in India released a list of 10 demands for the ceasefire to take effect

- Non-aggression by either side
- Iran to continue control over the Strait of Hormuz
- Iran's uranium enrichment to be accepted
- All primary sanctions on Iran to be lifted
- All secondary sanctions against entities that do business with Iran to be lifted
- All UNSC resolutions to be terminated
- All IAEA board of governors resolutions to be terminated
- Iran to be paid compensation for war damage
- US combat forces to be withdrawn from the region
- War to be stopped on all fronts, including against Lebanon
- These conditions to be ratified through a binding UNSC resolution

Trump initially said the US received a 10-point proposal from Iran which he called a "workable basis on which to negotiate". However, he and the White House later said the proposal circulating online was different from the one the US had received

GOVT HIKES GAS ALLOCATION FOR FERTILISER PLANTS

Rajeev Jayaswal
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday raised gas allocation for fertiliser plants to 95% of their requirements and permitted supply of commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to additional sectors, including agriculture, pharmaceuticals, paint, ceramic, foundry and glass, officials said — moves that came hours after the US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire.

In a briefing, Sujata Sharma, joint secretary in the petroleum ministry said natural gas supplies to fertiliser plants have been raised again from 90% to 95% of their requirement. This is the second increase in a week. The government on Monday raised gas allocation for the fertiliser sector from about 70% to 90%. Natural gas is both fuel and feedstock for fertiliser plants. —PT

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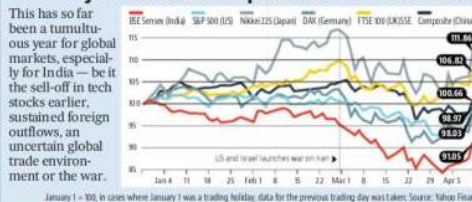
By Sreedev Krishnakumar
ALL DATA AS OF WEDNESDAY, 10PM



How global equity markets reacted to the ceasefire announcement

Global markets mounted a relief rally after the US-Israel-Iran ceasefire was announced early Wednesday morning (Indian time). Indian benchmark indices NIFTY 50 and BSE Sensex closed with around 4% gains from the previous trading session. Asian and European markets also posted strong gains during the day as the ceasefire eased fears of a wider energy shock. US S&P 500 was trading up 2.4% during early session.

How major markets have performed in 2026 so far



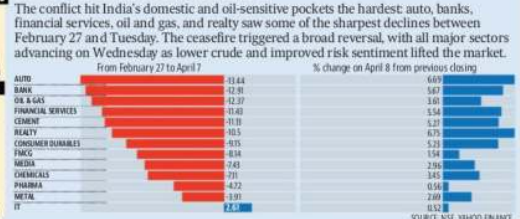
Rupee holds on to recent gains



Brent crude price this year



How sectoral indices fared



Hormuz stays blocked as hundreds of ships seek exit

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW YORK: The Strait of Hormuz remained largely blocked on Wednesday, as shipowners try to understand if they can safely transit the vital waterway following a fragile ceasefire between the US and Iran that was announced overnight.

Just three ships were observed leaving the region on Wednesday, according to ship-tracking data compiled by Bloomberg. Some had links to Iran, and the country's media subsequently reported that passage for tankers would remain blocked after attacks on Lebanon. In normal times about 135 ships cross daily, and over 800 freighters are stuck inside the gulf, mostly waiting to leave.

While shipowners and insurer groups lined up to welcome the ceasefire, they also warned that more details will be needed to determine if safe transit is possible. Iran has said a precondition of the ceasefire is that its armed forces should coordinate navigation through what is the world's most important oil channel. Tehran has also been charging a toll of as much as \$2 million a transit for some carriers.

"Time will tell whether it is a pause or a peace but, in the meantime, it is highly unlikely that trade into the Gulf will simply resume," said Neil Roberts, head of marine and aviation at the Lloyd's Market Association. "Several in Asia, the Middle East (West Asia) and Europe said they were calling insurers and security advisors, and had put vessels on standby to transit Hormuz."

How soon flows return to normal will dictate the path ahead for global commodity prices. The waterway, which handles a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas, has been all but closed since US and Israeli strikes at the end of February prompted Iran to tighten its control, triggering an unprecedented oil-supply crunch.

Throughout the conflict, shipowners have cited the safety of their crews as a reason not to transit. Iran says it has agreed to two weeks of safe passage in coordination with its armed forces and within "technical limitations." By contrast, US President Donald Trump announced a "COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and

The priority now is to ensure an evacuation that guarantees the safety of navigation

ARSENIO DOMINGUEZ, IMO's Secretary-General

said it was monitoring the situation. Germany's Hapag-Lloyd AG said it will continue to avoid Hormuz for now but added that the ceasefire was positive. Binco, a shipping trade group whose members control almost two-thirds of the world's seaborne freight capacity, also struck a cautious tone, adding that it was still awaiting details of safe navigation plans from the US and Iran. "Leaving the Persian Gulf without prior coordination with the US and Iran would entail heightened risk and would not be advisable," said Jakob Larsen, the group's chief safety and security officer.

Crew safety

Those views mirrored private comments from owners with ships in the region. "Several in Asia, the Middle East (West Asia) and Europe said they were calling insurers and security advisors, and had put vessels on standby to transit Hormuz."

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SAFETY OPENING." He said in a separate social media post the US would be "helping with the traffic buildup" and "hanging around" to ensure smooth flows, options unlikely to appeal to Tehran.

Ships that transport energy make up a large part of the fleet that's stuck inside the gulf, data from intelligence firm Kpler show. There are currently 426 tankers hauling crude oil and clean fuels, plus 34 liquefied petroleum gas carriers and 19 LNG vessels. The remainder are carrying dry commodities, like agricultural or metal products.

Traders and shipowners will now be closely monitoring whether ships start making their way to transit the strait in either direction, and how they fare. As of Wednesday morning, more than 1,000 vessels were waiting on both sides, in clusters around Dubai and Khor Fakkan, in the Gulf of Oman.

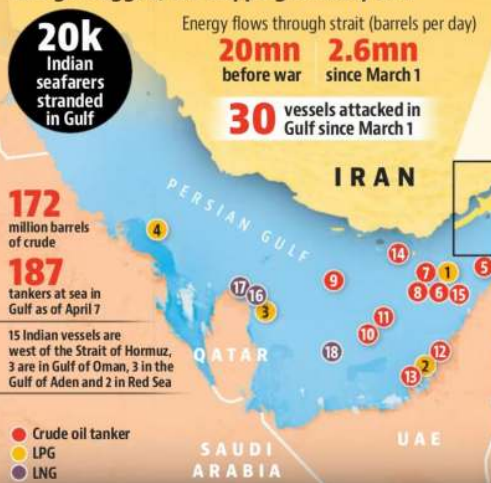
Two bulk commodity carriers, at least one of which called at Iran, crossed Hormuz on Wednesday. One of the vessels took a route between Iran's Larak and Qeshm islands. Another ship, a US-sanctioned oil tanker called Tour 2 that's flagged to Iran, may also have crossed based on Kpler data. "It's good to see that the market is reacting the way it is, but this is day one of a tentative ceasefire," Michael Pregel, former US Intelligence advisor, told Bloomberg Television. Movement of LNG ships will also be particularly closely monitored, as no loaded carrier has made it through the strait since the war began and one recent attempted transit by two tankers ended in a last-minute U-turn.

According to an International Maritime Organization tally at the end of March, some 20,000 civilian seafarers are stuck on board trapped ships and their utility and support vessels.

The IMO said that it welcomed the agreement. "The priority now is to ensure an evacuation that guarantees the safety of navigation," IMO's Secretary-General Arsenio Dominguez said.

India seeks to bring vessels home

The petroleum ministry has identified 18 vessels for evacuation on priority from the Persian Gulf. Five are India-flagged vessels and the rest are foreign-flagged, the shipping ministry said



Other than these, 13 ships carrying urea, sulphur and diammonium phosphate identified for evacuation by fertiliser ministry. Nine others also identified for evacuation by shipping, defence and external affairs ministries

Vessels carrying oil and gas

Vessels carrying oil and gas		Other India-flagged vessels to be evacuated	
1 JAG VIKRAM India-flagged 20,000 mt	5 MT DESH VIBHOR India-flagged 288,893 mt	14 OMEGA TRADER Panama-flagged 288,893 mt	15 LEGIO X EQUESTRI S Marshall Islands-flagged
2 SARV SHAKTI India-flagged 45,221 mt	6 MT DESH VAIBHAV India-flagged 286,572,452 mt	16 LNCG DISHA Malta-flagged 62,370 mt	17 AL GHASHAMIA Marshall Islands-flagged 93,683 mt
3 SYMI Marshall Islands-flagged 22,000 mt	7 SANMAR HERALD India-flagged 275,000 mt	18 MUBARAZ Liberia-flagged 59,208 mt	
4 GASCHIE M ERICA Portugal-flagged 20,000 mt	8 MT DESH GARIMA India-flagged 275,000 mt		
	9 PLATA CARRIER Liberia-flagged 275,000 mt		
	10 NISSOS KEROS Marshall Islands-flagged 270,000 mt		
	11 SINGAPORE LOYALTY Marshall Islands-flagged 2,600,000 mt		
	12 MINERVA DOXA Greece-flagged 140,000 mt		
	13 MONTE URBASA Portugal-flagged 140,295 mt		

(*metric tonnes)

Other India-flagged vessels to be evacuated

- MV JAG ARNAV
- CMA CGM DIAMOND
- SSL KAVIRI
- BW LOYALTY
- CMA CGM MANAUS
- MT DESH SURAKSHA
- API PRITI 2
- SANMAR SUPARNA

Vessels that reached India

● LPGC SHIVAJI: March 16

● LPGC NANDA DEVI: March 17

● JAG VASANT: March 28

● BW TYR: March 31

● BW ELM: April 1

● PINE GAS: April 2

2 foreign-flagged vessels also brought crude to India: Smyrni and Shenlong

The journey from ceasefire to peace in West Asia

Jawed Ashraf

After 40 days of accelerating escalation and expansion of the war in West Asia — with many red lines crossed — the two-week ceasefire announced on Wednesday allows breathing space and hope. US President Donald Trump's post-threatening civilisational destruction and Iran's response involving regional annihilation threatened a nuclear-winter-like situation for West Asia and grave economic crisis for the world.

Iran rejected the 15-point US

bat forces from the region; retention of enrichment rights; termination of UNSC and IAEA resolutions along with all sanctions; payment of compensation to Iran; and, above all, control of the Strait of Hormuz, with fees for transit rights. There is no offer on limiting military and missile capabilities.

The negotiated package will be different. But wherever the framework settles finally, if it does at all, it will leave Iran in a better position than it was in the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) — popularly known as the Iran nuclear deal — that Trump trashed in 2018, and what Iran was willing to accept before the US and Israel

gressed, it gained strategic momentum and advantage; its resistance resonated across the world. But, among the shrewdest strategic actors, it would also have calculated the point of inflection in the trajectory and the cost of more lethal attacks from an unrestrained Trump. The US acted with shifting objectives and incoherent fury in the face of strategic failures and unanticipated Iranian capabilities and strategy. Trump, too, would have tallied the cost and casualties of a prolonged war and domestic political and economic consequences, if not increasing international alienation. Israel's shield of impermeability was repeatedly breached.

IF PEACE FOLLOWS, WASIA'S POWER BALANCE WILL CHANGE FOREVER. IN THE REGION, IRAN WILL MATTER MORE; INFLUENCE OF U.S. WILL SHRINK

longer conflict could imperil them.

Wars start through the escalation of miscalculations and misjudgments. Negotiations break down for the same reason. Disagreements over details unravel broader understandings. There is still a wide gap in positions, and

Israel has rejected the inclusion of Lebanon in the ceasefire framework, and launched a huge wave of strikes. There is too much at stake for Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to stop, unless the US restrains him.

If peace and settlement follow, West Asia's power balance will change forever. Within the region and in Eurasia, Iran will matter more. The US's influence will shrink, even if it does not turn out to be like Britain's Suez moment of 1956. China and Russia will gain in influence. The US might even work with Iran to retain presence and influence. Global fragmentation and diversification on trade, finance, payments and energy will grow.

tion, the Cold War, regional disputes, and ideological differences. The region has unmatched diversity of size, population, religion, history, languages and prosperity. Yet, today, 11 countries have come together in a shared journey of peace and prosperity in the form of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, managing their differences and balancing external powers.

As I have argued earlier, the long and unsettled arc of West Asia's history has more complexity and churn than the simple equations that appear through the lens of the present. The Arab-Israeli conflict is not inevitable. For centuries, the Turko-Iranian and

but also from concerns about the stability of the monarchies — these lock them in a reciprocal security and economic pact with the US, which helped them avert the fate of many "nationalist" rulers in West Asia and North Africa during the Arab Spring. And, if Israel's vision of territorial expansion and regional hegemony holds, the Gulf States cannot remain sanguine about the future. Further, the damaged foundations of their ambitions can be repaired only with assurance of regional peace. Iran's peaceful regional reintegration will be good for all. Iran must be recognised for its power and stature. But, Iran, too, must assure neighbours that it harbours no

For India, the role of media-

tors and messengers should be less important than lasting peace and stability in the region. And, as argued earlier, India needs to not only assess and prepare for alternative scenarios in West Asia with the revival of its traditional equities, but also work with others for the restoration of norms over power in the world.

Jawed Ashraf, a former ambassador, currently chairs IIPO. The views expressed are personal.



SIKSHA 'O' ANUSANDHAN

SAAT-2026



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PCI
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Civil Engineering

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Mechanical Engineering

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Electronics and Communication

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Structural Engineering

Electric Vehicle Technology

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BBA

MBA

Integrated MBA

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MBA (Artificial Intelligence and Data Science)

HOTEL MANAGEMENT PROGRAMMES

[REMOTE ACCESS CRIME]

32 'paper solvers', 'kingpin' of online test cheating racket held in Dwarka

Hemanti Bhandari

newdelhi@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police busted an organised cheating racket, arresting its kingpin and detaining 32 students, who allegedly cracked online competitive entrance examinations for management institutions using remote-access software, officers aware of the matter said on Wednesday.

The students, called "paper solvers" by the kingpin and an associate, were allegedly duped and hired on the pretext of answering academic questions on e-learning platforms by promising them a payment of ₹500-₹1,000 per question, officers said.

The police acted on a tip-off and made the bust at a building

named "Happy Homes" in Dwarka. "Upon reaching the spot, several youths were found acting suspiciously. During sustained questioning, the accused disclosed details of the racket," deputy commissioner of police (Dwarka) Kushal Pal Singh.

Investigators said the kingpin used to arrange candidates to appear in the entrance examinations of a reputed management institute in Mumbai. The exams were scheduled to be conducted at an IT lab in Jaipur, Rajasthan. "He revealed that he accessed computer systems at the exam centre using remote access software such as AnyDesk and Ammy Admin, allowing external 'solvers' to attempt the paper," the officer said.

Police said an associate of the kingpin played a key role in

recruiting college students. The 32 students on the Dwarka premises had allegedly been similarly called to solve questions and were bound down by the police. They were found to be from various parts of the country and are enrolled in institutions such as Delhi University, Jamia Millia Islamia, Delhi Technological University (DTU), and IIT Roorkee, among others.

"Further probe into who all are involved at the centre in Jaipur is underway," the DCP said. A case was registered under sections 318(4) (cheating), 61(2) (criminal conspiracy) and 62 (attempting to commit crime) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) at Dwarka Sector 23 police station.

Police said efforts are on to trace the absconding associate.

HC REJECTS PLEA ALLEGING ILLEGAL DETENTION IN PIT DEATH CASE

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Wednesday dismissed a plea alleging illegal detention moved by Rajesh Prajapati, the subcontractor accused in the death of 25-year-old Kamal Dhiyani, who fell into an unguarded pit in Janakpuri, after observing that the claim was devoid of any merit.

Judicial magistrate first class Harjot Singh Aulga of Dwarka courts said the allegation was not supported by any cogent material or prima facie evidence on behalf of the accused.

The court said, "On the contrary, the record, particularly the CDR, suggests otherwise. The court is not expected to embark upon a fishing and roving enquiry in the absence of foundational material, especially when the allegations do not find support from the record".

ARNABHIT SUR

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Computer Science and Engineering
Computer Science and Information Technology

B.TECH PROGRAMMES IN EMERGING COMPUTING

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Computer Science and Engineering (Cyber Security)

Computer Science and Engineering (Data Science)

Computer Science and Engineering (Internet of Things)

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BBA LL.B (H) - Integrated

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BHMT (Bachelor of Hotel Management & Catering Technology)

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undersigned at following phone numbers.

Website : <http://cbi.nic.in>
e-mail : cic@cbi.gov.in
Fax : 011-24368639
Ph. : 011-24368638, 24368641
DP/4554/SE/2026 Ph. : 011-29894753, 8750870933

SHO
P.S., Badarpur,
New Delhi
DP/4580/NE/2026

missing boy but no clue has come to light so far. If anyone have any information about this missing boy please inform to the following.

SHO,
Police Station Harsh Vihar,
North East Distt., Delhi-110093
Ph.: 8527367474
DP/4580/NE/2026

SEARCH FOR MISSING



General public is hereby informed that a male namely Harman Singh, S/o: Harpreet Singh, R/o: BE-150, 2nd Floor, Gali No-5, Hari Nagar, New Delhi has been missing since 01.04.2026 at 9:00 PM from his home. In this regard DD No. 128A, Dated 02.04.2026, has been registered at P.S. Hari Nagar, New Delhi. The description of missing male is as under:

Name: Harman Singh, Age: 20 Years, Height: 5'10", Complexion: Fair, Face: Oval, Build: Medium, ID Mark: Black Colour Birth Mark over Left Eye & Wearing: Blue Colour T-Shirt & Black Colour Lower and Black Colour Shoes in his feet.

If anyone have any information about this missing male please inform P.S. Hari Nagar, New Delhi.

Web: <http://cbi.nic.in>, Email: cic@cbi.gov.in
Ph.: 011-24368638/24368641, Fax: 011-24368639 SHO
Police Station Hari Nagar, New Delhi
DP/4540/WD/2026 Ph: 8750871126, 8618197003

APPEAL FOR IDENTIFICATION



General public is hereby informed that this person (depicted in the photo) Name: Unknown S/o: Unknown R/o: Unknown Age: 20-25 years, Sex: Male, Height: 5 feet 6 inch, Face: Long, Complexion: Wheatish, Build: Medium, Wearing: Blue Colour Jeans, Multi Colour Check Shirt & Light Green Shirt, was found

during train accident at Pole No. 3/11 G near G2B to NDLS, UP Railway Lines, Ganesh Nagar, Shakarpur, Delhi, dated 07.04.2026 under area of P.S. Anand Vihar Railway Station, Delhi

In this regard a DD No.37A dated 07.04.2026, has been lodged at P.S. Anand Vihar Railway Station, Delhi Dead Body has been preserved in GTB Hospital Mortuary, Delhi for 72 Hours. If any person having any information or clue about this person may kindly inform to the following.

SHO
P.S. - Anand Vihar Railway Station, Delhi
Ph.: +91-9999151767, 8750871314
DP/4584/Rly/2026

APPEAL FOR IDENTIFICATION



General public is hereby informed that a unidentified dead body of a male namely Unknown, S/o: Unknown, R/o: Unknown found dead on 22.03.2026 at Gate No. 1, Near Barbar Shop, Old Delhi Railway Station, Delhi. In this regard DD No. 02 A, dated 22.03.2026 has been lodged at Police Station Old Delhi

Railway Station, Delhi. Identification of unidentified male is as under:

Name: Unknown, Age: About 55 Years, Height: 5'8", Complexion: Unknown, Wearing: Unknown.

If anyone have any information or clue about this male may kindly be inform undersigned.

SHO
P.S. Old Delhi Railway Station, Delhi
DP/4582/Rly/2026 Ph.: 8800718580

APPEAL FOR IDENTIFICATION



General public is hereby informed that a male namely Unknown, S/o: Unknown, R/o: Unknown was found dead on 01.04.2026 at 09:15 AM From Railway Line KM Pol No. 1527/21, UP/Down Line, Near Okhla Railway Station, Delhi. In this regard GD No. 36A, Dated: 01.04.2026 has been lodged at Police Station New Friends Colony, Delhi. Physical

Description of unidentified male dead body is as under: Name: Unknown, Age: About 45 Years, Height: 5'1", Complexion: Wheatish, ID Mark: Black Mole on Head, Wearing: Blue Colour Track Pant and White Color Banyan.

If anyone have any information or clue about this male deceased may kindly be inform undersigned.

SHO
Police Station New Friends Colony, Delhi
DP/4556/SE/2026 Ph.: 011-26834563, 8750870924

ORDER

The Election Commission of India vide their communication dated 16.03.2026 has announced General Elections for Legislative Assemblies of Assam, Kerala and Puducherry to be held on 09.04.2026 (Thursday) to be declared as **"PAID HOLIDAY"** under section 135(B) of the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

Accordingly, all Employers of Industrial Establishments/ Factories/ Shops /Commercial Establishments/ Institutions operating in the National Capital Territory of Delhi shall grant a **"PAID HOLIDAY"** to their employees who are electors of General Legislative Assemblies Elections, 2026 of Kerala, Assam and Puducherry to enable them to cast their vote on the day of polling i.e. 09.04.2026 (Thursday), in case the scheduled day is a working day for the concerned Employees/Electors.

Non-compliance of the above directions shall attract action as per the relevant provisions of law.

(U.K. Sinha)

Additional Labour Commissioner

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0010/26-27

WhatsApp is helping India's small businesses do big things.

Nomad Eco Retreat welcomed
40% more bookings after using
WhatsApp business tools.



Learn how WhatsApp can support your small business at whatsapp.com/impact



06

Hindustan Times

MY DELHI

NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

35-yr-old woman killed, body stuffed in bed box

Karn Pratap Singh

karn.singh@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old woman was murdered and her body stuffed inside a double bed box allegedly by her 22-year-old "boyfriend" at a paying guest (PG) accommodation in outer Delhi's Mangolpuri on Tuesday afternoon, police said on Wednesday. Police said the prime accused, single name, was arrested on Wednesday along with his 50-year-old uncle and the uncle's 52-year-old friend for allegedly assisting in the crime.

Senior officers said the 22-year-old confessed that he killed the woman in a fit of rage after she refused to be physically intimate with the 52-year-old and his uncle.

"He allegedly pinned the woman to the floor with his hands and legs, causing injuries to her forehead, smothered her with a blanket, and then strangled her. He stuffed the body into a bed box at the PG accommodation owned by his friend. His uncle and the uncle's friend remained on guard outside the room, and later helped him flee,"



The body bore strangulation marks and forehead injuries. The woman, from Mangolpuri, worked as a help.

JATIN NARWAL, joint commissioner of police (western)

said a senior police officer investigating the case.

Deputy commissioner of police (outer) Vikram Singh said the Mangolpuri police station received a call around 7pm Tuesday reporting that a woman's body had been found inside a bed box in a room of building in Pattihar Market.

A police team reached the spot and learnt that a PG facility was being run on the floor by a man who lived in one of the rooms. He told police that he 22-year-old had asked for access to his room for a few hours to meet a woman.

When the PG owner returned around 7pm, he found the room unlocked and the accused missing. On entering, he noticed a leg protruding from the bed box. He opened it and found the woman's body, after which he alerted police, officers said. "The body bore strangulation marks and injuries on the forehead. It was sent for a post-mortem examination. The woman, a Mangolpuri resident, worked as a domestic help. She was married and had three children," said joint commissioner of police (western) Jatin Narwal. Police said a case under sections 103 (murder) and 238 (causing disappearance of evidence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita was registered.

Investigations revealed that the woman was in a relationship with the prime accused, who ran a chicken shop near her residence. On Tuesday around 4.30pm, the two went to the room. The other two also reached there.

The 22-year-old fought with her, pinned her down, smothered and strangled her. He then hid the body in the bed box and fled with the other two," said an officer involved in the probe.

NGT SAYS TANKERS CARRYING TREATED WATER MUST ALSO HAVE TRACKERS

Aaditya Khatwani

htreporters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The National Green Tribunal (NGT) said on Wednesday that its earlier directive, ordering that only GPS-fitted tankers be used for commercial water supply, also applied to tankers carrying treated water from sewage treatment plants (STPs).

The NGT's principal bench, comprising judicial member Arun Kumar Tyagi and expert member Afroz Ahmad, issued the clarification after two applicants had contended that NGT's earlier directions should not apply to tankers transporting treated water, and sought protection from coercive action.

The initial directive was issued on March 28, 2025. Then, the tribunal stated only GPS-fitted tankers can be used for commercial water supply and also mandated strict action, including registration of FIRs.

On Wednesday, the tribunal highlighted gaps in DJB monitoring mechanism and said that the agency will have to issue gate passes and transit passes for each driver and maintain proper records.

Delhiwale

EXPERIENCE YOUR CITY LIKE NEVER BEFORE.



Mayank Austen Soofi



63-YEAR-OLD HIT BY MOTORBIKE NEAR MODI MILL

CM takes stock of sanitation, waste management issues

40 years of presence

Proust questionnaire with a fellow citizen

Your idea of happiness. I experienced my greatest happiness two years

FLYOVER, DIES

NEW DELHI: A 63-year-old man was killed after a motorcycle hit him near Modi Mill flyover on Monday night, police said on Wednesday, adding that the accused was also injured in the incident.

A police officer familiar with the matter said the deceased was identified as Fauja Singh, 63, a resident of Nehru Camp. The accused is a resident of Jaitpuri and works as a manager at a private firm.

Police said that their control room received a call around 8pm regarding the accident, after which police reached the spot and found the bike in an accidental condition and the two injured on the road. "The two were rushed to a city hospital, where Singh succumbed to his injuries a few hours later," the officer said.

HT Correspondent

htreporters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Chief minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday chaired a meeting with officials of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to take stock of the sanitation and waste management situation in the Capital, issuing a series of directives from redevelopment of public toilets and formulating strong mechanisms to support sustainable waste disposal practices, officials aware of the developments said.

Among the key issues discussed was the establishment and capacity augmentation of state-of-the-art waste-to-energy plants in Ghazipur, Narela, Okhla and Tehkhand, intended to modernise waste processing and reduce landfill burden.

PUBLIC TOILET REDEVELOPMENT, OPERATION OF WTE PLANTS, AND COORDINATION AMONG AGENCIES WERE DISCUSSED, OFFICIALS SAID

"The plants have already been proposed and approved by the government and the department is now preparing detailed reports before work can be initiated in some cases, while in others, the plans are also ready," said a senior official, requesting anonymity.

Officials were instructed to undertake the redevelopment of nearly 1,000 public toilets and urinal blocks operated by

the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), in a bid to improve public hygiene facilities. In addition, three new biogas plants are planned at Goyla Dairy, Ghogha and Ghazipur to support sustainable waste disposal and these will be made operational soon, the CM informed, officials who attended the meeting said.

Officials were also asked to ensure coordination between the MCD and the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to ensure systematic cleaning of marketplaces.

Special campaigns will be launched to remove garbage along railway tracks more effectively, while road construction and repair works will be assigned to experienced agencies to ensure quality and accountability, officials said.

PRIVATE CAPITAL

One of the living landmarks of central Delhi's Kasturba Gandhi Road is Ram-esh Kumar Mohy. He has been the area's familiar face for many years. In fact, his shoe-repairing pavement stall is marking its 40th anniversary this year. This afternoon, he graciously agrees to become a part of our Proust Questionnaire series, in which citizens are nudged to make "Parisian parlour confessions", all to explore our distinct experiences. He takes only a single break in between to nudge a street dog to a bowl of milk that was placed for the dog in a corner of the pavement.

The principal aspect of your personality.
My simple way of life.

What is your present state of mind?

I am thinking about my business. It is not as thriving as it used to be. Seven to eight office complexes in the vicinity have either shut down or moved away in recent months, which has directly led to a loss of my customers.

Your main fault.

I drink whiskey.

Your favourite occupation.

Repairing old shoes.

ago, when after six grandsons, I was blessed with a granddaughter.

Your favourite names.

Lakshita, the name of my granddaughter.

What would be your greatest misfortune?

It has already happened, with the death of my second son.

If not yourself, who would you be?

I would have had an office job, as a chaprasi in a bank. Years ago, I had almost secured that job, but things changed at the last moment.

Where would you like to live?

I already live there, in Welcome Colony. It is my own house: two rooms downstairs and two upstairs, with steady water and power supply. And the mandir of Guru Ravidas Ji Maharaj is very close to our house.

Your hero in real life.

My elder brother, the late Shri Gore Lal. My parents were often very ill during my childhood, and it was my brother who supported me in every way a parent would have.

Faults for which you have the most tolerance.

When people make vulgar jokes.

Your motto in life

Never wishing ill of others.



READ: For more stories by Mayank Austen Soofi, scan the QR code

HT Homage



With profound grief and deep sorrow, we wish to inform the sad demise of

Shri Mukul Gupta

(Senior Advocate & Former ASG)

s/o Late Smt. Prakash & Shri Wazir Singh Gupta on Tuesday, 7th April 2026.

Prayer Meeting will be held on Friday, 10th April 2026 from 4.30pm to 5.30pm at Chinmaya Mission, Lodhi Road.

Deeply mourned by:

Sangeeta Gupta (Wife)

Son & Daughter-in-law
Tushar & Mansi Gupta

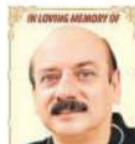
Daughters & Sons-in-law
Dr. Aastha - Ankur Gupta
Paridhi - Udit Gupta

Sisters & Brothers-in-law
Justice Mukta Gupta (Retd.)
Achla - Brijesh Garg

Meenakshi - Nishit Goei

Grandchildren:

Reyana, Mahira, Mamik and Sharanya



DR. PREM GROVER

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6th April 2026 in Delhi.

Rasam Kriya, Shradhanjali, and Rasam Paddi

Thursday, 09 April 2026

07:30 PM - 2:30 PM

Venue:

Shri Radha Gauri Mandir,

Rangpuri, New Delhi

A warm and generous heart,

remembered for his unshakable

fath and a life devoted to

humanity.

Family remembered by:

Meena Grover

Siddhanti & Chaitan Grover

Shubham & Shweta Grover

Abhinav & Mohini

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GOOLLY QUIZ

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Q. In Indian T20 league, which player hit 5
sixes in the final 5 balls to win the match?

A. Andre Russell

B. Hardik Pandya

C. Rahul Tewatia

D. Rinku Singh



Scan to play



7th Apr 8 Winners

1. Mamta Vohra (Ghaziabad) 2. Pradip Babanrao Nimbekar

3. Omkar (Lucknow)

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NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

Hindustan Times

MY DELHI

07



DELHI: STANDING COMMITTEE GIVES NOD TO RENAME MCD ZONES

NEW DELHI: The standing committee on Wednesday granted anticipatory approval to change the names of the MCD administrative zones to align them with the Delhi government's newly created revenue districts, officials said.

The committee's chairperson Satya Sharma said that the change is being carried out in accordance with the provisions of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957.

She further added, "The names of the MCD zones are being aligned to ensure better coordination among departments," she said.

[WEST DELHI]

Man held for sexually assaulting 11-yr-old girl

Karn Pratap Singh

karn.singh@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A 25-year-old man was arrested for allegedly sexually assaulting an 11-year-old girl outside her residence in Nihar Vihar on Saturday, police said on Wednesday.

Police said the man, who was working as a vegetable vendor, was arrested on Tuesday from the Nihar Vihar area after investigators scanned over 100 CCTV cameras in the neighbourhood. Deputy commissioner of police (DCP) (outer) Vikram Singh said that on Saturday, the Nihar Vihar police station

sexually assaulted on Friday by an unknown person while she was outside their residence.

The accused fled the spot soon after, police said.

"The counselling of the girl was conducted and her statement was recorded in the presence of her parents. Based on her statement, a case was registered under Section 74 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and investigation was taken up by the Nihar Vihar police personnel," said DCP Singh.

DCP Singh said during the

DELHI CM ORDERS ACTION ON GST OFFICIALS FOUND ABSENT ON DUTY

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Chief minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday conducted a surprise inspection at the state GST office in ITO, where several officials including senior officers were found absent from duty.

Gupta directed that immediate show-cause notices be issued to all those who were missing from their duties. She reiterated that biometric attendance is mandatory for all, and directed departments to ensure strict compliance. Officials have also been asked to submit biometric attendance records for

The maximum temp on Wednesday was 28.2°C, the lowest maximum since April 23, 2016, when it was recorded at 27.2°C. **ANURAG KUMAR/HINDUSTAN TIMES**

Thanks to rains, Delhi sees its coldest April day in a decade

Aaditya Khatwani

aaditya.khatwani@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Scattered showers, particularly in the first half of Wednesday, led to Delhi experiencing its coolest April day in a decade, according to official data from the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The maximum temperature on Wednesday was recorded at 28.2 degrees Celsius (°C), the lowest maximum temperature since April 23, 2016, when it was recorded at 27.2°C. This follows Tuesday's maximum of 28.8°C - the coldest April day in three years.

According to IMD, the normal maximum temperature during April 6-10 is 35.1°C, making Wednesday's temperature nearly 7°C below normal. The minimum temperature was also noticeably below normal at 16.8°C, against the normal of 20°C.

Experts attributed the unusually low temperatures to western disturbances. "Western disturbances combined with an induced cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan caused widespread rain over many places along the northern plains, with some areas experiencing hailstorms too. The west-

Sunny, with a shiver



ern disturbances had been travelling at a lower altitude since March 15, which was the reason for unusually low temperatures in April.

However, now the weather system is moving eastward, and we will see a gradual increase in temperature, said Mahesh Palawat, vice-president of SkyMet Weather. IMD's seven-day fore-

cast predicts mainly clear skies throughout the coming week, with a daily increase of 1-2°C expected in the maximum temperature, reaching between 36°C and 38°C by April 14.

The minimum temperature is expected to fall between 14°C and 16°C on Thursday before following a similar rise. Saldarjung, Delhi's base station for weather,

received 6.4mm of rain in 24 hours till 8:30am. Wednesday, while Palam logged 4.4mm till 8:30am and another 1.2mm till 8:30pm, Lodhi Road logged 5.6mm till 8:30am and trace rainfall till 5:30pm. The highest wind speed recorded was 56 km/h at Palam around 1:30pm. The rainfall also improved the city's Air Quality Index, with the 24-hour average recorded in the satisfactory category at 93 at 4:00 p.m. by the Central Pollution Control Board. This marked the first time in 19 days that the city's AQI was recorded in the satisfactory category. March 20 was the last time the city's 24-hour average AQI was in the satisfactory category, also at 93, marking the first satisfactory day since October 9, 2025, when it had logged an AQI of 99.

The Centre's early warning system (EWS) stated that the AQI is likely to rise to the moderate category and is "likely to be in the moderate to poor category" for the next six days.

According to CPCB classification, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered "good," 51 to 100 "satisfactory," 101 to 200 "moderate," 201 to 300 "poor," 301 to 400 "very poor," and 401 to 500 "severe."

the house of councillors for the final approval, said Sharma. **HTC**

received a call from a person who alleged that his niece was

interrogation after the arrest, the man confessed to the crime.

the past one month, so that responsibility can be fixed.



CM Gupta and LG Sandhu inspect the Yamuna ghats. **VIPIN KUMAR/HT**

LG, CM inspect Yamuna ghats, restoration works

Snehl Sinha

snehl.sinha@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Lieutenant governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and chief minister Rekhla Gupta, inspected the Vasudev Ghat and Yamuna Bazar Ghat on Tuesday, reviewing sanitation, infrastructure and ongoing works linked to Yamuna rejuvenation.

According to officials, the visit aimed at assessing preparedness ahead of the summer and monsoon seasons, while reviewing the progress of Yamuna's restoration. During the inspection, officials noted that Vasudev Ghat developed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) was an

eco-friendly public space, while Yamuna Bazar Ghat needed further development.

The LG directed agencies to timely rejuvenate the entire floodplain stretch from Palla to Kalindi Kunj. He called for coordinated efforts from multiple agencies. "Yamuna rejuvenation and curbing air pollution, water shortage and flooding are non-negotiable priorities," Sandhu said. The chief minister said the Delhi government has prioritised Yamuna cleaning as part of its environmental agenda.

"Making Yamuna clean is not just a project but a firm commitment of the government," Gupta said.

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7.	Manager	04	Level-8 [Rs. 9300-34800+4800 (GPI)]
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10.	Section Officer (Accounts)	10	Level-8 [Rs. 9300-34800+4800 (GPI)]

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ECI-TMC meeting ends with bitter exchanges

Harsh Yadav
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A meeting between a four-member Trinamool Congress (TMC) delegation with chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi on Wednesday sparked a charged confrontation with an unprecedented attack by the poll panel and a sharp response by the political party.

The delegation comprised Rajya Sabha MPs Derek O'Brien, Sagarkha Ghose, Menaka Guruswamy, and party spokesperson Saket Gokhale, and they presented a memorandum demanding neutrality from officials involved in the electoral process.

The meeting turned heated almost immediately. Minutes after the delegation left, ECI posted on its official X handle: "ECI's Straight-talk to Trinamool Congress. This time, the Elections in West Bengal would surely be Fear-free, Intimidation-free, Inducement-free and without any Faid, Boon, Jamming and Source Jamming." The post was made in both English and Hindi.

The TMC hit back sharply.



Gyanesh Kumar and Derek O'Brien

"Our straight-talk to @ECISVEEP. This time, the Elections must be Free from Delhi's control. Free from political bias. Free from selective targeting. And free from double standards," the party posted on X.

O'Brien's said the meeting lasted minutes. "The chief election commissioner told us within seven minutes of the meeting to get lost," the meeting started at 10:02 AM and ended at 10:07 AM. What I saw today is a shame. I challenge the Election Commissioner to release the video or audio of what happened today," he said.

Senior ECI officials, however, said Kumar requested O'Brien to maintain the decorum of the commission room, stating that



shouting and indecent behaviour were not appropriate. Officials said O'Brien raised his voice at ECI and even asked the CEC not to speak.

The meeting came a day after ECI deleted nearly nine million names as part of the special intensive revision (SIR) in Bengal. Of the six million cases placed under a controversial 'logical discrepancy' category, around 2.7 million were found ineligible.

Ghose questioned how genuine voters could be restored. "If they have been deleted and have to appeal to a tribunal with freezing of electoral rolls for the first phase, how will a genuine voter be included in the list?"

West Bengal Assembly members will be held in two phases on April 23 and April 29, with counting scheduled for May 4.

MAMATA'S INCOME GREW NEARLY 50% IN LAST FIVE YEARS, SHOWS AFFIDAVIT

Joydeep Thakur
joydeep.thakur@htlive.com

KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee's declared income has increased by nearly 50% over the last five years, according to her election affidavit filed on Wednesday along with her nomination to the Bhabanipur assembly constituency in south Kolkata.

The Trinamool Congress (TMC) chief declared an annual income of ₹23,21,570 for 2024-25, up from ₹15,47,845 in 2020-21. Her income, she has consistently maintained, comes from bank interest and royalties from her books.

"She is a seven-term MP and a three-term chief minister but she never drew any salary. Her only sources of income are bank interests and royalty from her books," a TMC leader said, requesting anonymity.

Banerjee, known for her literary pursuits, has authored 153 books across Bengali, English, Hindi and Urdu.

Her movable assets, including jewellery, have seen a marginal rise from ₹15,37,509 five years ago to ₹16,72,352 now. She has declared no immovable assets.

A law graduate from University of Calcutta, Banerjee recently became the first sitting chief minister to argue her own case before the Supreme Court, challenging voter list deletions after special intensive revision (SIR) in the state.

Bhabanipur is set for a high-stakes contest, with the Bharatiya Janata Party fielding senior leader Suresh Adhikari against the Congress. Adhikari had defeated her in Nandigram during the 2021 assembly elections.

Adhikari's affidavit shows his annual income rising from ₹83,100 in 2020-21 to ₹17,38,590 in 2024-25, with earnings from business, MP pension and MLA salary. His declared assets have declined over the same period, with movable assets falling from ₹59,31,647 in 2021 to ₹24,57,600, and immovable assets from ₹1,24,10,000 to ₹46,21,002.

"By rejecting the motion at the very first stage, you effectively eliminate all subsequent stages, including scrutiny by an independent committee and Parliament's collective wisdom," Singhvi added.

[DIVERSE VIEWS]

Congress battles a war of narratives in Kerala

Amrith Lal
amrith.lal@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Cacophony defines the Congress in Kerala — a sharp contrast to the discipline of the Communist Party of India (Marxist), where democratic centralism allows concentration of power at the top. In the Congress, every person is an opinion, or a faction.

This votes today — is an existential battle for the Congress and the United Democratic Front it heads. On the one hand, it faces a formidable challenge from the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front that seeks a Congress-mukt (free) Kerala; on the other hand, it must fend off a rising Bharatiya Janata Party that eyes the party's Hindu voters in its pursuit of building a pan-Indian Hindu electorate and a Congress-mukt India.

Until recently, many state Congress units have been embattled. Congress has sought to survive this double-barrelled attack by alleging a deal between the two parties.

The D-word (deal) has been a part of the Congress campaign with the Congress, has taken a different take on this chaos. "Sushaktamaya ekadhipatya manu apparuthu, ashaktamaya janadhipatyanividhe", which, translated with context, indicates that the Left offers a robust dictatorship while the Congress thrives on a flexible democracy.

Nothing exemplifies Narayanan's playful description of the Congress as its relationship with senior leader Shashi Tharoor. Until recently, many state leaders were making, aside remarks about Tharoor's politics.

However, the Thiruvananthapuram MP has re-emerged as among the party's most sought-after campaigners. In Ramn, a constituency hugging the Western Ghats in south-east Kerala, local resident Binny Sahitya called the former Union minister a "Gen Z icon". The size and enthusiasm of the crowd that waited in the heat with candidate Pazhakulam Madhu to receive Tharoor, who was running late by an hour, were revealing. A visibly happy Tharoor said that he was pleased and gratified with the appreciation he has received from Congress candidates. Over a week, he covered at least 60 constituencies, often clocking 250-300 kms a day, holding road shows,



Senior Congress leaders VD Satheesan and Shashi Tharoor during an election campaign in Thiruvananthapuram. HT PHOTO

campaign has been quiet about who its CM face is, unlike the LDF, whose campaign is centred on its captain, CM Pinarayi Vijayan.

Kalpita Narayanan, a well-known associate with the Congress, has taken a different take on this chaos. "Sushaktamaya ekadhipatya manu apparuthu, ashaktamaya janadhipatyanividhe", which, translated with context, indicates that the Left offers a robust dictatorship while the Congress thrives on a flexible democracy.

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addressing street corner meetings, and even press conferences. In simple functional Malayalam, he makes a case for the Congress-UDF candidate, appealing particularly to the youth. "A simple message is a positive message," Tharoor explained. The ultimate acknowledgement came from Satheesan in Paravur. "I give the assurance that we will make use of Shashi Tharoor's knowledge and expertise," he said, with Tharoor standing beside him.

The Congress-UDF workers recognise that another loss — the LDF broke the Kerala pattern of alternating between fronts in office in 2021 — could be disastrous for the party. The general election and local bodies poll results have instilled hope, though few risk predicting a wave or sweep in the party's favour.

UDF workers this time have been putting in extra effort to do squad work, undertake house visits, and hit the streets. Multiple Muslim League leaders in northern Kerala confessed that they were surprised by the enthusiasm shown by Congress workers in campaigning for UDF candidates. John Samuel, head of the state Congress publicity wing, said that the party revamped its booth, ward, and mandal committees after the 2021 loss. The Congress's performance in state polls has been declining since 2001, when it won 62 seats. In the subsequent four elections, it came down to 24, 38, 22 and 21, whereas the CPI(M) raised its tally to 65, 45, 58, and 62 seats, respectively. With the exit of the

Kerala Congress (M), the UDF is now a relatively weaker alliance; the Muslim League provides ballast in the Malabar region, but Revolutionary Socialist Party, Communist Marxist Party, and Revolutionary Marxist Party have limited influence.

The UDF is confident it has won back Muslim and Christian voters who were moving away from the party. The campaigning of Rahul Gandhi Vadra (both have been of electoral politics in the state, representing the Wayanad Lok Sabha constituency) has buoyed the party's secular, centre-left credentials. CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby, however, alleged that the Congress's secular posture emanated more from its grievance at losing power than from any ideological conviction.

But the real test for the Congress will be in managing the different social constituencies that it once patronised. The expansion of the CPI(M) as a mass party since the 1970s, the rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party, the absence of a pan-state, community leaders after the fading of K Karunakaran, AK Antony and Oommen Chandy, and the shrinking of its national footprint, has tested the Congress's ability to offer itself as a party of governance in Kerala. The CPI(M) has tried to make the most of this crisis by offering Pinarayi Vijayan as a strong and decisive administrator, a contrast to the Congress leadership that is perceived as a prisoner of communal and caste interest groups. This narrative has many takers in the state.

A visible change in the UDF campaign is its crop of powerful campaigners — Satheesan, Tharoor, and Lok Sabha MP Shafi Pambaram among them. Pambaram has the image of a rockstar in northern Kerala, with his road shows a big hit among the youth and women. He also fills a vacuum in Congress of popular leaders from the Muslim community. In contrast, the CPI(M) has invested solely in Vijayan and, only in the last phase of the campaign, brought in younger faces.

As voters troop across to the polling booths, the Congress and the UDF will have their fingers crossed. A win would be a lifeline to the party — and the alliance — as it battles a war of narratives and seeks to reinvent itself as a party of social democracy.

Oppn criticises rejection of notices for removal of CEC

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Leaders of at least six Opposition parties, including the Congress and Trinamool Congress, on Wednesday criticised the rejection of the notices for moving a motion in Parliament to remove Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar from his post, and indicated all options were open to challenge the decision by the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha presiding officers.

Senior Congress lawmaker Abhishek Singhvi alleged the decision undermines constitutional processes and weakens accountability in a democracy. Addressing a press conference, he claimed that such rejection at a preliminary stage amounted to "strangling" the entire impeachment mechanism envisaged in the Constitution.

"When accountability is adjudged intelligently, then democracy itself stands impeached," Singhvi said, "If the Election Commission's position was strong, there should be no fear of scrutiny."

He claimed that the presiding officers "committed a fundamental conceptual error by collapsing a multi-stage constitutional process into a single decision at the admission stage."

TMC leaders Derek O'Brien and Sagarkha Ghose, RJD's Manoj Jha, AAP's Sandeep Pathak, DMK's Yogesh and NCP-SP's Rajeev Jha were also present in the press conference.

Rajya Sabha chairman CP Radhakrishnan and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla rejected the Opposition's notice against the CEC arguing that the allegations lack necessary proof, have already "been decided" or are

currently under judicial review. Senior leaders indicated that they might consider going to court over the issue.

Singhvi said: "The larger picture has to be looked at. The basic architecture of giving both adjudicatory power to a committee and political power to parliament can be nullified by interpreting only the admissibility issue." He maintained that the Constitution provides for a detailed procedure involving an initial admission, the formation of a judicial committee, framing of charges, the submission of a report, parliamentary discussion and finally, a decision.

"By rejecting the motion at the very first stage, you effectively eliminate all subsequent stages, including scrutiny by an independent committee and Parliament's collective wisdom," Singhvi added.



Siddaramaiah

EC ACTING WITH BIAS: K'TAKA CM AFTER QUERY ON FUNDS IN BYPOLL

Arun Dev
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah on Wednesday accused the Election Commission of India (ECI) of acting with bias after it sought details on fund disbursements under the state's guarantee schemes in two assembly constituencies.

The chief minister's remarks came after EC wrote to the state government regarding the release of funds in Davanagere South and Bagalkot, where by-elections are scheduled for April 9. In a letter dated April 2, EC secretary Pawan Deswal asked chief secretary Shashini Rajneesh to provide details of financial transfers and identify officials who authorised them. The Commission said it had received inputs about "fresh sanction of financial benefits" under schemes such as Gruha Lakshmi, Yuva Nidhi, Shakti, Gruha Jyothi and Anna Bhagya.

EC noted that the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) is in force in these constituencies and said no fresh fund releases should be made without prior approval. Rejecting the concerns, the

Fate of 1,849 candidates in two states, one UT set to be sealed today

Utpal Parashar and Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

GUWAHATI/THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Around 53,05 million voters will seal the fate of 1,849 candidates on Thursday, when polling for the assembly elections will be held in Kerala, Assam and Puducherry. The votes will be counted along with the other two states — Tamil Nadu and West Bengal — on May 4.

In Assam, voting will be held for all 126 constituencies, with over 25 million voters eligible to exercise their franchise to decide the fate of 722 candidates. The state had witnessed a high-decibel campaigning leading up to the crucial assembly polls.

The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is seeking a third consecutive term along with its allies, the Asom Gana Parishad and the Bodoland People's Front, contesting 90, 26 and 11 seats respectively. The Congress, aiming for a comeback, has stitched together a broad alliance with parties including the Rajar Dal, Assam Jatiya Parishad and CPI(M), contesting 89 seats.

Other players in the fray include the All India United Democratic Front (30 seats), the Aam Aadmi Party, Trinamool Congress (TMC), and the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha.

trial forces to ensure security. Key constituencies include Jalukbari, where chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma is seeking re-election and Jorhat, where Congress leader Gaurav Gogoi is contesting his first assembly poll.

In Kerala, over 27.1 million voters will exercise their ballots across 140 constituencies in a triangular contest between the CPI(M)-led LDF, the Congress-led UDF, and the BJP-led NDA. The electorate comprises 13.2 million male, 13.9 million female and 273 transgender persons, with around 460,000 first-time voters. The state has put in place elaborate arrangements, including over 30,000 polling booths and deployment of more than 76,000 police personnel.

Around 2,040 polling stations have been classified as "critical", with heightened security in districts such as Kannur, Kozhikode and Kasargod. In a unique initiative, over 350 "pink booths" will be managed entirely by women. The ruling LDF, led by CM Pinarayi Vijayan, is aiming for a rare third consecutive term, while the UDF is banking on anti-incumbency to return to power. The BJP, which does not have representation in the outgoing assembly, is attempting to expand its footprint.

In Puducherry, around 950,000 voters will decide the fate of 294 candidates across 30 assembly seats. The contest primarily pits the NDA, comprising the AIADMK

HC QUASHES ECI NOTIFICATION FOR PONDA BYPOLL

Gerard de Souza
gerard.desouza@htlive.com

PANAJI: The Bombay High Court at Goa on Wednesday declared the by-election to the Ponda assembly constituency null and void, cancelling the notification a day before polling was scheduled to commence.

Disposing of petitions challenging the legality of the election, the court ruled that holding the bypoll was untenable under Section 151A of the Representation of the People Act, as less than one year remained in the term of the current assembly.

"The petition is allowed and the notification declaring the holding of the by-election is set aside," the court said. The election has been cancelled, said advocate Rama Rivankar, appearing for the Election Commission of India (ECI). He added that a request to stay the order for two weeks had been rejected and that the detailed judgment would be awaited.

Rivankar said the court held that "there needs to be at least one year from the date of counting of votes" for a by-election to be held under Section 151A.

The ruling has triggered a political row, with the Congress alleging foul play. State Congress president Amit Patkar termed the development a "dark day for democracy," accusing the BJP and the poll panel of collusion.

poll diary

DAY BEFORE POLLING, ASSAM CONGRESS CANDIDATE QUITS CITING LACK OF SUPPORT

SILCHAR: Congress candidate from the Udalguri (ST) constituency, Suren Damary, on Wednesday announced his resignation from the party citing lack of organisational support and communication from the leadership, a day ahead of polls. Addressing the media, Damary said he was dissatisfied with the functioning of the party after filing his nomination last month. "They made me candidate, but throughout my campaign the party did not maintain even basic communication," he said.

BJP REVEALS LAST CANDIDATE FOR BENGAL ELECTIONS

KOLKATA: The Bharatiya Janata Party on Wednesday released its sixth list for the Bengal assembly polls, naming only one candidate, Rakesh Singh, for the Kolkata Port sector. Singh will be contesting Kolkata mayor and cabinet minister Rakesh Singh's seat. He has been winning the seat continuously since 2011, when the Trinamool Congress came to power in Bengal for the first time. The polls will be held in the second phase on April 29. Singh was earlier expelled from the Congress after he was arrested in September 2025 in connection with the violence at party headquarters.

CASH-FOR-VOTE CLAIM AGAINST BJP CANDIDATE

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The district collector of Palakkad has submitted a preliminary inquiry report on allegations against Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader and Palakkad assembly candidate Sothra Surenandran of trying to influence an elderly voter by distributing money. Wednesday, the office of the state's chief electoral officer Rathan U Kelkar said. The EC sent a flying squad to conduct an on-the-spot inquiry in Kannadi panchayat of the constituency. "The flying squad recorded the testimony of a woman who was alleged to have received the money," the office said.

[DELIMITATION]

Don't create a storm in calm South: Stalin

Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin on Wednesday demanded a fair delimitation for the southern states, warning that his state would not accept any decision taken by the Centre without its consent.

In a post on X titled, "Delimitation Danger: Is India sliding into dictatorship", the DMK chief said, "Do not turn a calm South into a storm".

Stalin posed a series of questions to Prime Minister Narendra Modi demanding "why the Bharatiya Janata Party-led central government is shrouding the entire delimitation process in secrecy instead of coming clean on how it intends to carry it out?"

He pointed out that the late Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee deferred delimitation in 2001 for 25 years in the national interest. "What is PM Modi's answer to the just and reasonable demand of

southern states to follow the same path today," Stalin queried. Stalin sought to know what the "tearing hurry" to convene a special session of the Parliament meant in the middle of five state elections. "Why is the government brushing aside the fair and reasoned demand of Opposition leaders to hold the special session only after April 29? what is it trying to hide?" he asked.

He asserted that the DMK would not stand by and watch any attempt that places the rights of southern states at stake while handling greater power to the North.

"The South Demands Fair Delimitation," he said. Criticising Stalin, AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami said, "The delimitation is a national exercise."

Already, a central minister has clarified that the state was not affected. Why are you harping on it? It appears you don't have anything else to talk," Palaniswami said.

Kharge apologises for his 'illiterate' remark

Ishita Bahi
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge



are being deliberately misinterpreted. Even so, I express my sincere regret. It was never my intention to hurt the sentiments of the people of Gujarat or

attacked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan. He said these two people can fool people who are illiterate in Gujarat or

...IN SOME CASES, SUCH AS THE 2019 poll-time announcements about ongoing programmes. "These are part of commitments made during the 2023 assembly polls," he said, adding funds are transferred "regularly in a transparent and structured manner" as per guidelines. "This is governance, not inducement," he said.

...BETTER, ALONG WITH THE UNBANNED voters, according to ECI data. Over 640,000 first-time voters and more than 250,000 senior citizens above 80 years are part of the voting population. Poll authorities have made extensive arrangements, including webcasting across over 3,000 polling stations and deployment of cen-

...THEY ALSO AIM, AGAINST THE ENEMY bloc led by the Congress and DMK. CM N Rangasamy is among the prominent candidates in the fray, as the NDA seeks to retain power while the opposition pushes to regain control of the Union territory.

With agency inputs

...FIVE MONTHS THE ELECTION COMMISSION squandered... This is clearly the handwork of the BJP and the EC. Patkar said, claiming his party was poised to win the seat.

CM Pramod Sawant said, "The decision of the court is shocking. We are in touch with our central party leadership."

...ON WEDNESDAY ISSUED AN APOLOGY over his alleged "illiterate" remark on people from Gujarat and some other states during an election campaign in Kerala.

The remark triggered a political uproar with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) terming the statement as "shameless, demeaning and utterly despicable."



Mallikarjun Kharge

...However, Kharge said his words were being "deliberately misinterpreted".

"Some remarks of mine in a recent election speech in Kerala

...WHICH I HAVE ALWAYS HAD AND WILL continue to have the highest of respect," the Congress leader said in a post on X.

On Sunday, Kharge while addressing a rally in Kollam district sought to make a comparison between the people of Kerala and other states ruled by the BJP, especially Gujarat, as he

...OTHER STATES, THAT ARE IN THE PAIN-BOUND state.

The remarks sparked a rift between Congress and BJP leaders, with leaders from the BJP demanding senior Congress leaders like Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and Sonia Gandhi clarify whether they agreed with the statement.

NEW DELHI
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Hindustan Times

My INDIA

09

Sabarimala: SC pushes back on govt's 'hands off faith' argument

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday pushed back against the Union government's argument that courts cannot sit in judgment over religious practices by branding them as superstitious or irrational, reminding the Centre that even religious freedoms under the Constitution are subject to public order, morality, health and other fundamental rights.

On the second day of the hearing of the Sabarimala reference, a nine-judge bench led by CJI Surya Kant emphasised that while courts may exercise restraint in matters of faith, they cannot be "completely demured" of jurisdiction where a practice is found to be egregiously violative of constitutional guarantees.

"If something shocks the conscience of the court...on the face of it, no further adjudicatory exercise may be required. The court will simply say it is contrary to public order, morality or health," observed the CJI, responding to submissions by solicitor general Tushar Mehta. The bench also includes justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Arvind Kumar, AG Meech, R Mahadevan, Prasanna B Varma and Joydip Bagchi.

The exchange marked a contin-

If something shocks conscience of the court...on the face of it, no further adjudicatory exercise may be required

SUPREME COURT

uation of the court's probing scrutiny of the Centre's central argument that secular courts lack the institutional competence to determine whether a religious practice is superstitious and that such reform must be left to the legislature. Mehta argued that judges, as experts in law and not religion, should refrain from classifying practices as irrational or non-essential, warning that such an exercise would amount to judicial overreach into matters of faith.

The bench, however, was unconvinced by the sweeping nature of this submission. Justice Amalulab terming the argument "too simplistic", asserting that courts retain the authority to examine whether a practice bears the colour of superstition, even if the manner of reform may

ultimately lie with the legislature. Justice Sundresh added that adopting a "hands-off approach" in all such cases would effectively strip courts of their constitutional role, particularly where a practice is so manifestly violative, drawing a parallel with practices like sati, he said. On his part, justice Bagchi tested the limits of the Centre's argument through hypotheticals, asking whether courts would remain powerless if practices such as witchcraft were claimed as part of religion in the absence of legislative intervention.

While Mehta maintained that such cases could be addressed under the grounds of public order and morality, rather than by labelling them as superstition, the bench repeatedly indicated that judicial review cannot be so narrowly confined.

Justice Nagarathna, meanwhile, emphasised that courts, while examining essential religious practices, must do so from within the philosophical framework of the religion itself, but always subject to constitutional limitations. "That does not take away the jurisdiction of the court in an appropriate case," she noted, underscoring the balance between deference to faith and constitutional scrutiny.

The hearing also saw a broader debate on the meaning of "moral-

ity" under Articles 25 and 26, with the Centre arguing that it should be understood as "societal morality" rather than "constitutional morality"—a concept it described as vague and indeterminate.

The bench appeared divided on this, with justice Bagchi observing that constitutional morality governs secular life, while religious practices may be informed by the internal morality of a denomination, raising the question of how the two can be reconciled in a constitutional democracy.

In an aside, the CJI also questioned the reliance on academic writings in constitutional adjudication, particularly in the 2018 Joseph Shine judgment that struck down the offence of adultery, remarking that such viewpoints are ultimately "subjective".

At the same time, the bench clarified that the validity of Joseph Shine itself is not directly under challenge in the present proceedings, even as the Centre has urged the court to declare its reasoning as not good law.

The bench, which will continue hearing the case on Thursday, is tasked with answering questions arising from the 2019 reference, including scope of judicial review over religious practices, the contours of the essential religious practices doctrine, and meaning of constitutional morality.

HC rejects Michel's plea for release from jail

Shruti Kakkar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Wednesday dismissed a plea filed by Christian Michel James, the alleged middleman in the AgustaWestland VVIP chopper case, seeking release from prison on the ground that he had already served the maximum sentence for the offences for which he was extradited and could not be prosecuted for offences not covered by the extradition order.

A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dubeja



Christian Michel James

observed that the petition lacked merit, noting that Michel was merely seeking to re-agitate an issue that had, at least prima facie, already been considered by the Supreme Court.

"Therefore the petitioner is merely trying to re-agitate the same issue, which at least on prima facie basis stands consid-

ered by the Supreme Court. The same may not be permissible. We find no merit in the present petition. The same is accordingly dismissed," the court said in its 19-page verdict.

Michel, represented by advocate Aljo K Joseph, had challenged the trial court's August 7, 2025 order denying his release and questioned Article 17 of the India-UAE extradition treaty, which allows prosecution for offences for which extradition is granted and for "connected offences".

He argued in his petition that he had already undergone five

years of sentence under the Prevention of Corruption Act and could not be tried for forgery, added later through supplementary chargesheets invoking IPC Section 467, without consent from the UAE.

The CBI and ED, represented by additional solicitor general DP Singh, argued that Michel's extradition in December 2018 was based on charges of cheating, conspiracy and corruption, and that Article 17 permits prosecution for connected offences.

They said forgery was intrinsically linked to the allegations forming the basis of extradition.

Andhra may ban private sleeper buses over safety norm violations

Srinivasa Rao Apparao

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh government is contemplating a ban on private sleeper buses, officials said on Wednesday, adding that the move was spurred by a recent spate of serious accidents involving such vehicles.

The cabinet sub-committee constituted by chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu to review measures to prevent bus accidents took the matter up for discussion on Tuesday. State transport minister Mandipalli Ram-

prasad Reddy and home minister Vangalapati Anitha were present. Most private sleeper buses currently in service were converted vehicles rather than factory-built models, officials present informed the sub-committee, and flagged the lax compliance with structural and safety standards, including lack of adequate emergency exits and poor ventilation.

"In the first phase, the state government is examining the possibility of banning non-factory-built sleeper buses. We shall take up with the Centre seeking regulatory intervention to either

restrict or prohibit unsafe sleeper coach operations," Reddy said.

Meanwhile, the government is rolling out a series of safety measures with immediate effect, he added. It includes regulation of travel time based on distance between the points of origin and destination. "If a bus reaches earlier than the stipulated time, it will not be allowed into the city," the minister said, adding the move was aimed at discouraging speeding. Private buses operating on routes longer than 300 kilometres will now require to be staffed by two drivers.

6 HELD IN 2016 CUSTODIAL DEATH CASE IN CUTTACK

BHUBANESWAR: Police in Odisha's Cuttack district on Wednesday arrested two retired police personnel, two retired home guards and two serving home guards, nearly a decade after an alleged custodial death of 44-year-old man Saroj Senapati alias Akula.

"The six were arrested after sufficient evidence was found against them," said Narasimhapur police station inspector-in-charge Tapan Pati. The case dates back to December 9, 2016. Police had initially denied allegations of torture, claiming he died in a scuffle with cops. HT

Nirav moves ECHR against extradition

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Two weeks after the high court of justice in London refused to reopen Nirav Modi's extradition case, a verdict which has shut all doors for him legally in the United Kingdom, the fugitive diamondaire has approached the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR) in Strasbourg, France, in a last ditch attempt to save himself, people familiar with the development said.

Indian agencies, however, believe that his application is likely to be rejected at the admission stage only as his previous attempts to invoke the convention for the protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms, better known as the European Convention on Human Rights, before the UK courts have been dismissed by the judges.

"If anything, this fresh attempt by Nirav Modi will just delay by a few months his repatriation to India because he has already exhausted all his legal options in the UK," said an official, requesting anonymity.

The UK high court, on March 25, took into account the assurances from the Indian government — delivered in September 2025, December 2025, and through a note verbale from the Indian High Commission in London in February 2026 — that Modi will not be interrogated by any of the five investigating agencies handling his cases, as it dismissed his plea to reopen the



Nirav Modi

extradition, which was ordered by a Westminster's court in London in February 2022.

Elaborating the process at ECHR, a second official said that "if Modi's plea is found admissible by the body, then the government seeking extradition (India) will be called to submit its observations on both, the admissibility and the merits of the case. However, if rejected at the admissibility stage, he won't be able to appeal at ECHR again".

The UK is a party to the European Convention on Human Rights. Modi had previously raised the issue of torture in Indian prisons, if extradited, and his mental health to oppose the extradition but the courts in London have not found merit in his arguments.

HT reached out to Nirav Modi's legal team in London through email but there was no response. Accused of defrauding Punjab National Bank of ₹6,498 crore — part of a total ₹13,578 crore fraud, with around ₹7,000 crore linked to his uncle Mehul Choksi — Modi has been in a UK prison since his arrest by Scotland Yard in March 2019, based on India's extradition request.

SC RAPS STATES, UTs OVER FAILURE TO CURB TRAFFICKING

Abraham Thomas

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday expressed concern over the increasing cases of child trafficking and directed states and union territories to take timely action in retrieving missing children by cracking down on the inter-state gangs.

The observations came while

LUTHRA BROTHERS WALK OUT OF JAIL AFTER GETTING BAIL IN FORGERY CASE

Gerard de Souza

letters@hindustantimes.com

PANAJI: Owners of fire-ravaged nightclub Birch by Romeo Lane, Saurav and Gaurav Luthra, walked out of the Central Jail at Colvale in north Goa on Wednesday, 116 days after they were arrested after being deported

Drone Didi Yojana

Under the Namo Drone Didi Yojana

- ★ Training to women for operating drones along with free drone facility
- ★ Provision of subsidy as per eligibility and norms

the court was monitoring implementation of an April 2025 judgment in a case of a missing child from Uttar Pradesh where directions were issued to all states and union territories to implement recommendations contained in a 2023 NHRC commission report on Human Trafficking conducted by Delhi-based Bharatiya Institute of Research and Development. The judgment also required all high courts to issue directions to district courts to take up such cases on a day-to-day basis and conclude the trial in three months.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan said, "This is a serious matter. Day after day we come across reports of children going missing and occasionally we read about their retrieval. It all depends on your will. Please take it seriously. Do not take this lightly."

The court was addressing home secretaries of MP, Goa, Haryana, Mizoram, Odisha, Punjab and UT of Lakshadweep, who were in default in complying with April 2025 directions. Next hearing is on April 29.

from Thailand, hours after a local court granted them bail in a forgery case.

The duo, promoters of Birch by Romeo Lane, an illegally operating nightclub where a fire in December last year claimed 25 lives and who are prime accused in the case, were granted bail by the Judicial Magistrate on Wednesday in a second case of document forgery. On April 1, the brothers were granted bail in the main case in which they are accused of culpable homicide.

Speaking to reporters on Wednesday, the brothers' advocate said they were granted bail "subject to regular conditions on furnishing a bond of ₹1 lakh and a surety of ₹50,000 each."

ED attaches assets worth over ₹17 crore

Meanwhile, the Enforcement Directorate's Panaji zonal office attached properties worth over ₹17.45 crore under the provisions of PMLA in connection with an ongoing investigation into the "illegal" operation of the nightclub Birch by Birch by Romeo owned by Luthra brothers.



Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

Non-Stop Haryana

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NEW DELHI
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Govt rolls back some LPG curbs, allots more gas to fertiliser plants

Rajeev Jayaswal
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday raised gas allocation for fertiliser plants to 95% of their requirements and permitted supply of commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to additional sectors, including agriculture, pharmaceuticals, paint, ceramic, foundry and glass. Officials said, moves that came hours after the US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire.

In a briefing, Sujata Sharma, joint secretary in the petroleum ministry said natural gas supplies to fertiliser plants have been raised again from 90% to 95% of their requirement. This is the second increase in a week. The government on Monday raised gas allocation for the fertiliser sector from about 70% to 90%. Natural gas is both fuel and feedstock for fertiliser plants.

Currently, gas is first supplied to meet 100% requirements of domestic consumers through piped natural gas (PNG) and automobiles, through compressed natural gas (CNG).

Speaking about the LPG supply, Sharma said the government on Wednesday issued an order allowing commercial LPG supply to additional sectors such as agriculture, urea, heavy water, pharmaceuticals, paint, ceramic, foundry and glass. The order promises to meet 70% of their gas requirements before March "with overall sectoral limit of 200 tonnes per day," she



The 15-day ceasefire may help in strengthening energy supply chains and calm raising fuel prices, officials said.

added.

The government initially cut LPG supplies to commercial consumers in order to meet the requirement of 332 million domestic household customers.

After ensuring supplies to domestic consumers, on March 12, the government allowed supplies of commercial LPG in a calibrated manner to hospitals and educational institutions. Sharma said. This has since progressively raised to 70% and covers restaurants, dhabas, hotels, canteens, community kitchens, and the steel, automobile, textile, chemicals and plastic sectors.

The government has also doubled the supply of 5kg free trade LPG (FTL), sold mainly consumed by migrant labourers. That move came after the industry feared a potential mass exodus of migrant labourers due to the shortage of 5kg FTL in several industrial clusters. Sharma said supplies to FTL consumers

have been augmented. Over 110,000 FTL cylinders were sold on Tuesday alone, she said. Since March 23, a total of 8,90,000 FTL cylinders have been sold, she added.

After war broke out in West Asia on February 28, energy supplies were hit. Before the war, India imported 60% of its LPG requirements, and 90% of that came from the West Asia, predominantly Qatar.

According to officials, the 15-day ceasefire may help in strengthening energy supply chains and calm raising fuel prices. Benchmark Brent crude prices, at \$72.87 a barrel before the war in West Asia, soared to \$119.5 by March 9, but fell sharply by 15.3% after news of the ceasefire to \$92.55 a barrel (at 5:35 IST on Wednesday). India is the world's third biggest consumer of crude oil after the US and China and imports over 88% of crude oil it processes.

Cabinet clears ₹41K cr for fertiliser subsidy

Zia Haq
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday cleared ₹41,534 crore towards nutrient-based fertiliser subsidy for the summer-sowing season, raising it by ₹4,317 crore, a nearly 12% jump from the previous cropping cycle, to make up for higher costs and cushion farmers amid supply disruptions due to the West Asian conflict.

The higher subsidy, which covers mixed crop chemicals, is aimed at keeping the price of 50-kg packages of diammonium phosphate steady at ₹1,350 despite higher import prices.

"The West Asian conflict has had an impact on fertilisers. There's no problem of availability in India. Some people have started hoarding, which is not good," information and broadcasting minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said, briefing reporters.

The nutrient-based subsidy regime offers fertilisers at lower-than-market price to farmers based on their phosphatic and potassic content, which is aimed at discouraging overuse.

Food security in the world's most-populous country is closely linked to the adequate availability and affordability of key fertilisers, as farmers prepare for the summer-planting season.

The government makes available 28 grades of P&K fertilisers, which are also covered, to farmers at subsidised rates through manufacturers and importers. These are sold by manufacturers at a discount, who are then reimbursed by the government.

Fertiliser manufacturers say a ceasefire announced by Iran and the US has come as a breather, which will help boost availability. "The ceasefire is a timely and positive development as it is expected to improve LNG availability from the Gulf and support uninterrupted fertiliser supplies ahead of the kharif season. This will help stabilise domestic production, ease import-related cost pressures, and curb speculative price increase," said PS Gahlaut, managing director, Indian Potash Limited.

The country relies on imports of fertilisers such as urea, DAP and muriate of potash, along with liquefied natural gas, which fires crop-nutrient plants. The latest hike in subsidies pertains to a category of crop nutrients that are heavily reliant on imports. Higher shipping costs and a supply crunch came barely two months ahead of the kharif season, which accounts for half of India's annual food supply.

India, Bangladesh take steps to normalise ties

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India and Bangladesh on Wednesday agreed to take forward the normalising of ties after a period of unprecedented strains, including resumption of existing mechanisms to address differences and bolster trade and energy cooperation, as Bangladesh foreign minister Khairul Rahman met his counterpart S Jaishankar and other top leaders.

Rahman, who made a stopover in New Delhi en route to Mauritius to participate in the Indian Ocean Conference, is the first minister to visit India since Tarique Rahman's Bangladesh Nationalist Party swept the general poll in February. The Indian side has made a concerted outreach to the BNP to rebuild ties that hit an all-time low under the interim government led by Muhammad Yunus.

During Rahman's meetings with key Indian interlocutors, the two sides decided to address contentious issues such as former premier Sheikh Hasina's presence in India and the arrest of two Bangladeshi nationals in West Bengal for alleged involvement in the killing of radical leader Sharif Osman Hadi in such a manner that they did not impede progress in other aspects of the bilateral relationship, people familiar with the matter said.

"The focus was on strengthening key aspects of the relationship, including people-to-people ties and trade, which will be done by resuming contacts through existing mechanisms," a person said on condition of anonymity.

Rahman reiterated Dhaka's request to extradite Hasina and former home minister Asaduzzaman Khan as they were given the death penalty by the International Crimes Tribunal, according to a statement from Bangladesh's foreign ministry.

He also thanked the Indian government for apprehending the suspected killers of Hadi. "Both sides agreed that the arrested individuals will be returned to Bangladesh in accordance with the procedures laid out in the extradition treaty between the two countries," the Bangladesh statement said.

A readout from the external affairs ministry was silent on these



S Jaishankar with Bangladeshi Foreign Minister Khairul Rahman on Wednesday.

issues, though the people cited above acknowledged the cases of Hasina and Hadi figured in the talks. Hasina and Kamal have lived in self-exile in India since they fled Bangladesh following the collapse of the Awami League government in August 2024 after weeks of student-led protests.

Gunmen shot Hadi in Dhaka last December and died while being treated in Singapore. The attack sparked violent protests across Bangladesh that took on anti-Indian overtones because of unsubstantiated reports of an Indian link to his killing. Kolkata Police arrested two Bangladeshi nationals for alleged involvement in Hadi's killing in March and were handed over to the National Investigation Agency.

At his meeting with Rahman, Jaishankar pointed to "India's desire to engage constructively with the new government" in Dhaka and further strengthen ties, according to the external affairs ministry's readout. The two sides agreed to explore proposals for deepening the partnership through the relevant bilateral mechanisms. Follow-on official meetings are expected to take place at an early date, it added.

Jaishankar said on social media he and Rahman discussed the strengthening of various facets of bilateral relations, and regional and global developments.

Bangladesh's foreign ministry's statement quoted Rahman as saying that the BNP government will pursue a foreign policy with the principle of "Bangladesh First" and on the basis of mutual trust and respect and reciprocal benefit."

The Bangladesh statement also cited Jaishankar as saying that Indian visas, particularly medical and business visas, will

Jaishankar set to visit Mauritius, UAE this week

NEW DELHI: External affairs minister S Jaishankar will visit Mauritius and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) this week to bolster bilateral relations, the ministry said on Wednesday.

Jaishankar will travel to Mauritius during April 9-10 to participate in the Indian Ocean Conference and deliver the keynote address, the external affairs ministry said. The minister will meet the leadership of Mauritius and review the entire spectrum of bilateral ties.

He is also expected to hold discussions with his counterparts from other nations. Jaishankar will make an official visit to the UAE during April 11-12. He will meet the leadership of the UAE to "review close cooperation and deepen the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries," the ministry said.

He "eased in the coming weeks". The easing of visa restrictions, imposed by India when ties nosedived during the tenure of the interim government, has been a key ask from Dhaka.

During his meeting with petroleum and natural gas minister Hardeep Puri, Rahman expressed thanks for the recent supply of diesel to Bangladesh by India and sought an increase in the diesel and fertiliser supplies. Puri indicated the Indian government will "consider the request readily and favourably," the Bangladesh statement said.

Puri said on social media that he and Rahman had discussed bilateral cooperation in the energy sector but didn't give details. Indian officials earlier said Bangladesh's request for additional supplies of diesel and petroleum products will be considered while keeping in mind availability and market conditions.

Challenges to Trans Act: HC seeks Centre's reply

Shruti Kakkur
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Wednesday issued a notice to the Centre in petitions challenging the controversial amendments introduced in the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026, particularly those relating to the revised definition of 'transgender', the removal of self-perceived identity as the basis for obtaining a transgender certificate from the district authority, and the proposed requirement of certification by a medical board.

The Bill to amend the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 was passed by Lok Sabha on March 24 and the Rajya Sabha on March 25 with a voice vote amid strong objections from the opposition that demanded that the bill be referred to a standing committee for wider consultations. It became law after President of India Droupadi Murmu gave her assent on March 30.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Udayhaya and Justice Tejas Karia sought the Centre's response to these petitions and

other was filed by Lakshay Jain, a working professional.

"Issue notice to the respondents. Let an affidavit and reply be filed. List on July 22," the court said in its order.

In his petition, Dr Jain, an advocate, contended that the amendment, by reintroducing state control over gender identity through mechanisms of verification and certification, amounts to a legislative rollback of a fundamental right already recognised by the Supreme Court in National Legal Services Authority v. Union of India.

In that decision, the Court held that gender identity forms an integral part of dignity, autonomy and personal liberty under Articles 14, 19(1)(a) and 21 of the Constitution, and affirmed that every individual has the right to self-identify their gender.

The petition stated the amendment shifts the law from a rights-based framework to a regulatory screening mechanism, contrary to binding constitutional jurisprudence that recognises gender identity as intrinsic and personal, and not subject to biological determination.

"The Amendment violates the

India welcomes ceasefire, calls for free Hormuz Strait passage

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India on Wednesday welcomed the two-week ceasefire between Iran and the United States and called for the unhindered movement of global commerce through the Strait of Hormuz while expressing the hope that the developments in West Asia will encourage peace efforts in Ukraine.

Iran and the US announced the ceasefire, brokered by Pakistan with the backing of China, early on Wednesday, following 40 days of air strikes and attacks on energy and other infrastructure that had triggered fears of a wider war engulfing West Asia. The conflict, which began with Israel and the US's military strikes on Iran on February 28, disrupted shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, used to transport 50% of India's oil imports.

"We welcome the ceasefire and hope that it will lead to a lasting peace in West Asia. As we have continuously advocated earlier, de-escalation, dialogue and diplomacy are essential to bring an end to the conflict in the region," Jaishankar said.



Randhir Jaiswal

were impacted by the virtual closure of the critical waterway by Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), sparking concerns about a possible shortage of oil and gas in the country. Since the start of the conflict, only eight Indian-flagged LPG carriers had transited the strait, and Iran has been clearing the passage of vessels on a case-by-case basis.

Jaishankar said the Indian side continues to be in touch with Iran and other stakeholders to ensure the unimpeded transit of Indian-flagged shipping through the strait, though there have been no discussions with Tehran on paying a fee to use the waterway. "This is an evolving situation [and we are] in touch with partners and stakeholders to serve our interests," he said.

Canada: International students told to verify compliance with norms

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: Canada's immigration department has started sending letters to international students, including several from India, enrolled at higher education institutions to verify their compliance with study permit norms, after a report by the country's Auditor General raised concerns over the integrity of the International Student Program.

compliance purposes, the student was required to provide a formal letter from their designated learning institution confirming current enrolment status with current and previous transcripts from any designated learning institution(s) they had attended in Canada. "Failing to provide the required documents within 21 days could result in the loss of your temporary resident status in Canada," the letter said.

Sierah, however, said such action was not taken in her case.

INDIA, TURKIYE TALK TERROR, TIES AFTER 4-YEAR GAP

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India raised the fight against cross-border terrorism during foreign office consultations with Turkey on Wednesday, the first such engagement between the two countries in almost four years.

India-Turkey relations have been buffeted by a range of issues in recent years, including the Turkish leadership's position on Kashmir and Turkey's support for Pakistan during a brief conflict with India last year.

The 12th round of India-Turkey foreign office consultations

REPORTER: BY THE PUBLISHED AND
fixed July 22 as the next date of
hearing. While one petition was
filed by Dr Chandresh Jain, the

RIGHTS TO DIGNITY, PRIVACY AND
rights to dignity, privacy and
constitutional autonomy under Ar-
ticle 21," the petition stated.

external affairs ministry spokes-
person Randeep Jaiswal told a
media briefing.

India has always been in
favour of peace. We welcome all
steps that lead to peace and sta-
bility. We hope that this develop-
ment in West Asia will also en-
courage peace efforts in
Ukraine," he said.

The conflict, Jaiswal noted, has
caused "immense suffering to peo-
ple and disrupted global energy
supply and trade networks", and
India expects unimpeded freedom
of navigation and global flow of
commerce will prevail through
the Strait of Hormuz.

He also claimed the US has
"met and exceeded all military
objectives" and is "very far along"
with a definitive agreement for
long-term peace with Iran, as
almost all "points of past conten-
tion" have been agreed on by the

briefing that ensuring the safety,
security and welfare of the large
Indian community in West Asia
remains the "highest priority",
and Indian missions are facilitat-
ing visas and transit through
neighbouring countries due to air-
space restrictions in Israel, Iran,
Iraq, Kuwait and Bahrain.

The Indian embassy in Tehran
issued a fresh advisory on
Wednesday urging Indian nation-
als to "expediently exit Iran" in
coordination with the mission and
using routes suggested by Indian
authorities. Indians have been
leaving Iran via Armenia and
Azerbaijan immigration consul-
ant Kanwar Sierah, said that for

received by several students,
including many from India, in
recent weeks. The issue of fraud
was addressed in International
Student Program Reforms
report submitted to the Parlia-
ment on March 23 by the coun-
try's Auditor General (AG). In a
statement issued at the time, AG
Karen Hogan said, "The depart-
ment needs to act on the infor-
mation it has to address integrity
concerns in the program."

A letter received by an Indian
student from Immigration, Refu-
ges and Citizenship Canada
(IRCC), and shared by Mississau-
ga immigration consultant
Kanwar Sierah, said that for
fraud occurred in previous
years and most of the students
from then had already com-
pleted their courses. "They are
finally acting, but it may be too
late," Sierah noted.

SEARCH FOR MISSING



Reshma
Long, Built: Medium, Wearing: White Colour Pajama, Chocolate Colour Ladies Frock and Black Colour Burqa and Chappal in feet.
If anyone has any information about this missing female please inform P.S. Mehrauli, New Delhi.
Web: <http://cbl.nic.in>, E-mail: cic@cbl.gov.in
Ph: 011-24368638/24368641, Fax: 011-24368639
SHO
Police Station Mehrauli, New Delhi
Ph: 8750870824, 8527239119
DP/4534/SD/2026

SEARCH FOR MISSING



Suman
In this regard DD No. 36 Dated
26.03.2026 has been registered at PS: Nabl Karim, Delhi.
Sincere efforts have been made by local police to trace out the
missing female but no clue has come to light so far. If anyone
have any information about this missing Female please inform to
the following.
Website: <http://cbl.nic.in> SHO
E-Mail ID: cic@cbl.gov.in
Fax: 011-24368639
DP/4526/CD/2026
Mobile: 8750870428, 9968800307

MP forest guard run over by vehicle of sand mafia: Police

BHOPAL: A 35-year-old forest guard was killed after a tractor-trolley allegedly run over by illegal sand mining rans over him in Madhya Pradesh's Morena district on Wednesday, police said.

Morena additional superintendent of police (ASP) Surendra Singh Daxar said forest guard Harshesh Gurjar, 35, of the patrol team, attempted to stop the vehicle, but its driver ran him over, killing him on the spot.

"The driver, identified as Vinod Kori, fled the scene with the vehicle after the incident," the ASP said, adding that the forest guard died on the spot.

A case has been registered and efforts are being made to trace the driver, the ASP said.

India ranks 3rd in RE capacity after China, US: Union minister

NEW DELHI: India ranks third globally in renewable energy installed capacity, after China and US, according to a renewable energy statistics for 2025, Pralhad Joshi, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy said on Wednesday.

He said India has moved ahead of Brazil in the ranking. The Harshesh Gurjar Renewable Energy Agency released the statistics as of December 2025. India achieved a total non-fossil capacity addition of 55.3 GW during FY 2025-26, he said.

China has the highest renewable energy capacity at 2258.02 GW followed by USA at 467.92 GW and India at 250.52 GW. India is followed by Brazil with a capacity of 228.20 GW and Germany with 199.92 GW.

Staunch Nehru-Gandhi family loyalist till the end

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Nine days after Raj Kundra Hirani's *Lage Raho Munnabhai* was released, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) met in New Delhi on September 10, 2006, to plan the centenary commemoration of Mahatma Gandhi's Satyagrah in South Africa. Mohsina Kidwai invoked the movie—an unusual reference for a meeting—and told her colleagues to learn from it on how to communicate Gandhi's message to the new generation.

Born in 1932 to an aristocratic family in Uttar Pradesh's Banda district, Kidwai was a staunch Nehru-Gandhi family loyalist, particularly of Indira Gandhi. The platform for her entry in politics, however, was laid way back in 1954 when 22-year-old Mohsina met Jawaharlal Nehru with her father-in-law Javed

NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

MPC MEETING

exudes calm and assurance by alluding to India's better macro fundamentals before this crisis, it is also bringing in the realism that there are now downside risks to growth forecasts and upside risks to inflation forecasts. Heightened uncertainty during a supply side shock has made the MPC to be on a "wait and watch" mode as the temporary ceasefire in the middle east conflict offers the opportunity to assess the balance of risks," Samiran Chakraborty, Chief India Economist, Citibank said in a note.

While MPC did not give tangible estimates of the war's disruptive impact on the economy, it did flag possible channels through which the adverse effects will be felt.

"First, elevated crude oil prices could increase import inflation and widen the current account deficit. Second, disruptions in energy markets, fertilisers and other commodities may adversely impact industry, agriculture and services, reducing domestic output. Third, heightened uncertainty, increased risk aversion and safe haven demand could impact domestic liquidity conditions, economic activity, consumption and investment. Fourth, weaker global growth prospects may dampen external demand and reduce remittance flows. Finally, adverse spillovers from global financial markets could tighten domestic financial conditions and raise the cost of borrowing. Overall, the initial supply shock can potentially transform into a demand shock over the medium term if the restoration of supply chains is delayed," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said in his written statement issued after the meeting.

To be sure, RBI also underlined the fact that Indian economy can deal with these disruptions. The fundamentals of the Indian economy are on a stronger footing, providing greater resilience to withstand shocks now than in the past. The economy is confronted with a supply shock. It is prudent to wait and watch the changing circumstances and the evolving growth-inflation outlook," the MPC resolution said, justifying its wait and watch approach on the policy front.

Experts believe that future conditions, especially the price of crude oil, will be critical in whether or not RBI increases interest rates going forward.

"Looking ahead, we think that if the energy shock lingers, it could weigh more on growth than on inflation, looking more like the pandemic than the 2022 oil price shock. We believe the RBI can focus on keeping inflation within the 2-6 band rather than strictly at 4%. Our assessment suggests that if oil averages below US\$100/bbl, inflation should stay under 6% (assuming normal rains or a moderate El Niño). If oil averages above US\$100/bbl, inflation would likely breach 6% and could prompt rate hikes — though that isn't our base case," Pranjali Bhandari, Chief India Economist, HSBC said in a note.

Brent crude price fell by 16% to reach around \$92 per barrel on Wednesday after a two-week ceasefire was announced.

The war's disruption on the Indian economy has also diverted RBI's attention and intervention outside the typical growth-inflation dynamic which is the mainstay of India's monetary policy under the inflation targeting framework.

Exchange rate management has emerged as one of the most important challenges on this front.

The Governor's statement acknowledged the situation and assured markets that its recent interventions in the currency markets ought to be seen as attempts to manage volatility rather than completely undermining market determined dynamics.

"Specifically, intervention in the foreign exchange market is aimed at smothering excessive and disruptive volatility without targeting any specific level or band for the exchange rate. This is consistent with our long-standing policy of the exchange rates being market determined. RBI stands committed to this policy and judiciously contain excessive or disruptive volatility to ensure that self-fulfilling expectations do not exacerbate currency movements beyond what is warranted by fundamentals", the Governor's statement said.

The rupee has lost nearly 2% of its value against the US dollar since the West Asia war began, but gained 0.5% on Wednesday to close at 92.59 to the dollar.

NAKAMOTO UNMASKED?

Both Back and Nakamoto were linked to the Cypherpunks, a loosely organised group from the 1990s that advocated the use of cryptography to protect privacy, which later became a sight. The report notes that Back had proposed a decentralised digital currency system resembling Bitcoin years before its creation.

Back also developed Hashcash, a system designed to combat spam, which later became a key component in Bitcoin's architecture. The report suggests Nakamoto combined Hashcash with other ideas such as "B-money" to build Bitcoin.

The report further argues that Back had the technical background required to create Bitcoin, including expertise in distributed systems, C++ programming and public-key cryptography — all central to Bitcoin's design.

It also points to linguistic similarities, including the use of quirky and stylistic patterns, which the report says uniquely match Back among hundreds of individuals in relevant online communities.

Bitcoin was introduced in 2009, after which Nakamoto remained active for about two years before disappearing in 2011. The report claims Back's public engagement with Bitcoin began shortly after Nakamoto's disappearance, following a period of relative silence when the cryptocurrency first emerged.

Despite the circumstantial evidence, Back has maintained there is no definitive proof linking him to Nakamoto and dismissed the conclusions as speculative.

WOMEN'S QUOTA BILL

The Women's reservation bill or the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 that was passed in Parliament in September 2023, stipulates setting aside one third or 33% of the total seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies for women.

HT reported earlier that the government was working on de-linking the bill to provide 33% reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies from the ongoing census, and roll out the law from 2029 general elections. This will involve raising the number of seats in the legislatures by 50%. The

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

amendments could see the number of seats in the Lok Sabha increase to 816. Of this, 273 will be reserved for women, and the proportional representation of each state will remain the same. The number 816 is close to the 814.5 figure that can be arrived at by increasing the number of seats in the Lok Sabha, currently at 543, by 50%.

Last week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced that a special three-day sitting of Parliament from April 16 to 18 will fast-track the implementation of the bill, assuring southern states that their representation will not reduce.

The government has earlier conveyed to the Opposition that it intended to set up a delimitation commission by June.

FRAGILE CEASEFIRE

longer posed a significant threat to US forces or the region. The Iranian military said the country forced Israel and the US to accept its proposed conditions and surrender.

Much about the agreement was unclear as the sides presented vastly different versions of the terms.

Iran said the deal would allow it to formalize its new practice of charging ships passing through the strait, a crucial transit lane for oil. But the details were not clear, nor was it known whether vessels would feel safe using the channel or whether ship traffic had resumed. It also was unclear whether any other country agreed to this deal.

The White House said Trump is opposed to tolls for ship passage through the strait.

Pakistan and others said fighting would pause in Lebanon, where Israel has launched a ground invasion against the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group.

Israel said it would not, and strikes hit Beirut on Wednesday. The fate of Iran's missile and nuclear programmes — the elimination of which were major objectives for the US and Israel in the deal — remained unclear. Trump said the US would work with Iran to remove buried enriched uranium, though Iran did not confirm that.

In the streets of Tehran, pro-government demonstrators screamed: "Death to America, death to Israel, death to compromisers" after the ceasefire announcement and burned American and Israeli flags.

The chants underscored the

anger animating hard-liners, who have been preparing for what many assumed would be an apocalyptic battle with the United States. Trump warned Tuesday that "a whole civilization will die tonight, if a deal was not reached."

Trump initially said Iran proposed a "workable" 10-point plan that could help end the war the US and Israel launched on Feb. 28. But when a version emerged that indicated Iran would be allowed to continue enriching uranium — which is key to building a nuclear weapon — Trump called it fraudulent.

Vance later said the deal was being misrepresented within Iran, though he did not offer details. The White House said, Vance would lead the American negotiating team in talks in Islamabad starting Saturday aimed at finding a permanent end to the war.

US special envoy Steve Witkoff and Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner were also part of the talks.

According to Iranian state media reports, the Iranian delegation will be led by Speaker of Parliament Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, a central figure in Tehran's wartime leadership structure who has taken on strategic responsibilities since the early phase of the conflict.

Meanwhile, in a statement on X, Ghalibaf said that three key clauses of a 10-point proposal were violated before negotiations set to start on Friday in Pakistan, adding that in such a situation, the plan allows for both Iran and Oman to charge ships, according to a regional official who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss negotiations they were directly involved in. The official said Iran would use the money it raised for reconstruction.

That would upend decades of precedent treating the strait as an international waterway that was free to transit and will likely not be acceptable to the Gulf Arab states, which also need to rebuild after repeated Iranian attacks targeting their oil fields.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said passage through the strait would be allowed under Iranian military management, further clouding the picture of who would be allowed to transit the waterway.

News of the ceasefire sent stock markets surging worldwide, and oil prices plunged back toward \$80 per barrel.

to "utilize every operational opportunity" to strike Hezbollah. The Israeli military said it struck more than 100 targets within 10 minutes Wednesday across Lebanon, the largest wave of strikes since March.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun condemned the Israeli attacks as "barbaric." Arab League chief Ahmed Aboul Gheit accused Israel of "persistently seeking to sabotage" the Iran ceasefire deal.

Hezbollah has not confirmed if it will abide by the ceasefire, though the group has said it was open to giving mediators a chance to secure an agreement. An official, speaking on condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to comment publicly, said the group would not standing at Israel unless Israel agreed to do the same.

While Iran could not match the sophistication of U.S. and Israeli weaponry or their dominance in the air, its ability to control the Strait of Hormuz proved a tremendous strategic advantage. Iranian attacks and threats deterred many commercial ships from passing through the waterway, through which 20% of all traded oil and natural gas passes in peacetime.

That rolled the world economy and raised the pressure on Trump both at home and abroad to find a way out of the standoff.

The ceasefire may formalize a system of charging fees in the strait that Iran instituted — and gave a new source of revenue.

A short time later, the United Arab Emirates' air defenses fired at an incoming Iranian missile barrage. Kuwait said Wednesday three power and water desalination plants were badly damaged after 28 Iranian drones were launched at the country. Saudi Arabia said it intercepted nine drones. A UAE foreign ministry spokesman later said the country would seek clarifications on the terms of the ceasefire.

US-Israeli strikes have battered Iran and its leadership, but they have not entirely eliminated the threats posed by Tehran's nuclear program, its ballistic missiles or its support for regional proxies, like Hezbollah. The U.S. and Israel said addressing those threats was a key justification for going to war.

Trump said Wednesday that the U.S. would work with Iran to "dig up and remove" enriched uranium that was buried under joint U.S.-Israeli strikes in June. He added that the tone of the material had been touched since. Any retrieval is expected to be an intensive undertaking.

There was no confirmation from Iran.

Hezbollah told a Pentagon briefing Wednesday that the U.S. would do "something like" last June's joint strikes with Israel on Iranian nuclear sites if the country refuses to surrender its enriched uranium voluntarily.

Tehran insisted for years that its nuclear programme was peaceful, although it enriched uranium up to 60% purity, a short, technical step from weapons-grade levels.

Iran referred to its nuclear programme differently in two versions of the ceasefire plan that it released. The version in Farsi included the phrase "acceptance of enrichment" for its nuclear program. That phrase was missing in English versions shared with Iranian diplomats by journalists.

Shortly after the ceasefire announcement, Bahrain, Israel, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates all issued warnings about incoming missiles from Iran. That firestorm appeared to rest.

An earlier time, Iran's Lavan Island came under attack, according to Iranian state television. The state broadcaster reported that no one was hurt but did not say who launched the attack. The island is home to one of the terminals that Iran uses to export oil and gas.

A short time later, the United Arab Emirates' air defenses fired at an incoming Iranian missile barrage. Kuwait said Wednesday three power and water desalination plants were badly damaged after 28 Iranian drones were launched at the country. Saudi Arabia said it intercepted nine drones. A UAE foreign ministry spokesman later said the country would seek clarifications on the terms of the ceasefire.

TOP COURT ENDS 'MATRIMONIAL BATTLE OF MAHABHARATA'

Abraham Thomas
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: An acrimonious matrimonial battle between a couple that spanned across 80 cases for over a decade was given a quietus by the Supreme Court, which termed the marriage "dead" for all practical purposes and described the dispute as a "matrimonial battle of Mahabharata."

In its order passed on Tuesday, the court exercised its extraordinary — constitutional power under Article 142 to annul the marriage, grant payment of ₹5 crore to the wife and the two children as full and final settlement of all claims, while ordering closure of all pending litigation.

The bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said, "There is no doubt in the mind of this court that the marriage is dead for all practical purposes and this is a supremely fit case warranting exercise of jurisdiction under Article 142 of the Constitution of India, not only to annul the marriage, but to provide a quietus to this decade-long dispute which has crossed all limits and has assumed the status of a matrimonial battle of Mahabharata."

Commenting on the conduct of the husband, a lawyer, the bench said most proceedings appeared "vindictive and vengeful", indicating a "hostile, cantankerous and vindictive approach". The husband has been granted one year to pay ₹5 crore. The court directed that the husband should pay the full payment and restrained the husband from initiating further civil or criminal proceedings against her or her relatives.

The couple married in January 2010 and separated in October 2016. They have two sons. The legal proceedings began shortly after their separation.

Litigation escalated after the husband defaulted on interim maintenance of ₹1 lakh per month ordered by a family court.

"In our firm opinion, the actual sufferers would be the two minor sons," the court said. The court granted the wife custody of both sons, with visitation rights to the husband.

INLAND WATERWAYS AUTHORITY OF INDIA
Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways, Govt. of India
A-13, Sector-1, Noida - 201301 (U.P.)
Phone No. 0120-2312521

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tender No.: IWA/15012/2025-4
Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWA) invites online bids/tenders from experienced, registered contractors for O&M and Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (CAMC) of RIS Stations under Phase-II (Farakka to Patna) in NW-1. The details and tender document can be downloaded from 09.04.2025 to 30.04.2025 from our website www.iwaonline.in and CPPP Portal www.eprocure.gov.in. Last date for submission of online bids is 30.04.2025 up to 15:00 hrs and date of opening of tender is on 01.05.2025 at 15:30 hrs. Submission of online bids will be through www.eprocure.gov.in.
Hydrographic Chart

Hindustan Times
CHECK OUT TODAY'S EDITION

HT City
SPLITSVILLE FOR SANYA MALHOTRA AND RISHAB RIKHIRAM SHARMA

PPSCL Punjab State Power Corporation Limited
Regd. Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala-147001
Corporate Identity Number: U40109PB2010SGC033613
Website: www.ppscl.in
(Contact No. 96461-22185)

Tender Enquiry No. 377/SO-168/S-1/2026 Date: 07.04.2026
By: CE/Substation Design/TS Organization, C-1 Shakti Vihar, PPSCL, Patiala
Invites E-tender for manufacturing, testing and supply of 25 nos. 25/31.5 MVA 66/11KV Power Transformers. For detailed NIT & Tender Specification, please refer to <https://tenders.ppscl.gov.in> from 09.04.2026 (11:00 AM onwards).
Note: Correspondence and amendments, if any, will be published online at <https://tenders.ppscl.gov.in>
RQ No. 1079/12/2026/27/10276 C46926

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Online applications are invited for admission to the Full-Time/Part-Time Ph.D. programme in Engineering/Technology (CSE/ECE/IT), Management Studies, and Engineering Sciences. The last date for submitting the application is 20.04.2026. For more details and application forms, please visit the institute website: <https://www.iiitm.ac.in>. For any query, dial 0751-2449704/720 or email to phdadmission@iiitm.ac.in.
Joint Registrar (Academics)

Office of the Commandant Service and Supply Battalion
MHA/Government of India
Village- Saboli, PO:- Nathupura, Sonapat (Haryana) PIN-131029
Phone no. 011-20872506, FAX-011-20872507

Auction Notice Date- 17/.....
No. 1382
It is hereby notified for public information that the under mentioned unseizable and obsolete goods will be sold in Auction on "Where It Is As It Is" through sealed tender at the office of the Commandant, SS Battalion Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force, Saboli, Sonapat, Haryana.

Sl. No.	Description of Items	No. of Lots	Location	Date and time of auction
1.	Wooden Items	02	SS Battalion Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force, Saboli, Nathupura Sonapat, Haryana	17.04.2026 (10.00 AM and onwards)
2.	Clothing (Normal)	01		
3.	Clothing(EI)	01		
4.	Electrical and Electronics Items	01		
5.	Plastic Rubber, Tyre, Tubes ETC Items	02		
6.	Misc Items which is not covered in above	01		
7.	TENT Extendable	01		
8.	Ferrous Items	02		
9.	battery Items	01		
10.	Utensils Items	02		
11.	Glass Items	02		

Terms and condition for auction shall be as under:-
1. All the obsolete and unseizable store items shall be available for inspection on any working day from 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM from 13.04.2026 to 14.04.2026.
2. An amount of Rs. 5,000/- should be deposited through demand draft in favor of Commandant, SS Battalion Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force payable at SBI Narela Delhi on or before 16.04.2026 by the bidders as bid security amount.
3. An amount equal to 25% of bid value as "Earnest Money" in form of demand draft payable to the Commandant, SS Battalion Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force should be deposited Within 24 Hours DT.18.04.2026 at 1600 Hours completion of the auction process.
4. The balance amount of highest bid value should be deposited within 4 days i.e. 21.04.2026 and the delivery of the obsolete and unseizable store items should be taken within 04 days i.e. 21.04.2026.
5. If the successful highest bidder failed to deposit highest bid value, the bid security money will be forfeited.
6. The department reserves the right to withdraw or cancel the Auction if considered necessary without assigning any reasons.
Date of auction:- 17.04.2026 (10.00 AM and onwards)
Commandant
SS Battalion
Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force
CBC 1912/11/0002/627

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण, सी-2, सेक्टर-3, गुरुग्राम, हरियाणा-201308 (Haryana)
Toll Free No. 18001808296 वेबसाइट: www.yamunaxpresswayauthority.com

पत्रांक: आई.ई.ए.प्लेन/एच/377/2026 सार्वजनिक सूचना दिनांक: 08.04.2026

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा ग्राम भुनासवाली सैक्टर-34, 33, 11 व ग्राम चटवाली सैक्टर 13 व आकलन सैक्टर 10 के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि का सुविधायित विकास हेतु सम्बंधित कुचको द्वारा दी गयी सहमति की दर को 2008/- प्रविष्टिनीति से यमुना विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा सार्वजनिक सूचना 314/77-3-163पत्र, दिनांक 23.02.2016 में तय प्रक्रियानुसार निम्नानुसार क्रम विधि जांचा प्रस्तावित है:-

क्र.सं.	कार्यकार का नाम	खसरा संख्या	खसरे का क्षेत्रफल (हे.मै.)	कार्यकार का नाम	विस्तारानुसार क्षेत्रफल (हे.मै.)	अन्य विवरण
ग्राम भुनासवाली सैक्टर-34						
1.	रामचन्द्र पुत्र मोहन सिंह निधि ग्राम	42	105	0.3360	मैं से	0.0419
2.	जानेन्द्र शर्मा पुत्र सुरेश चन्द शर्मा निधि ग्राम पथोकरा	36	370	1.6730	मैं से	0.0650
3.	हेमराज पुत्र सोहन निधि ग्राम	17	338	1.0380	मैं से	0.0666
4.	वीरवती देवी पत्नी सरवन सिंह निधि ग्राम	17	338	1.0380	मैं से	0.0681
5.	धर्मपाल चर्च खमवाल पुत्र हुसली निधि ग्राम	84	354	0.1290	मैं से	0.0430
ग्राम भुनासवाली सैक्टर-33 व 11						
6.	रुचि गुप्ता पत्नी चण्ड गुप्ता निवासी गड 320, एच-30, गुरुग्राम	213	470	3.2720	मैं से	0.0630
7.	सिद्ध शर्मा, नमिष कुमार शर्मा, सिद्ध शर्मा पुत्रनगर अशोक शर्मा व रीता शर्मा पत्नी अशोक शर्मा निवासी मोहल्ला राधिका नगर, चण्डपुरा	196	182	0.9490	मैं से	0.0632
ग्राम चटवाली सैक्टर-13						
8.	श्रीमती शकुपल देवी पत्नी मोहन प्रकाश निवासी हीरा कोठी, सिकन्दरगढ़, बुलन्दशहर	480	878	0.8040	सम्पूर्ण	0.8040
9.	हंसराज सिंह पुत्र विजय सिंह निवासी गरिमा गार्डन, रासियाद, गुरुग्राम	408	55	0.6860	मैं से	0.0843
ग्राम आकलन सैक्टर-10						
10.	चरनवी पत्नी मोहन चन्द शर्मा निधि ग्राम	147	307	2.3520	मैं से	0.1178
11.	कुलदीप सिंह, कृष्ण पुत्रनगर प्रताप सिंह निधि ग्राम	128	309/2	1.1050	मैं से	0.0396
12.	प्रदीप सिंह माटी पुत्र जय सिंह माटी निधि ग्राम	152	293	4.2360	मैं से	0.1265
13.	प्रेमपाल सिंह पुत्र सुरलाल निधि ग्राम	152	293	4.2360	मैं से	0.0235

अतः उपरोक्त भूमि अग्र किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है, तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिनों के अंदर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण कार्यालय/सीआरएल से अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्यचिह्न/वप विस्तारिकारी
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिनियुक्त क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा प्रकृत मान्य पत्रान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/हाउसिंग/कोलोनी का किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अक्षय है। सामान्यतः इस प्रकार की खरीद-फरोकत के पूर्णतः संचयन से तथा औद्योगिक क्षेत्र के ग्राम विकास को बढ़ावा देना। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaxpresswayauthority.com देखें।

19th MIFF
MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL 2026
Documentary | Short Fiction | Animation
15 June - 21 June 2026

Last date of submissions
EXTENDED
Till 12 April 2026 by 11:30 PM (IST)
Last date for submission of hard copies of documents - 17 April 2026 by 05:30 PM (IST)

HIGHLIGHTS

- Golden Conch + ₹10 Lakhs for Best Documentary (International competition)
- ₹45 Lakhs total cash awards in various other categories
- Best Short Fiction Film
- Best Animation Film
- Best Debut Film
- Best Student Film
- Technical awards

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Website: miff.in
filmfreeway.com/MumbaiInternationalFilmFestival-MIFF

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Sumit Chandra : 9810980800

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Park Facing G-Block
316 sqd House
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C-8, VISHAL ENCLAVE, ND-27

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Vastu Perfect 12 mr Road

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Basement, G.Fir (20 Ft
Height) with Mezzanine,
First Fir & Open Terrace
Recently Re-Built
Super Area - 13,300 Sq Ft
Carpet Area - 8,000 Sq Ft
(Extendable to 9,600 Sq Ft)
Glass Exterior
Lift & Power Back-up
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ATER KAILASH - 1, 5, -27, Main road facing N Block Market 550 Sq. Yds. One BHK Elegantly Furnished Contact Owner 9810105720, 99985.2025

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PLOT NO: 87, SEC 155 (NORTA)

137-138, ECOTECH-1 EXTN. (GV)
PLOT NO: 87, SEC. 155 (NOIDA)
OWNER: 98111-04200
AME INDUSTRIAL Buildings 137-138, Ecotech 1 Ext, Gremo - 380000 sqft, Corner @ 28 psft (4) 87 / 355 Noide - 600000 sq ft, Corner @ 35 psft for IT / Industry. # 98111-04200 (Owner).

13

nt Authority
star Pradesh - 244 001

(Detail: 08/04/20)
Marketed through a Design-Build-
Contract is available on the E-Procurement
Development Authority's website
on or before 28/04/2020. Pre-bid
link: <https://www.geogix.com/procurement>
Users shall note that the response is
available on the E-Procurement Portal
(<http://www.mdemaradiah.com/in>)

For the corrigendum in
expression of previous

For the corrigendum in
pression of previous
sile, **TO BE READ AS**
Timing of Tender:-
14-2026, 11:00 Hrs.
Physical submission of
andatory Document
ed in clause 2.11.2:-
15-2026, 11:00 Hrs.
Timing of tender:-
15-2026, 16:00 hrs
will remain same. For
www.irops.gov.in

will remain same. For
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the Punjab and Haryana high court. "This was the only case in which he was yet to secure bail. The court considered the fact that there are 400-odd witnesses in the case and 900 accused people. As the trial is going to take some time, given his old age of 75 years, the court allowed bail to him," said Sheoran.

J&K LG SACKS TWO GOVT STAFF OVER TERROR LINKS

SRINAGAR/JAMMU: The Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) administration, led by Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, on Wednesday terminated the services of two more government employees for their alleged involvement in reviving terrorism and providing logistical support to proscribed outfits Hizbul Mujahideen and Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), officials said.

"These dismissals were executed under Article 31(2)(c) of the Constitution of India. This is part of the ongoing drive to root out terrorists embedded in the government machinery," an official said, requesting anonymity.

The two sacked employees have been identified as Farhat Ali Chaudry, a Class-IV employee in the education department in Ramban district, and Mohammad Shafi Dar, who worked as a Class-IV employee in the rural development department in Bandipora district, officials said. **HTC**

SC dismisses case against man who eloped with minor, later married her

Utkarsh Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Can the law step back when life moves on? Answering in the affirmative, the Supreme Court has quashed criminal proceedings against a man who eloped with a minor but later married her, saying continuation of the case would disrupt their "happy life".

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and NV Anjaria underscored that the ultimate aim of the justice system is to deliver substantive and meaningful justice, which may sometimes require discontinuing proceedings when circumstances so demand.

"Aim of all legal proceedings is to arrive at justice, a meaningful and substantive. In some cases, the justice is done by bringing home the outcome in accordance with law, whereas in some matters, the action in law would deserve to be halted soon

after the fact. This is the only case in which he was yet to secure bail. The court considered the fact that there are 400-odd witnesses in the case and 900 accused people. As the trial is going to take some time, given his old age of 75 years, the court allowed bail to him," said Sheoran.

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THE COURT SAID CONTINUATION OF THE CASE WOULD DISRUPT THE "HAPPY LIFE" OF THE COUPLE

and terminated...yielding to the legitimate demand of facts and warrant of circumstances," the bench noted in its judgment released on Tuesday.

The case arose from criminal charges against the man for eloping with a girl in 2020—an act that constitutes an offence under law. The minor's father got a criminal case registered under the charges of kidnapping and rape. However, during the course of time, the two married and have since been living together as husband and wife. After the Uttarakhand High Court refused to quash the charges against the man by an order

in 2025, the man and his wife filed a joint appeal in the top court.

Taking note of this subsequent development, the bench held that continuing the prosecution would not only be unnecessary but would also cause undue hardship to the couple.

"It may be true that fleeing with a girl who is minor is an offence under law. However, the subsequent development of marriage between the two lovers and the fact that they have been married living would outweigh the need to take the alleged offence or the criminal proceedings to their logical end. In the fact situation...continuation of criminal proceedings...would become harassing and stand as an abuse of process of law," said the bench.

It added that forcing the couple to undergo trial despite their settled marital life would amount to a "painful interference in their happy life".

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Scholars write to President over NCERT book ban

NEW DELHI: Amid the ongoing controversy over the now-withdrawn National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) Class 8 social science textbook featuring a chapter on the judiciary, more than 50 academicians and scholars have written to President Droupadi Murmu, alleging that the Supreme Court's ban amounts to "judicial overreach" that "encroaches upon academic freedom".

In a letter dated April 7, the 51 signatories urged the President to ask the education ministry to move the SC to withdraw the ban and waive the "harsh punishment" imposed on Prof Michel Danino, educationist Suparna Divakar and legal researcher Alok Prasanna Kumar.

Girl attempts suicide after stalker, 3 others assault father in MP

BHOPAL/SAGAR: A 14-year-old girl allegedly attempted to die by suicide after her father was assaulted by her stalker and three others for filing a police complaint against them in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district, police officers said on Wednesday.

The class 9 student set herself on fire at her house and was rushed to Bundelkhand Medical College and Hospital in Sagar in critical condition, a senior officer said, adding that the four accused, all minors, have been booked under relevant sections of the BNS as well as the SGT Act. In his police complaint, the girl's father said a 16-year-old boy from another village, 6 km away, had been harassing her for the last three months, frequently calling her despite being warned.

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E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <http://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

- 36/S.M.-Jal-IIV.E.T/2025-26**, Strengthening of Sewerage (P/L, Internal Sewer Line Sector-49 Connect to Deep Sewer Line in STP Sector-50B), Noida. Cost Rs. 498.35 Lacs.
- 37/S.M.-Jal-IIV.E.T/2025-26**, Emergency Work (M/o W/s (Replacement of Old Choked Water line, Water line Repair, Replacing Sluice/Reflex Valve, Repairing of Chamber etc. related Work in Sector-39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 50(B), 51, 51(B), 94, 96, 97, 98, 124, 125, 126, 127, 82, 92, 93, 93(A) & 93(B)), Noida. Cost Rs. 150.51 Lacs.
- 14/S.M.-JAL-O.A.J/2025-26**, O/M of Sewer line and MSPS/SPS at Expressway (Shifting of Deep Sewer Line due to Construction of Underpass at Changan 6.10 K.M. Near Sector-108, Noida Gr. Noida Expressway), Noida. Cost Rs. 182.75 Lacs.
- 15/S.M.-JAL-O.A.J/2025-26**, M/o of STP (Supply and fixing of Sluice gate with its related allied work for control to backflow from Hindon river to STPs Sector-123), Noida. Cost Rs. 160.71 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: 15.04.2026 upto 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: 16.04.2026 at 11.00 AM.

General Manager (Jal) Noida
Office: Sector-5
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

INLAND WATERWAYS AUTHORITY OF INDIA

(Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Government of India)
A-15, Sector-1, Noida - 201301 (U.P.) Tel: 9120-2646356 & 2674659

NOTICE

Date: 08.04.2026

Ref: Employment Notice No. IWA/17011/2020-Admin Dated 20.01.2026

With reference to the above, the last date of receipt of application for filling up of 01 vacant post of Deputy Director (Finance & Accounts) on deputation basis for a period of 03 years has been extended upto 4th May, 2026.

For further details as regards please visit IWA Website www.iwa.nic.in.

Sd/-
SECRETARY

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DPM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for and on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the undermentioned work:

Name of Work with its location	Outsourcing of PBI maintenance activity of 25 KV AC Traction system over DL-LHB area (PSUNUR, PSBPNP, PSUKODE) for a period of two years.
Approx. Cost of work	Rs.2,47,07,391.41/-
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.4,54,200/-
E-Tender Bid Online Submission period	15.04.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 30.04.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	30.04.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
Fund Allocation	07041032
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.irpsa.gov.in
E-Tender No.: 02-TRD-NDR-2026-27 Dated: 08.04.2026	11632026

Serving Customers With A Smile

MADHYA PRADESH RURAL ROAD DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

(AN AGENCY OF PANCHAYAT & RURAL DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVT. OF M.P.)
3rd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Arena Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)
(GST No. 23AAATM9054A3ZX)

DPR CONSULTANCY OF BRIDGES

(Short Time E-Procurement Notice)

No. 3482/22/D-12/Brg DPR/2026 Bhopal, Dated: 08.04.2026

Online Bids are invited from the reputed Consultants for preparation of DPR of Bridge under PMGSY as per details given below:

- No. of Packages - 22
- Nodal PU - Khandwa, Khargone, Dhar-1, Barwani, Ujjain, Shajapur, Gwalior, Chhindwara, Jabalpur, Narsinghpur, Pandhurna, Balaghat-1, Mandla, Narmadapuram, Betul, Bhopal, Sehore, Rewa & Satna.
- No. of Bridges - 198
- Total Estimated Construction Cost (in Rs.) - Rs. 6528000000.00

- Cost of Bid Document, Bid Security (EMD) and service charges as appearing on e-procurement portal are to be paid simultaneously through Debit Card/Credit Card/Internet Banking or system generated challan. For detailed procedure of online payment of EMD and submission of affidavit please refer document number 2 of detailed NIT.

- RFP document may be seen, downloaded and purchased from our e-procurement website <https://mptenders.gov.in> from 11:30 hrs. on 17.04.2026.
- Last date of Submission of bid is 11.05.2026 up to 13.00 hrs.

Other details & Conditions may be seen in the detailed NIT and Tender Document for preparation of DPR of Bridges under PMGSY April 2026 amended up to date on our Website <http://mptenders.gov.in>.

CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (Tender)
M.P., Madhyam/125268/2026

"सर्वी सदाक" एम प्रजननक क, पीपीएक सेक्टर राष्ट्रक विकास मे संपन्नो दो

राजस्थान राज्य भण्डार व्यवस्था निगम

संकेत: राज/भर/ई.निविदा/2026-27/165 दिनांक: 07/04/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या: 01/2026-27

निगम द्वारा विविध वर्ष 2026-27 में निम्नलिखित पर कार्य करे जाने वाले निगम कार्य हेतु उपर्युक्त नवी में पंजीकृत सेक्टरों के ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑन-लाइन निविदाएं आम संख्या 01 से 24 तक दिनांक 09.04.2026 को सायंको 5.00 बजे से दिनांक 29.04.2026 को सायंको 6.00 बजे तक ऑनलाइन ही एवं 8 दिनों के समान रूप से निम्नलिखित वेबसाइट पर www.eproc.rajsathan.gov.in, www.sppp.rajsathan.gov.in, www.agriculture.rajsathan.gov.in/rswc पर देना का संभव है।

UBN No.SWC627WLOB00002 से UBN No.SWC627WLOB000025 तक अतिरिक्त अभियन्ता राजस्थान/री/25/462

RAIL COACH FACTORY, KAPURTHALA

On behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Production, Rail Coach Factory Kapurthala is inviting open tenders through Indian Railways portal www.irpsa.gov.in for the under mentioned work on prescribed tender format.

A) Open E-Tender No.: RCF-KKH-DYCEEP-2026-27-01 **(B) Name of Work:** Procurement of Complete cable harness along with printing of Formulas for LHB Non-AC Coaches at RCF, Kapurthala. **(C) Place of Work:** Rail Coach Factory, Kapurthala. **(D) Approx. cost:** Rs. 14,99,821/- (Rs. Fourteen lakh ninety-nine thousand eight hundred twenty-one only) **(E) Cost of tender documents:** Free of cost **(F) Earnest Money:** Rs. 30,000/- (Rs. Thirty Thousand only). **(G) Quantity of Coaches:** 157 nos. **(H) Period of Completion:** 06 months **(I) Availability of Tender Documents for viewing & Downloading:** From 06.04.2026 (14:00 hrs) to 28.04.2026 (11:00 hrs) on website www.irpsa.gov.in **(J) Date & Time of closing of tender:** 28.04.2026 at 11:00 hrs. **(K) Date & Time of opening of tender:** 28.04.2026 at 12:00 hrs. **(L) Validity of Tender:** 1) 60 days from the date of opening of tender. 2) Participation by Association of Partnership (ACPP) Joint Venture (JV) firms are not allowed for this tender. 3) (a) Advance to contractor is not applicable. (b) Purchase preference clause is not applicable. (c) Price variation clause is not applicable. **(M) Website particulars:** www.irpsa.gov.in

Eligibility Criteria & Credentials: Eligibility Criteria & Credentials of Bidders for Apply/Installation including Handling, Testing, Commissioning of Ready-made Cable Harness in LHB AC/ Non AC Coach Variants and Other special Coaches at RCF. The following eligibility criteria including Credentials of Apply/Installation, Testing, Commissioning of Ready-made Cable Harness(es) in LHB AC/ Non AC Coach Variants & Other special Coaches being manufactured at RCF, shall be applicable. **(1) Similar Nature of Work:** (Not Applicable) **(2) Technical Eligibility Criteria:** (Not Applicable) **(3) Special Technical Criteria:** (a) Class 'A' Electrical Licence: Bidder shall have valid Class 'A' Electrical Licence by the Competent Authority. **(4) Financial Eligibility Criteria:** (Not Applicable) **(5) Deployment of Staff Qualification & Experience:** The Bidder shall ensure deployment of only Trained/Skilled Persons having minimum Qualification of ITI in Electrical/ Electronics with minimum experience of 05 Years or 10th pass with 08 years experience for working in the any type of Rolling stock as above. Bidder shall also depute at least 01 Supervisor having qualification Diploma/ Degree in Electrical/ Electronics with at least 04 years of experience for degree holder and at least 03 year experience for diploma holder in the same field. The Bidder shall deploy adequately trained/ experienced person ONLY for execution of the Electrical Coach Work, who are well versed with the all related Code Provisions/ Safe Working Instructions, all Work related activities including Stage/ Final Testing & Commissioning while working on 750/415 VAC/ 110V AC/DC etc. Coach Electrical System/Equipments, its inter connections/ end terminations, associated electrical circuits, trouble shooting etc. and the same shall be followed strictly & satisfactorily without any violation.

Note: (1) for submission of electronic offer, bidders will have to get themselves registered one time on irpsa.gov.in online without any payment. (2) Bidder are required to obtain the class III digital signature certificate with company name from certifying authorities, as per the list available on website irpsa.gov.in (3) Helpdesk details: helpdesk.irpsa@cris.gov.in in Phone -011-23370704, 24102655 (4) The tender notice is also available on web-site www.rcf.indianrailways.gov.in **Dy. CEE/EP**

T. No.: 003-M/2026-27 Dated: 08.04.2026

FIROZABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION (FMC)

(UTTAR PRADESH, INDIA)

Letter No: 38 /NNF/2026-27 Date: 08-04-2026

Re-NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

Municipal Commissioner, Municipal Corporation, Firozabad invites online bids from interested Bidders for the "Selection of an Agency for Operation and Maintenance of Atal Bihari Vajpayee Park in Firozabad." The details of Submission of eBids are available in the RFP document uploaded on the up tender Portal E-tendering portal <http://etender.up.nic.in>. Municipal Corporation reserves the right to cancel any of all the eBids and cancel the Bidding process without assigning any reason thereof. The work mentioned below through e-Procurement in conformity with the terms and conditions of this advertisement and the detailed tender call notice in two Bid systems (Part-1 Technical Bid and Part-1 financial Bid/Price Bid) from intending bidders fulfilling the eligibility criteria mentioned in The RFP. Interested Bidders can participate in the bidding after registering them on E-tendering portal <http://etender.up.nic.in>. Bidder can submitted There Bid in <http://etender.up.nic.in> after paying the tender fee as mention below and RFP document through online payment in the name of Municipal Corporation Firozabad, Bank Name- Punjab National Bank. Account No. 03822011009820, IFSC- PUNB0038210 Bidder will have to upload the scanned copy of transaction slip along with technical bid and Financial bid, failing this: the Bid is liable to be rejected. The Bidder should deposit the Earnest Money online in above mentioned account number or through FDR from a Nationalized/scheduled Bank pledged in favor of Executive Engineer, Municipal Corporation Firozabad. The scanned copy of the transaction slip must be uploaded along with technical bid. The bidders should have necessary Portal enrollment (Digital Signature Certificate) under e-procurement process of Govt. of Uttar Pradesh in required class/category.

S.No	Name of the Work	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.)	Tender fee with GST @ 18%
1	Selection of an Agency for Operation and Maintenance of Atal Bihari Vajpayee Park in Firozabad	55,000.00	5,900.00

Time schedule for Bidding:-

S. No	Description	Critical Dates
1	Upload/Publish of RFP	09-04-2026
2	Bid start Date of RFP	09-04-2026
3	Pre-Bid Meeting/Time	17-04-2026 (12:00 PM)
4	Bid Closing Date/Time of RFP	27-04-2026 (02:00 PM)
5	Technical Bid Opening Date/Time	27-04-2026 (04:00 PM)
6	Financial Bid Opening Date/Time	To be notified

- Other details can be seen on website <http://etender.up.nic.in> (for view, download and bidding).
- Subsequent corrigendum, if required, shall appear in these websites.
- Authority reserves the right to reject any or all the tenders without assigning any reasons Contractor who wants to participate in bid must registered themselves on <http://etender.up.nic.in>
- For any other queries, please contact Executive Engineer, Nagar Nigam Firozabad, Also, for further queries, the bidders are advised to send an email to: nagamnigamfz@gmail.com.

Executive Engineer
Nagar Nigam Firozabad



OPINION

The
Hindustan Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

[OUR TAKE]

Learnings from war in West Asia

It offers sobering lessons about the futility of waging conventional battles. For India, it's time to audit energy security and resources

Whether the ceasefire between US-Israel and Iran holds is something beyond the control of anyone other than the three countries directly involved, but there are learnings from the war for those willing to learn — which means any such analysis must perforce exclude Iran and Israel, both of whose positions have remained unchanged over decades. And the starting point for any such analysis must be the acceptance that the ceasefire will likely result, not in an enduring peace but an uneasy détente, courtesy the hard positions of Iran and Israel, and the mercurial nature of US President Donald Trump and, thereby, the sobering influence of the US as a superpower.

For the US (and the world), the war is a lesson that a confrontation using conventional (but modern) weapons, with a reasonably strong opponent is unlikely to end quickly, if it is likely to end at all (as the Ukraine-Russia conflict has shown; it is now in its fifth year). Democracies, unlike authoritarian regimes, will always face higher costs of being involved in such conflicts. This despite the obvious asymmetry between the two sides — the US is the world's richest and largest economy, and has the world's most powerful military. It's the kind of epiphany that should prevent future wars, but geopolitics doesn't work that way. Still, President Trump's attention will soon move to matters domestic, primarily the mid-terms, and that is good for the world.

There are significant learnings for India as well. While many commentators will focus on those in the realm of foreign policy (where there are lessons), the more pressing ones are those related to energy and supply-chain security. The after-effects of the war (should the ceasefire last) will result in at least a full percentage point, perhaps a bit more, being shaved off India's growth rate for 2026-27, something the country can ill-afford. One of the main reasons for this is India's dependence on imported energy and petrochemical inputs. This is a good time for the country's political leadership to review progress specifically in four areas: Coal gasification; green hydrogen; renewables; and strategic reserves (in oil and gas). India has ambitious programmes in all four, but barring renewables, it has made little progress. It's time to ask why — and hold those responsible to account.

Unless this is done, the next crisis — and there will be one — will see a similar shock to the system.

Drawing a distinction between religion & law

There are two aspects of note in the Centre's submission to the Supreme Court, which has set up a nine-judge bench to hear pleas asking for a review of a landmark 2018 verdict that allowed women of all ages to enter the Sabarimala shrine in Kerala. One

Together, we shall advance Nari Shakti

Women's reservation in legislatures affirms a principle that has guided our civilisational ethos — that society progresses when women progress

In the coming days, India will be immersed in a festive season, with celebrations taking place across the length and breadth of the nation. The people of Assam will mark Bongaal Bihu while Odisha will celebrate Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti. In West Bengal, Poila Boishakh will usher in the Bengali New Year and in Kerala, Vishu will be observed with immense enthusiasm. In Tamil Nadu, Puthandu (new year) will be celebrated while in Punjab and other parts of Northern India, it will be Baisakhi, which will usher in a spirit of hope as well as positivity. I convey my best wishes to all those across India and the world who are marking these festivals. May these auspicious occasions bring happiness and prosperity to everyone's lives. Furthermore, on April 11, we will commence the 200th birth anniversary celebrations of Mahatma Phule and on April 14, India will pay homage to Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar on Ambedkar Jayanti.

In addition to these special occasions, when the spirit of renewal fills our hearts and minds, our nation stands at the threshold of another historic occasion. It is an opportunity to

deepen the foundations of our democracy and to reaffirm our collective commitment to equality and inclusion.

On April 16, Parliament will be convened to discuss and pass an important bill that advances women's reservation. To describe this merely as a legislative exercise would be an understatement. It is a reflection of the aspirations of

and decision-making, they bring with them experiences and insights that enrich public discourse and improve the quality of governance.

It is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and the Assembly elections to the various states in the coming times are conducted with women's reservation in place. Over the decades, there have been repeated efforts to



Narendra Modi

provide women with their rightful place in democratic institutions. Committees were made, bill drafts were introduced but they never saw the light of day. But the broad consensus has remained that women's representation in legislative bodies has to increase. In September 2023, Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam with the same spirit of consensus. I consider it to be among the most special occasions of my life.

This opportunity to ensure women's reservation also resonates deeply with the spirit of our Constitution. The makers of our Constitution envisioned a society where equality is both enshrined and realised in practice. Strengthening women's participation in legislative institutions is an important step towards fulfilling that vision. It reflects our commitment to building a society where every citizen has an equal stake in shaping the nation's destiny.

This is a moment that cannot be deferred any longer. Every delay in advancing women's representation is, in effect, a delay in strengthening the



When women participate in administration and decision-making, they bring with them experiences and insights that enrich public discourse.

quality and inclusiveness of our democracy. For decades, the need for greater participation of women in legislative institutions has been acknowledged, discussed, and reaffirmed. To postpone action now would mean extending an imbalance that we already recognise and have the capacity to correct. At a time when India is moving forward with confidence and purpose, it is essential that our institutions reflect the aspirations of all citizens, especially those who form half our population. Timely action will not only honour long-standing commitments but also ensure that the momentum of progress is sustained. This is truly a historic opportunity to make our democracy more representative, responsive and future-ready.

This moment calls for collective action. It is not about any one government, party or individual. It is about the nation as a whole recognising the importance of this step and coming together to realise it. It is what we owe to our Nari Shakti. That is why the passage of a bill for women's reservation

should reflect the broadest possible consensus and be guided by the larger national interest. Such opportunities call upon us to act not for ourselves, but for future generations. They remind us that the true strength of a democracy lies in its ability to evolve and to become more inclusive over time.

As we approach this historic Parliament sitting, I appeal to all Members of Parliament, across party lines, to come together in support of this important step for the women of India. Let us seize this opportunity with a sense of responsibility and purpose. Let us act in a manner that reflects the highest traditions of our democracy. India has always shown that when it comes to matters of national importance, it can rise above differences and act with unity. This is one such moment. Let us move forward together and strengthen Constitutional values and empower our Nari Shakti for national progress.

Narendra Modi is Prime Minister of India

[GRAND STRATEGY]
Happymon Jacob



The telling pause in the US-Israel war on Iran

Washington entered the war against Iran as the clear favourite. It has now paused the war, offering lessons for everyone in how not to fight a war. Of course, Iran couldn't defeat the US militarily. It only needed to survive, on its own terms. And it did, visibly and defiantly for 39 days, against the world's lone superpower. In such a war, survival alone would have been victory. But Iran managed something more than mere survival. It walked away with its Strait of Hormuz card still in hand, its regime intact, and its own 10-point framework on the negotiating table as the agenda for the next two weeks. Tehran has also amply demonstrated the limits of American military power and the sustainability of Washington's political resolve.

Read it alongside the US withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021 — two moments, five years apart, in which the world's most powerful military walked back from a war it could not win, let alone finish honourably. It took 17 years the last time, and it took 39 days this time.

To be fair: Washington's failure must be measured against its own stated aims. Obliterate Iran's ballistic missile capability, anni-

merce is Iran's. Iran's Hormuz card is set to define the future of West Asia's geopolitics in unprecedented ways.

Lastly, consider the optics. In international politics, optics are not separate from outcomes; they shape outcomes. The moment a dominant power agrees to talks with an underdog in the middle of a war, the stars begin aligning in the underdog's favour. That powerful image will stay on in the minds of America's friends and partners alike.

What does the ceasefire imply for regional actors? For Israel, Prime Minister Netanyahu wanted to use American firepower to permanently neutralise Iran. With the US stepping back, that objective will be unmet. If the world's most powerful military could not break Iran in 39 days, Tel Aviv is in no position to succeed where Washington failed. What's worse, Israel now knows something it did not know before this war with the same disturbing clarity, that its own territory is not safe for, after all, Iranian missiles did reach Israeli soil.

The Gulf States too have come out of this war deeply worried. Consider this: Iran, with whom none of them have a warm relationship with, is now the region's most pre-

[JD VANCE] VICE PRESIDENT, UNITED STATES

If the Iranians are willing in good faith to work with us, I think we can make an agreement



Many owners of the West Asia ceasefire

Everybody is claiming victory in West Asia. President Donald Trump has done so repeatedly, and Iran was shouting defiance every time it fired a missile. Pakistan's Prime Minister (PM) Shahbaz Sharif's picture is being flashed everywhere; the media in Islamabad reported all night about the talks between Field Marshal Asim Munir and US and Iranian officials. Trump now acknowledges that China was an important mediator. Beijing however remains silent.

Let's look at the facts. Trump has declared that all military objectives were accomplished. Satellite imagery analysis does show considerable destruction of key Iranian facilities such as the Khajir Missile complex out-

side Tehran. Pakistan's missile was shot down, for a charge of \$2 million per ship for reconstruction. Surprisingly, Trump's latest offer is to help unblock the Strait, so that Iran can start reconstruction. However, upstream States are unlikely to agree tamely to this levy over international waters. But in the public sphere, an underdog stood up to the most powerful country ever. That's the stuff of 'victory'. The reality, however, is that a long hard climb lies ahead. Whoever heads the present regime has an unenviable task.

Pakistan has had a risky run. First held up as the country that brokered a ceasefire, it seems now to have been only a front. A reliable account reported mistakes in a tweet ostensibly from PM Sharif, which says, "Draft: Pakistan PM's message on X" calling for cooperation in the ceasefire. The tweet

the Centre has argued that questions of who may enter a place of worship are not facets of gender discrimination but are rooted in religious practice, belief and the specific character of the deity. The submissions caution the bench against adopting standards of review that assess religious practices on grounds such as "rationality," "modernity," or "scientific defensibility". The fact is many discriminatory practices — notoriously those related to caste bias and untouchability — emanate from a warped reading of scriptures. The court will have to be cautious in allowing leeway to religious practices that threaten to breach legal guidelines.

Two, the government has urged the bench to declare that the law and reasoning in the 2018 *Joseph Shine* judgment, which struck down the offence of adultery, are not good law. Worryingly, the Centre has contended that the 2018 ruling rested on an overbroad and subjective application of "constitutional morality". The 2018 judgment was significant because it drew clear boundaries around a private act that had been criminalised owing to an overhang of colonial morality from the Victorian era. Flowing from the landmark verdict in 2017 that upheld the constitutional right to privacy, the decriminalisation of adultery removed the government from the bedroom and drew a distinction between social and constitutional morality.

The concept of constitutional morality underpins not just the *Joseph Shine* judgment but also a whole host of other milestone verdicts, including the 2018 decriminalisation of homosexuality. In pushing to overturn this judgment and assail against constitutional morality, the government is unfortunately exhibiting the same instincts as India's formerly colonial masters — instincts that have no place in a mature republic.

THIRTY-NINE DAYS, SEVEN IS SUPPORTING FOR proxy networks, and ensure it never acquires a nuclear weapon. Thirty-nine days later, the regime is mostly intact, the military is severely damaged but far from obliterated, and Iran's nuclear programme is still in play. Iran gave no quarter, yielded to no ultimatum, and paused this war to fight another day, if need be. On March 6, US President Donald Trump posted on social media: "There will be no deal with Iran except unconditional surrender." It took him just two days to reverse that. Of course, Trump was bluffing: but if you use a bluff for too long, it becomes a joke.

Does Washington have any friends now? At a White House press conference, Trump answered it himself: "Japan didn't help us. Australia didn't help us. South Korea didn't help us." He called NATO a "paper tiger". Not too long ago, in March, he had boasted he needed no one's help; by April, he had no one. Washington must not have felt this lonely since the end of World War II.

Remember what Iran looked like on the eve of Operation Epic Fury? A regime shaken to its roots by the largest protests since 1979, its economy crippled by sanctions, its proxies hollowed out by years of Israeli strikes, and its neighbours growing steadily more confident in its decline.

The war has undue most of it. Nothing consolidates a regime like a common enemy. The reforms that Iranian protesters demanded now seem a distant prospect. Trump's war may have strengthened the Iranian regime more than Ayatollah Ali Khamenei could have wished for.

Then, there is Hormuz. Before this war, Hormuz was a hypothetical Iranian threat. Today, Hormuz is Iran's trump card — to play in negotiations, to leverage for sanctions relief, to brandish against future attacks, and to remind the world that the most important chokepoint in global com-

merce, must remain under Iranian control while invariably focus on strengthening itself militarily for years to come.

Washington's security assurances, mostly assumed but never tested at this scale, have been found wanting. Reconciliation with Israel, already complicated by Gaza, is now further out of reach after a war fought in their neighbourhood. And the Arabian dreams they built in the desert, the gleaming cities, the Vision 2020s, the careful hedging between great powers, now sit under the shadow of doubt.

They are, in the most uncomfortable sense, friendless in a dangerous neighbourhood being unable to fully trust Washington, unable to afford Tehran's ire, and unable to make peace with Tel Aviv. And their streets are watching.

If there is one country that must have watched this war carefully and drawn lessons, that would be China. Iran fought the war, and China has drawn its lessons. This is what Beijing's strategists would think today: If Washington's resolve has limits against an outgunned, sanctioned, struggling middle power, those limits are unlikely to expand against a peer competitor with whom each of America's allies have deep economic linkages with. Beijing has every reason to be more confident today vis-à-vis Washington than before the Iran war.

This is why the ceasefire matters beyond its terms, beyond the fate of Tehran's nuclear programme or the future of the Strait of Hormuz. The Iran war will be studied, cited, and remembered for generations to come by scholars and policymakers alike. The next time Washington issues an ultimatum, to anyone, the ghost of Tehran will linger in the room.

Happinessom is a distinguished visiting professor, School of Humanities & Social Sciences, Shiv Nadar University, and editor, INDIA'S WORLD magazine. The views expressed are personal

indeed, reduced significantly. Tehran's key enrichment plant, Fordow, was almost destroyed in June, with highly sensitive centrifuges damaged. Restarting these will require huge resources, difficult after Operation Epic Fury. Though there is no sign of the 440 kg of enriched uranium up to 60%, bringing this up to weapons-grade level will require those centrifuges to function. Other sites like Isfahan are also a pile of rubble.

So at one level, mission accomplished. The US motto of "I do as I will" remains unchanged. That matters, as Trump travels to China. And the defence department is going to ask for the largest defence budget rise in history of \$1.5 trillion. That matters too. It's big money for everyone.

Israel has got much of what it wanted. Tel Aviv has expressed support for the ceasefire "as long as Iran no longer poses a nuclear, missile and terror threat" to it. That's an important caveat. Meanwhile, Israel has won in terms of a new united neighbourhood that wants Tehran's war-waging capability erased. Peaceful sheikdoms have faced violence and damage to infrastructure. Key players including Saudi Arabia will now move towards connectivity across West Asia, including the IMEC (India Middle East Economic Corridor). The map of the region has been changed almost irrevocably. That's huge. Israel also leaves itself free to hit Lebanon. Either issue could wreck the ceasefire.

Iran's win is the strangest. From offering "zero stockpiling" and complete international inspection of its nuclear programme in February, it is now demanding acceptance of its right to enrich. As a member of the NPT (Non Proliferation Treaty) it may legally do so. It also now has effective control over the Strait of Hormuz, which it did not before. It has smartly offered to share levies with

its oil customers in the meantime to the US, and cooperation from "Iranian brothers". True, PMs don't usually operate their own accounts, but a foreign office staffer would hardly refer to his own PM in such words. It's a give away that the message was drafted outside the country. But Islamabad did hold talks with Egypt, Turkey and Saudi Arabia, and perhaps, US vice president JD Vance. The possibility that the tweet was drafted by Vance's team remains, or equally, by the Chinese.

Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi reportedly made 26 calls to parties, and vetoed a UN resolution by the Gulf States to allow armed escorts for shipping. President Trump also acknowledged Beijing's vital role. China is now in the driver's seat. Though it backs Islamabad's hosting of the first ceasefire delegation, Beijing will probably not attend the meeting. Negotiations may yet backfire, and China is not going to risk that.

Meanwhile, Islamabad will quite justifiably cash in, with its admirable narrative building glossing over its inability to honour its commitment to the mutual defence agreement with Riyadh.

Meanwhile, there is relief, including in India, which is struggling with energy issues.

There are risks ahead. Wartime leaders rarely make it to peace. More than one leader will have to watch his back, and that itself may be an impediment to peace. Besides, war is so much more profitable for weapons manufacturers and oil majors. Peace will come only when everybody wins. That needs skilled business diplomacy, and that's where Delhi needs to weigh in.

Tara Kartha is a former director, National Security Council Secretariat. The views expressed are personal

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Hindustan Times

WORLD

17

How Trump went from threatening Iran's annihilation to surprise truce

Associated Press

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump over the course of a day went from threatening Iran with "annihilation" to proclaiming that the battered Islamic Republic's leadership had presented a "workable" plan that led him to agree to a 14-day ceasefire that he expects to pave the way to end the nearly six-week-old war.

The dramatic shift in tenor came as intermediaries led by Pakistan worked feverishly to head off a further escalation. Even China, Iran's biggest trading partner and America's most significant economic competitor, quietly pulled strings to find a path toward a ceasefire, according to two officials briefed on the matter.

Controlling the strait

As Trump boasted about US and Iranian military success over the last six weeks, he appeared to be working from the premise that he could bomb Iran into capitulation.

Starting with the killing of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in the opening salvo of the war, he seemed to discount that the Iranian leadership could opt for a long, bloody war. The Islamic Republic over the last 47 years has repeatedly shown it's willing to die in, even when it appears to America they're working against their own self-interest.

The clerical leadership held Americans hostages for 444 days, from late 1979 to early 1981, at the cost of the country's international standing. The mullahs allowed the ruins Iran-Iraq war to go on for years, leaving hundreds of thousands dead. It stood by Hamas after the October 7 attack that spurred a war with Israel that would defang the Iran-backed group in Gaza as well as Hezbollah in Lebanon, and created the conditions that led to the collapse of Tehran-backed Bashar Assad's authoritarian rule in Syria.

Iran's leadership — battered and outgunned — evaded confidence that it could very well bog down the world's superpower in a

DAY 40 Israel hits Lebanon, hundreds killed

Israeli airstrikes on Hezbollah group killed hundreds in Lebanon despite Iran, the US and Israel agreeing to a two-week ceasefire

ATTACKS BY IRAN, ALLIES

- 1 **ISRAEL** Cluster munition impacts in several areas across central part of the country
- 2 **IRAQ** Five explosions heard in the centre of Baghdad
- 3 **KUWAIT** Drones target oil and power facilities
- 4 **BAHRAIN** Drone attack injures two citizens
- 5 **QATAR** Falling debris from an Iranian missile attack hurt four people, including a child
- 6 **UAE** Drone/missile debris fell on Habshan gas complex in Abu Dhabi leading to fire; two Emiratis and an Indian suffered injuries due to falling debris from an interception of an attack in Abu Dhabi
- 7 **SAUDI ARABIA** Oil facilities in port city Yanbu targeted; East-West pipeline comes under drone attack

ATTACKS BY U.S., ISRAEL

- 1 **LEBANON** Series of Israeli airstrikes hit several neighbourhoods in Beirut
- 2 **URMIA** Heavy airstrikes
- 3 **MAHABAD** Airstrikes
- 4 **ALBORB PROVINCE** Bridge on the Kharraz highway targeted
- 5 **TEHRAN** Heavy airstrikes
- 6 **ARAK** Iranian Aluminium Company plant bombed
- 7 **MAHNAHR** Petrochemical complex attacked
- 8 **LAVAN ISLAND** Oil refinery targeted
- 9 **KISH ISLAND** Airstrikes



SAUDI ARABIA'S KEY EAST-WEST PIPELINE ATTACKED BY DRONE

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com

RIYADH: A key Saudi oil pipeline to the Red Sea was hit in a drone attack hours after a ceasefire in the war in the Middle East, according to a person familiar with the matter.

A pumping station along the route was targeted, and the damage is still being assessed, the person said, asking not to be identified because the details are not public. Saudi Arabia declined to comment.

The East-West pipeline has served as a vital lifeline, getting oil from Saudi Arabia's vast fields along the Persian Gulf to the port of Yanbu on the western Red Sea coast, effectively bypassing the largely closed Strait of Hormuz. The kingdom has cranked up flows through the link to full capacity, allowing close to 5 million barrels a day to be exported, or about 70% of total prewar levels.

The attack was first reported by the FT.

The hit to the pipeline's infrastructure comes the same day the US, Israel and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire in their war.

But there were reports of sporadic attacks across the region on Wednesday.



A woman walks next to an anti-Israeli mural in Tehran. REUTERS

Months-long Israel campaign led US to order strikes on Iran

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu pressed the United States for months to strike Iran before the Donald Trump administration finally agreed in the last week of February, The New York Times (NYT) reported.

On February 17, Netanyahu and Mousadid chief David Barnea met President Trump and senior US officials in the White House Situation Room.

According to the report, those present included chief of staff Susie Wiles, secretary of state and national security adviser Marco Rubio, defence secretary Pete Hegseth, Joint Chiefs chairman General Dan Caine, CIA director John Ratcliffe, along with Jared Kushner and special envoy Steve Witkoff, who had been negotiating with Iran. Vice President JD Vance was absent, travelling in Azerbaijan.

At the meeting, Netanyahu argued that Iran was ripe for regime change and said a "joint US-Israeli mission could finally bring an end to the Islamic Republic".

At one point, the Israelis played for Trump a short video that included a montage of potential new leaders who could take over the country if the government fell.

Among those featured in the video was Reza Pahlavi, the exiled son of Iran's last shah,

Hormuz, and the likelihood that Iran would land blows against US interests in neighbouring countries was assessed as minimal, NYT reported.

"Sounds good to me," Trump said, signalling what Netanyahu interpreted as a likely green light for joint action, the report said.

'Farical, bullshit'

The following day, US intelligence officials assessed Netanyahu's proposal in a separate Situation Room meeting. They broke it down into four elements: decapitation — killing Ayatollah Ali Khamenei; crippling Iran's regional power; triggering a popular uprising; and installing a secular leadership.

When Trump joined the meeting, Ratcliffe described the regime change scenario as "farical". Rubio was more blunt: "In other words, it's bullshit."

Vance, back from Azerbaijan, voiced strong scepticism, warning that a war with Iran would be "a huge distraction of resources" and "massively expensive", according to the NYT.

The go ahead

A final Situation Room meeting was held on February 26 at around 5pm, attended by Vance, Wiles, Ratcliffe, General Caine, Hegseth and Rubio.

Opening the meeting, Trump asked: "OK, what have we got?" Vance reiterated his opposition but added: "If you want to

Trump's Iran war leaves US looking weakened, bolstering China, Russia

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: The ceasefire in Iran has reinforced views among both adversaries and the Nato alliance that President Donald Trump's campaign against the Tehran regime marks a strategic setback, bolstering China and Rus-



It remains unclear to what extent the war has diminished Iran's nuclear programme and its leaders may have been incentivised to renew their ambitions to get the bomb, according to European diplomats.

One key unknown is the influence Tehran will be able to exert over the strait longer-term, one of

regimes and swiftly win wars, but that notion had been dispelled by the Middle East conflict, another official said.

More broadly, Trump's threat to destroy Iran's civilisation will make it harder for the US to paint itself as a benign hegemon, in contrast to Russia and China, which the West routinely accuses of war

costly, extended conflict even if it might not defeat a mighty US military.

Defence analysts largely agreed that the US military could quickly take control of the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow Persian Gulf waterway between Iran and Oman through which roughly 20% of the world's oil flows on any given day. But maintaining security over the waterway would require a high-risk, resource-intensive operation that could be a years-long American commitment.

Ben Connable, executive director of the non-profit Battle Research Group, said securing the strait would require the US military to maintain control of about 600 kilometres of Iranian territory, from Kish Island in the West to Bandar Abbas in the East, to stop Iran from firing missiles at ships passing through the strait.

We expect, in the coming days and weeks, that it [ceasefire] will be fully respected throughout the region and will allow negotiations to take place.

Emmanuel Macron,
French President

that bombing campaign against Iran within two weeks — only to have the president order airstrikes that he said “obliterated” Iran’s nuclear program before that interval was up.

Trump has also repeatedly used two weeks to set deadlines that ultimately led to very little during negotiations to end Russia’s war with Ukraine and even going back to his first term, suggesting he’d have major policy issues like health care solved over such a timeframe.

Trump has repeatedly made maximalist demands throughout the first 15 months of his second White House term only to dial them back.

The president backed off many of the sweeping “Liberation Day” tariffs he first announced in April 2025 after they caused the financial markets to go haywire.

I welcome with satisfaction, and as a sign of real hope, the announcement of an immediate two-week truce. Only by returning to negotiations can we reach the end of the war.

Pope Leo,
Catholic Church leader



Moon crew, ISS astronauts speak on first space call

WASHINGTON: NASA’s Artemis II moon mission crew spoke briefly with the astronauts living and working on the International Space Station (ISS) Tuesday afternoon, the first call of its kind in the history of spaceflight.

At around 2:40pm New York time, the two crews connected during an audio call and spoke about what it was like for the Artemis crew to launch and then fly around the moon.

BLOOMBERG

'Afghanistan and Pakistan agree to avoid escalation'

BEIJING: Pakistan and Afghanistan have agreed to avoid any escalation in their armed conflict, during talks hosted by China in recent days,

Beijing said on Wednesday. Hostilities escalated sharply at the end of February, when Pakistani airstrikes were followed by an Afghan ground offensive, with Islamabad declaring an “open war”.

AFP

France planning \$39bn boost to rearmament

PARIS: France plans to add a further €36 billion (\$39 billion) to its defence spending between now and 2030 under an updated military planning law that expands its nuclear arsenal and boosts missile and drone stocks. The increase, proposed despite one of the euro zone’s biggest budget deficits, reflects mounting security pressures from wars in Ukraine and West Asia and growing uncertainty over US commitments to NATO under President Donald Trump.

REUTERS

sia while squandering American strengths, according to people familiar with the thinking across capitals in Europe and the Middle East.

While Moscow and Beijing fear US military and intelligence superiority, they have seen it couldn’t force Iran’s capitulation, the people said. The tensions in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, which culminated in Trump threatening to leave the alliance, have left doubting over his commitment to its defence.

The two-week ceasefire, mediated by Pakistan, will also dent Trump’s credibility as a negotiator and likely further deter Russian President Vladimir Putin from making concessions in Ukraine, according to the people, who were granted anonymity to speak candidly about their assessments of the war conducted by the ally.

“Although Iran has suffered huge physical damage and much loss of life, it emerges strategically stronger,” former UK national security adviser Peter Ricketts said. “The regime has survived. It has shown the massive leverage control of Hormuz gives them.”

Officials in Europe cautioned that the terms of any lasting ceasefire had yet to be agreed, though they expressed concern that Iran may end up viewed as the strategic winner despite the killing of



Donald Trump departs after speaking with reporters at the White House in Washington, AP

Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and more than five weeks of heavy bombardment by the US and Israel.

“It’s certainly not a victory in that the United States has nowhere achieved any of its military objectives,” Long Island University Director of International Relations Dalia Fahmy told Bloomberg TV. “Actually, the war has cost the United States much more than anticipated.”

More headline

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps remains in place, and could likely become more hardline and quickly rebuild its missile programme, the people said. Tehran will have concluded that its drone capabilities are sufficient to cause significant problems for Gulf states and seen confirmation that its leverage over the Strait of Hormuz is capable of triggering a global energy crisis that may deter any future attack.

the officials said, noting with trepidation language in the statement announcing the ceasefire that transit will be permitted in coordination with the Iranian military. If it is able to dictate the terms of movement through the waterway or even charge tolls then Iran will in some ways have been left in a stronger position by the conflict, they said.

Iran wants a permanent control over the waterway going forward and after the war ends, according to a person with knowledge of the negotiations.

US allies are also fearful of the impact the conflict will have on the views of countries in the Middle East, Africa, Asia and South America toward Washington.

In the Gulf, there is particular alarm among some countries that their initial pleas to the Trump administration not to proceed with the conflict went unheeded, according to people familiar with their thinking.

And Gulf officials who say walking away with the Tehran regime in place as even worse, they said, with concern over Trump’s unpredictability prompting them to strengthen alliances elsewhere, they said.

Trump had likely viewed his operation against Venezuela President Nicolas Maduro as evidence he could decapitate enemy

crimes and human rights abuses, they said. They warned this may push so-called “middle ground” countries towards Moscow and Beijing, suggesting it may take years of diplomacy to undo.

Russia, Iran and China would likely also further strengthen ties among them in the wake of the conflict, making it even less likely that the US would be able to achieve its goal of fracturing those relations, sometimes termed a “reverse Kissinger” after the former secretary of state, officials said.

The Iran campaign has been a “serious setback” for Trump, said Wu Xinbo, director at Pundit University’s Center for American Studies in Shanghai who previously advised the Chinese foreign ministry. “When he comes to Beijing now, he’ll be frustrated and will realise that China will have to play an even larger role,” said Wu, who spoke before the ceasefire was announced.

Officials cited mockery of Trump in Russian and Chinese state media as evidence of how his handling of the war will likely be perceived by the regimes in those countries. The TACO meme — a “Trump Always Chicks Out” — is not just an amusing political attack by his domestic opponents but now a geopolitical conclusion of America’s enemies, one said.

WAR DIARY

Shehbaz Sharif's X post goes viral

ISLAMABAD: A social media post by Pakistan’s PM Shehbaz Sharif has triggered widespread debate after an apparent “draft” message was published on X and later edited. The incident quickly drew attention online, with users scrutinising the edit history and questioning the circumstances behind the initial post. The controversy began when the Prime Minister’s account shared a message that included the heading, “Draft: Pakistan’s PM Message on X.”

The inclusion of the word “Draft” suggested that the post may not have been intended for public release in its original form. Within a short span, the tweet was edited, removing the draft label but retaining the core content. **ANI**

do it, I’ll support you.” “I think we need to do it,” Trump told the room. The next afternoon, aboard Air Force One and 22 minutes before General Caine’s deadline, Trump issued the order: “Operation Epic Fury is approved. No abortions. Good luck.”

TRUMP TO DISCUSS LEAVING NATO IN MEETING WITH RUTTE

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump will discuss the possibility of leaving NATO when he meets with the alliance’s chief Mark Rutte on Wednesday, the White House said, accusing Washington’s partners of “turning their back” on the American people.

Trump has expressed anger at Western partners’ refusal to back his war on Iran, rocking the 77-year-old transatlantic alliance.

“It’s quite sad that NATO turned their backs on the American people over the course of the last six weeks when it’s the American people who have been funding their defence,” White House Press Secretary Karoline Levitt told reporters. **AFP**

{ IN DISPUTE }

Polymarket’s Iran bets draw fresh disputes amid insider scrutiny

Bloomberg

letters@bloombergenews.com

LONDON: Bets on a ceasefire between the US and Iran have sent more than \$170 million coursing through Polymarket, making it one of the largest geopolitical wagers in the short history of prediction markets.

Now, the aftermath is raising the same questions that have dogged the platforms for months: whether bettors are trading on inside information, and whether the platforms can cleanly settle the contracts they broker.

A series of well-timed Iran wagers placed on Polymarket by freshly created anonymous accounts have generated hundreds of thousands of dollars in profits so far, prompting analysts to scour the trades for tell-tale signs of insider activity. Some payouts on Middle East-related bets are now frozen in a dispute,

with traders unable to collect as users debate what constitutes a ceasefire.

Together, they expose the growing pains of an industry that is still building the infrastructure to match its ambitions.

Almost all of the recent cases that raised insider trading concerns have been based on circumstantial evidence, with no smoking gun pointing to specific insiders at work. On Wednesday, blockchain analysts firm Lookonchain highlighted three recently created accounts that secured more than \$480,000 in profits by betting on a ceasefire by April 7 and selling the position at high prices.

The final result of the April 7 contract remains under dispute, a process that will force most traders to wait for more than two days for payouts.

Total volume on the market has topped \$60 million and remains open for trading while

Traders place \$950mn bet on oil price falling hours ahead of truce

LONDON: Investors placed an approximately \$950 million bet on oil prices falling just hours before the US and Iran announced a ceasefire, the latest large wager on the direction of the world’s most traded commodity ahead of a major policy announcement by President Donald Trump.

On Tuesday, investors sold a combined \$800 million of Brent and US crude

futures at 1945 GMT, according to ISEG data.

At around 2230 GMT on Tuesday, President Trump stepped back from threatening the destruction of “a whole civilisation” and announced a two-week ceasefire with Iran, knocking crude futures down by some 15% to below \$100 a barrel at the start of Wednesday’s official trading session. **REUTERS**

the dispute is resolved.

The contracts highlight a persistent problem in prediction markets, where real-world events don’t always resolve according to black-and-white criteria. What’s more, the growing

array of suspicious activity is adding urgency to efforts to address the new risks opened up by prediction markets at a moment when Wall Street is moving to legitimise them and everyday users are piling in.

Prediction markets offer a way to make yes-or-no bets on events ranging from sports to elections and awards shows. Polymarket also uses its operations outside the US to list contracts tied to military conflict, resulting in heavy scrutiny from lawmakers. There’s growing momentum in Congress to rein in the nascent industry.

Polymarket and its largest rival, Kalshi Inc, have sought to crack down on insider trading as their platforms grow in popularity. Both firms have signed partnerships with third-party companies to help monitor the issue, and tightened their own rules to define more clearly when bets would be considered as having acted on inside information.

Resolving disputes

Disputes over how markets resolve are frequent, even if they only affect a small fraction of the thousands of contracts offered on

Polymarket every day.

On the platform, anyone can propose how a market should resolve by posting a small amount of collateral. If there’s a disagreement, another user can dispute the outcome. The matter is then put to a vote among holders of a cryptocurrency called UMA, with traders debating the evidence in a public Discord chatroom.

Someholders have argued that the ceasefire deal between the US and Iran would fall under a “temporary tactical stand-down”, which wouldn’t count under the rules drawn up by Polymarket. Others pointed to a statement from Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi which said Iran would halt its “defensive operations”, arguing that he hadn’t ruled out offensive manoeuvres.

Other Polymarket contracts that track truce dates as far ahead as December 31 have already resolved in favour of a ceasefire, complicating the matter further.

Street hits the speed lane as ceasefire revives hope

Srushti Vaidya

srushti.vaidya@livemint.com

MUMBAI: Markets cheered on Wednesday as a fragile peace blossomed in West Asia, following threats of a civilizational wipe-out the previous day. While the Sensex had its best day in over five years on Wednesday and the Nifty rose the most in almost a year, experts cautioned that the relief may be temporary, as Tehran has not indicated a definitive pause to its missile and drone strikes.

The Nifty and the Sensex jumped 3.78% and 3.85% to close at 23,997 and 77,562, respectively. During the day’s session, the Nifty recovered 4.32% of its fall since 28 February, when the West Asia war broke out. Anxieties cooled, with the India volatility index plunging 20%, its steepest single-day drop since 5 June, 2024.

“The announcement of a two-week ceasefire has lifted near-term market sentiment. However, it is premature to conclude that the conflict is fully behind us,” said Vinay Jaising, chief investment officer and head of equity advisory at ASK Private Wealth. Sustained improvement in sentiment will depend on whether the ceasefire translates



The Nifty and the Sensex jumped 3.78% and 3.85%, closing at 23,997 and 77,562, respectively. **REUTERS**

into a lasting de-escalation. Jaising added.

The US and Iran entered into a two-week provisional ceasefire just an hour before a major military deadline, which includes a temporary reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. The agreement followed 40 days of warfare that saw widespread destruction in West Asia and disrupted energy supply chains.

The ceasefire is market-positive because it directly reduces the risk of an oil shock to inflation and growth. Stephen Dower, head of Franklin Templeton Institute, wrote in a note. However, he too added that given its temporary and conditional

nature, it should be treated as a relief rally, not a definitive all-clear.

Sudeep Shah of SBI Securities had a different take. “The recent upmove in Nifty appears to be more than just a relief rally, supported by strong price action, improving breadth, and positive momentum indicators,” said Shah, who heads technical and derivatives research at the broking firm. The breakout above the 20-day exponential moving average and easing volatility suggest a shift toward a short-term bullish trend rather than a mere bounce, Shah added.

The BSE’s market capitalization increased by \$16 trillion on

Wednesday. The rally was broad-based, with the Nifty Smallcap and Midcap indices gaining 3.9% and 4.03% higher. All of Nifty’s sectoral indices closed in green. Adding to the positive tone was the central bank’s decision to keep the repo rate unchanged at 5.25%.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) net sold shares worth ₹2.81 crore in secondary markets on Wednesday, provisional data from BSE showed. DII’s net bought shares worth ₹4,168 crore.

Global markets rejoiced as well, with South Korea’s KOSPI rising 6.8%, Japan’s Nikkei 5.4%, China’s CSI 300 3.5%, and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index 3.1%. Oil plunged over 7% to \$93 a barrel 12% following the ceasefire, while the rupee gained 50 paise during the day. However, oil remains below the pre-war level of ₹73.91, indicating that even with the ceasefire announcement, the risk premium still exists.

Dover of Franklin Templeton said the damage is done as energy infrastructure across the Gulf has been hit, and restoring full production capacity will take time. “Supply normalization won’t be immediate, which means that oil, natural gas and fertilizer prices probably won’t fall quickly back to pre-war levels,” he added.

RBI plans to ease banks’ capital requirements

Anshika Kayastha

anshika.kayastha@livemint.com

MUMBAI: The banking regulator on Wednesday proposed easing banks’ capital requirements by allowing quarterly profits to be included in capital adequacy calculations and scrapping the mandate to maintain an investment fluctuation reserve (IFR).

Currently, banks are permitted to include their quarterly profits in the computation of their capital to risk-weighted assets ratio. However, this is subject to incremental provisions for non-performing assets (NPAs) at the end of any of the four quarters of the previous fiscal year, provided they have not deviated by more than 25% from the average of the four quarters.

“On a review, it is proposed to dispense with this condition,” RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra announced on Wednesday as part of the statement on developmental and regulatory policies released alongside the monetary policy statement. The move comes amid a benign credit cycle, with banks reporting decadal low NPAs.

The monetary policy committee kept rates unchanged at 5.25% while maintaining a “neutral stance”, citing geopolitical uncertainty and higher upside risks to inflation from the West Asia war. The draft circular issued later in the evening said banks can include quarterly profits in the computation of their common equity tier 1



The proposed measures could free up to ₹40,000 crore for the banking system. **REUTERS**

(CET1) capital, subject to a new formula which accounts for a bank’s cumulative profit or loss accumulated over each quarter of a fiscal year, as well as the average dividend paid by the bank during the last three fiscal years.

At the post-policy conference, the RBI chief said banks have been requesting relief, which is expected to ease access to capital amid unfavourable market conditions. “NBFCs (non-banking financial companies) already had some of the provisions. So, it was time that we aligned it,” he said, adding it does not change the calculation of net profit but changes the way capital adequacy is measured. “It is a better reflection of the capital that the banks have.”

This proposal gives considerable flexibility to banks to internal plough back,” State Bank of India (SBI) group chief economic

adviser Soumya Kanti Ghosh said in a note.

The central bank also proposed eliminating the requirement for banks to maintain an IFR as an additional buffer against depreciation in the value of their investments, subject to mark-to-market requirements.

In his statement, the RBI governor said banks already maintain a capital charge for market risk and also follow revised norms on classification, valuation and the operation of investment portfolios, which have warranted a review of the need for such a reserve. This will help enhance regulatory clarity and consistency, he said.

Opening up of the IFR corpus could free up around ₹35,000-40,000 crore for banks. SBI’s Ghosh said, adding that this corpus can be used “optimally and judiciously” by banks between CET-1 and P&L (profit and loss) account even when yields have moved substantially up during the last quarter.

In a later draft, RBI proposed removing the IFR requirement for bank categories maintaining a capital charge for market risk, and asked banks to instead follow the revised norms on classification, valuation, and the operation of investment portfolios. It proposed letting banks meet IFR requirements on balance sheet dates instead of continuously, and plans to harmonize IFR instructions across bank categories to remove inconsistencies and improve clarity.

NSE BEGINS IPO PREPARATIONS, MEETS 20 BANKERS

Agnidev Bhattacharya

agnidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com

MUMBAI: The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has begun preparations for its initial public offering (IPO), meeting all 20 of its investing bankers earlier this week to start drafting the offer document and outline a tentative timeline for the listing, three people aware of the matter told Mint.

“NSE met all 20 bankers together for the first time, where everyone agreed to a tentative timeline for the IPO,” one of the people cited above said, adding that the process will begin with the identification of risks and the preparation of required disclosures, work on which is likely to begin this week.

The exchange will contact all retail shareholders who wish to participate in the share sale by the end of April, a second person aware of the discussions said, wishing not to be named discussing private deliberations.

The exchange’s registrar had already asked retail shareholders late last month to express their interest in the IPO. “The exact date of the filing of the DRHP with SEBI is currently unknown. Accordingly, only such equity shares which have been held continuously since 15 June 2025 (the cut-off date) will be eligible to be sold in the Offer for Sale,” the registrar’s letter to retail investors read, a copy of which has been reviewed by Mint.

“Once these retail investors express their interests, the bank-

SC asks Heera Gold MD to surrender in ₹10,000 crore scam

Abraham Thomas
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday directed a woman accused of duping thousands of investors in a gold ponzi scheme to surrender within a week and cooperate with the Enforcement Directorate (ED), which had attached her assets and complained of non-cooperation in executing sale deeds.



SC warned of non-bailable warrants if accused Nowhera Shaikh fails to comply.

A bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwalla and K.V. Viswanathan ordered Nowhera Shaikh, managing director of Heera Gold Exim Pvt Ltd, to surrender within a week, observing, "This is a case of large-scale fraud where thousands of investors have been duped of over ₹10,000 crore. We are left with no option but to direct her to surrender within one week, failing which non-bailable warrants shall be issued."

The court had granted Shaikh bail in January 2021 and cancelled it in October 2024. However, the cancellation was stayed after she offered three properties for sale to repay investors.

The ED told the court that only one of the three properties has been sold, while the others were either encumbered or in the names of family members. Appearing for the ED, advocate Anann Venkatesh said: "We have identified 90 more properties for auction. Bidders are participating on the strength of this court's order. The petitioner has not been cooperating in executing sale deeds for 16 properties."

The bench noted that despite being given time to surrender after the October 18, 2024 order, Shaikh had failed to cooperate. "It appears that the petitioner is not cooperating with the ED on registration of sale deeds," it said.

Shaikh, present in court, argued through her counsel that properties were being auctioned at throwaway prices and that the PMLA tribunal is yet to approve the provisional attachment.

The court clarified that the ED was acting in accordance with its directions and that Shaikh must cooperate. It further directed that upon surrender, her counsel must inform when she is ready to execute the sale deeds. She will be escorted from jail to the sub-registrar's office for the process. "Once all 16 sale deeds are executed and formalities completed, the petitioner will be at liberty to approach this court," the bench said.

Turmoil on Street eats into demat additions in FY26

Mayur Bhalerao
mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com

MUMBAI: After two years of strong expansion, the pace of new demat account additions slowed in FY26, signalling a shift in retail investor behaviour as volatile markets and weaker returns tempered their enthusiasm.

Net demat account additions fell to about 32 million in FY26 from a record 41 million added

in FY25, according to data collated from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy. The total number of demat accounts crossed 25 million.

The 22% year-on-year decline in additions of demat accounts—dematerialized or paperless accounts mandated for trading in securities—suggests that the surge in retail participation during the recent bull run is beginning to lose momentum amid a more uncertain global and market environment.

The longer-term trend shows how growth is now normalizing after a sharp post-pandemic surge. New accounts had jumped from 14 million in FY21 to 35 million in FY23, marking a 142% rise, the data showed.

This was followed by a moderation to 25 million in FY23. The momentum picked up again in FY24 with 37 million new accounts and peaked in FY25, before easing in FY26 as market conditions turned more volatile.

"Markets are currently in a consolidation phase. Whenever markets are in a downturn and sentiment weakens, retail activity tends to decline. This is a cyclical pattern," said Kranti Bhatnagar, director of equity strategy at WealthMills Securities. "Seasonal investors typically enter when markets are rising, so periods of negative sentiment lead to slower account additions."

The moderation is also visible in monthly data.

Net additions fell to 2.15 million in March from 2.81 million in February and 3.62 million in January, marking the lowest level of account additions since May 2025.

Month-on-month growth slipped below 1% (to 0.97%), the slowest pace since January 2020.

"The slowdown appears largely cyclical rather than structural," said Harshad Dasani, business head at InVestor PMS.

ers will have a three-week period to review the outreach. During this time, the exchange will also formalise institutional participants for the offer-for-sale portion," the second person explained.

Once the sellers and the stake they are paring are fixed by the end of May, the exchange will determine the valuation for the offering, the third person said.

If all goes according to plan and everyone is on the same page about the valuation, the change is eyeing to file draft papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) by June or early July, the second person added.

Anthropic's AI model exposes thousands of software flaws

Agence France-Presse
feedback@livemint.com

NEW YORK: Anthropic on Tuesday said its yet-to-be-released artificial intelligence (AI) model called Claude Mythos has proven keenly adept at exposing software weaknesses.

Mythos has laid bare thousands of vulnerabilities in commonly used applications for which no patch or fix exists, prompting the San Francisco-based AI startup to form an alliance with cybersecurity specialists to bolster defenses against hacking.

"We have a new model that we're explicitly not releasing to the public," Mike Krieger of Anthropic Labs said in a statement. "Claude is letting cybersecurity specialists and engineers in the open-source community work with Mythos to use the model as a defensive



Mythos finds flaws in widely used applications.

weapon "sort of arming them ahead of time," Krieger explained.

Leaps in AI model capabilities have come with concerns about hackers using such tools for figuring out passwords or cracking encryption meant to keep data safe.

The oldest of the vulnerabilities uncovered by Mythos dates back 27 years, and none were ostensibly noticed by their makers before being pinpointed by the AI model, according to Anthropic.

META UNVEILS MUSE SPARK, ITS FIRST AI MODEL

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Meta Platforms on Wednesday unveiled Muse Spark, its first artificial intelligence model from a costly team it assembled last year to catch up with rivals in the AI race.

Shares of the company extended gains to trade up nearly 7%.

US tech giants are under pressure to prove their massive AI outlays will pay off. The stakes are especially high for Meta after it hired Scale AI chief executive officer Alex Wang last year under a \$14.3 billion deal and offered some engineers pay packages of hundreds of millions of dollars to staff a new superintelligence team.

THE CROSSWORDS

CRYPTIC CLUES

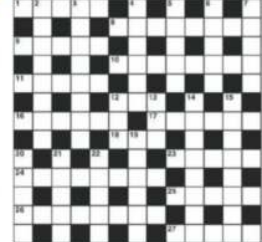
- ACROSS**
- General holds large weapon (5)
 - Rotor arm? (8)
 - Capone and Eisenhower appear similar (5)
 - Runners who jump the gun are not forgotten (8)
 - Use force to get peace we hear (5)
 - A refuge for thieves maybe (3)
 - How one talks with a caustic wit? (6)
 - Possibly united by here separated (6)
 - Lap up spilled tea (3)
 - Dry, quiet and waggy (5)
 - Worn after towing? (8)
 - It should be discarded before it comes to light (5)
 - Meet a number on the border (8)
 - Stone used in baguette (5)

DOWN

- They don't work for money (4)
- Being by water liked sea to be rough (8)
- Venerate an American patriot (6)
- The classic type of French novel (5)
- Not much used in an erotic scene (5)
- Sn of a group of lions? (5)
- Change colour but fade away utterly (3)
- Food that may be bolted (3)
- Writing one drink back with another (8)
- Take what shows taste (8)
- Exact satisfaction from Geneva (5)
- Paces around the room (5)
- Alouse in common, defiance (5)
- Become less neat (5)

PUZZLE 17455

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QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
- Sharply evident (5)
 - Instinct (2,15)
 - Merchandise (5)
 - Sworn (5,3)
 - Well-guarded (5)
 - A felling tool (3)
 - Gentle breeze (6)
 - By word of mouth (8)
 - Large cak (7)
 - Later in time (5)
 - Put finishing touches to (5,3)
 - Resentment (5)
 - Formal evening dress (5,3)
 - Tremble markedly (5)
- DOWN**
- Decisive (3-5)
 - Warning signal (3,5)
 - Stream of people entering (6)
 - Unable to progress (5)
 - Turn on fixed point (5)
 - Landing place (5)
 - An acquired facility (3)
 - Very long period (1)
 - Intend to deceive (1,3)
 - State of great terror (4,4)
 - Inequitable (6)
 - Angry murmur (5)
 - Recall in fear (5)
 - Habitually lazy person (5)

US COURT CLEARS HEARING IN ADANI SEC CASE

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

AHMEDABAD: A US court has allowed a pre-motion conference in the securities case against the Adani Group, as billionaire Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar Adani seek dismissal of the lawsuit filed by the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC).

The US District Court for the Eastern District of New York on April 7 granted the defendants' request to hold a pre-motion conference before filing a motion to dismiss.

The case, SEC v. Adani et al., arises from a complaint filed by the SEC in November 2024 alleging securities fraud linked to a 2021 bond issuance by Adani Green Energy Ltd.

The SEC had sued alleging they misled investors by failing to disclose an alleged bribery scheme tied to Indian state officials, framing the case under US securities laws.

DGCA orders 5G-safe upgrades for jets

Jatin Grover & Abhishek Law
jatin.grover@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Ever found your mobile phone's signal to be patchy while waiting for a flight? That's because telecom operators can't provide stronger signals near airports, as these can interfere with a small cockpit tool—a radio altimeter.

The electronic gauge, which measures the altitude of an airborne plane, feeds data to multiple automated systems on board. A wrong reading can be a safety risk, especially during poor visibility. But the restrictions have sparked concerns, as telecom operators expand 5G coverage and prepare for even stronger 6G networks.

Now, the civil aviation regulator has asked all airlines to modify the altimeters so that they are tolerant to 3300-3670 megahertz (MHz) C-band—a key range of spectrum to provide 5G services, according to the Director General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) order dated 19 November 2025.



The US earlier addressed concerns by requiring upgrades to aircraft radio altimeters.

Mint has reviewed a copy of the order.

The required modification or retrofitting must be completed by 31 December 2027, the order said.

India is not alone in facing this challenge. Countries such as the US and those in Europe have faced similar challenges, with regulators proposing deadlines extending to 2029-2032 for full fleet retrofits. But that has also

caused a spike in demand. According to estimates by the American regulator Federal Aviation Administration (FAA), upgrades will cost around \$4.5 billion for the US fleet alone.

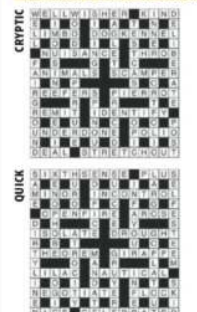
To be sure, the US had earlier addressed 5G interference concerns by requiring upgrades to aircraft radio altimeters, setting a February 2024 deadline. It later said the entire airline fleet had completed these upgrades by

September 2023, mitigating immediate risks. However, the country now has plans to expand 5G into a higher spectrum band.

Since the 2022 rollout of 5G in India, telecom operators have had to limit signal strength near airports and follow strict exclusion zones to avoid interference with aircraft systems. According to the November order, the DGCA has also prohibited pilots from conducting automatic landings and from using enhanced flight vision systems for touchdown in aircraft with radio altimeters that are not tolerant of 5G airwaves.

"There are airplanes with an old generation of altimeters, which can cause interference with 5G currently and 6G in the upper C-band in future such as 4.4-4.8GHz," said Bharat Bhatia, president of ITU-APT Foundation of India, which works with industry and government on telecom policy. "The altimeter replacement is the only solution, which could take time owing to a similar demand from other developing countries."

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17454)



PUZZLE 17455



WEATHER

THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
Many clear	Strong surface winds during day	Strong surface winds during day
31°C 15°C	33°C 16°C	35°C 18°C

ALMANAC

Today is 9th April 2026 +10° (Normal, Max) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min) +10° (Normal, Min)	Delhi 31°C 15°C	Mumbai 31°C 15°C	Kolkata 29°C 13°C	Chennai 36°C 27°C
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NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA TENDER NOTICE

Sl. No.	NAME OF BOARD/COMP./AUTH.	NAME OF WORK	OPENING DATE	CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT (IN RUPEES)	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/COMP./AUTH.	LOCAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAIL
1.	HSEDC	LIFTING AND DISPOSAL OF INDUSTRIAL WASTE FROM GREEN BELT AREA AT MR. PART-1, BAHADURPUR	13.04.2026	20.04.2026	Rs. 14.75 LACS	https://tenders.hsecl.in	8416767348 A. Bahadurpur ahsecl@hsecl.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT:
www.hseclprocurement.gov.in or www.ettenders.hsecl.in

NO. N-13/2021/40344020/13/7

DEPT. OF WATER RESOURCES, GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

"Procurement Notice No. ACEDC-CTC-01/2026-27"

32001/34/2627

- Name of the Work: Total 01 (One) No. Drainage work.
- Estimated cost: Rs. 697.72 lakh
- Period of Completion: 18 (Eighteen) months
- Date and time of availability of bid document in the portal: From 11:30 hours of Dt. 15.04.2026 to 18.08 hours of Dt. 28.04.2026
- Last date for receipt of bids in the portal: 18.08 hours of Dt. 28.04.2026
- Name and address of the Officer inviting Bids: Additional Chief Engineer, Drainage Circle, Gandpur, Cuttack-753003. e-mail id: sadain@nccsctd@gmail.com

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal of Odisha Government <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. All information, notices, addendum, cancellation notice etc. if required, will be published in this portal.

Additional Chief Engineer, Drainage Circle, Cuttack
OIPR - 32001/32515/126-27/0002

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, DHEMKANAL (R&B) CIRCLE DHEMKANAL

Corrigendum to bid identification No. C.C.E.DKL(R&B)/17/2025-26

The Bid invited vide Bid Identification No. C.C.E.DKL(R&B)/17/2025-26 vide letter No. 694 dt. 26.03.2026 has been modified as follows:

- The Bid document for the above notice will be available in the website: www.tendersodisha.gov.in from Dt. 18.04.2026 to 5.00 PM of Dt. 02.05.2026 for online bidding and shall be open at 11.00 AM on Dt. 04.05.2026.

All other terms and conditions of the above tender call notice will remain unchanged.

Chief Construction Engineer
Dhenkanal (R&B) Circle, Dhenkanal
OIPR - 34001/134/1321/26-27/0001

POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF UTTARAKHAND LTD.

(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Enterprise)

Office of Chief Engineer (O&M), Kumaon Zone, 220KV S/S, Campus, Kamalganj, Haldeewari-261139, Corporate ID U40101UR20045G02675 Phone No. 7088117917

E-Tender Notice

Power Transmission Corporation of Uttarakhand Limited invites E-Tender of following work and the last date of submission of e-bid (On line/Off line) is 08.05.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.

- Assistance in carrying out miscellaneous routine works for preventive maintenance of 132KV Almorah-Pithoragarh line, 132KV Chandak-Pithoragarh line, 132KV Ranihath-Bageswar line and 132KV Chandak-Lohaghat line under O&M Division, PTCUL, Almorah against E-Tender Specification No. CE/O&M/PTCUL/HLD/01/2026-27, TENDER ID 2026_PTCUL_93989_33.
- Construction of boarder/pitching at tower location No. 123 at 132KV Jaispur-Kashipur line under 220KV O&M Division, PTCUL, Mahukeshgarh against E-Tender Specification No. CE/O&M/PTCUL/HLD/02/2026-27, TENDER ID 2026_PTCUL_93996_33.

For more details please visit E-Tender Website www.uttarakhandsarva.com and E-Tender information is available at PTCUL Website www.ptcul.org. For any assistance on E-Tendering, please contact +91-8998989000.

Chief Engineer (O&M)
Kumaon Zone
Date: 08.04.2026 "Save Electricity in the Interest of Nation" PTCUL, Haldeewari

UTTARAKHAND OPEN UNIVERSITY

Teerapuri Bypass Road, Near Transport Nagar, Haridwar (Nainital)-261139

Uttarakhand Open University
Website: www.uou.ac.in or admission@uou.ac.in
No. UOU/Adm/3/02/2026
Dated: 08 April, 2026

Re-Advertisement for Faculty Positions

Online applications are invited in the prescribed Application Form, eligible candidates for recruitment of Associate Professor and Assistant Professor in various Subjects of the University. The last date of submission of online application form is 10-05-2026 and last date for receiving of hard copy of application at University is 23-05-2026 (05:00 pm). For details regarding vacancies, qualification, experience, fee etc. Please visit the University website www.uou.ac.in

Registrar

U.P. Power Transmission Corporation Limited Invites E-auction bids for Sale OF SCRAP

At 220 KV Substation Bagpat Under Electricity Transmission Division-Baraut-250611 District Bagpat Proposed Details of E-auction 23.04.2026 E-auction of 100 MVA Transformer (TELK Make) to be done on 'as is where is' through M/S M.S.T.C. Site of scrap- 220 KV Substation Bagpat Under ETD-Baraut District Bagpat Details of E-

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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G

Miller denies single, misses last ball to hand GT victory

Samreen Razzaqui

samreen.razzaqui@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: When two familiar opponents meet, sparks fly, there is bound to be drama. When David Miller met a familiar Gujarat Titans and vice versa, it was drama on steroids.

When Miller was acquired by Delhi Capitals for a mere ₹2 crore in the auction, some called it one of the biggest steals. A finisher with that kind of experience, a CV as rich as his and fit as ever, he could be a game-changer for Capitals.

And he showcased that mastery against one of his former partners. Despite batting with discomfort in his left hand—he had retired due to severe pain before returning—he almost pulled off a thrilling chase.

However, Titans pulled off a one-run win after Capitals were left to get two runs off the last ball with Miller facing Prasad Krishna. With that Titans open the account in IPL 2026. GT piled up 20/4 at the Foroshah Kotla and DC made 209/8 in reply.

An unbeaten 41 off 20 balls from Miller almost took DC across the long before a last-ball run-out at the striker's end saw Kuldeep Yadav walk back, sealing the dramatic win for GT.

KL Rahul's previous starts at the crease had been short—0 and 1—but a more in-synch batter turned up on the day. In the second over, he deposited Kagiso Rabada over long on six with a sublime pick-up shot.

Chasing 21, Capitals were off to an ideal start. Rahul and Patsum Nissanka stitched together a 76-run opening partnership. As Mohammed Siraj tried to find some swing and shape with the new ball, Nissanka punched him for three boundaries—one through cover, the second lofted straight back over Siraj's head and the third an off-drive.

He then laid into Ashok Sharma in the last over of Powerplay, the pacer hit for 23 runs in the over. Nissanka first smashed a slower ball for a four. Ashok changed his pace but even a 147kph delivery was hammered over mid-off for six. The next was crunched for a four and another change-of-pace delivery was met with the same result as Nissanka smashed it.

Although Krishna dismissed Nissanka for 41, he wasn't spared after that. Rahul decimated him with a 20-run takedown after that.



Gujarat Titans players celebrate after beating Delhi Capitals in their IPL match at Arun Jaitley Stadium.

AIJAY AGGARWAL/HT



POINTS TABLE

Team	P	W	L	NRR	Pts
1 RR	3	3	0	2.403	6
2 PBKS*	3	2	0	0.637	5
3 RCB	2	2	0	2.501	4
4 SRH	3	2	1	0.811	4
5 DC	3	1	2	0.275	2
6 GT	3	1	2	-0.270	2
7 LSG	2	1	1	-0.542	2
8 MI	3	1	2	-0.75	2
9 KKR*	3	0	2	-1.964	1
10 CSK	3	0	3	-2.57	0

*Still unbeaten

Rashid Khan swung the momentum back in Gujarat's favour as he dismissed Nitish Rana and the in-form Sameer Rizvi—bowed first ball playing the wrong line—in the same over.

With Delhi reeling at 101/3, Rahul tried to stabilise the innings but the momentum did seem to have been affected. It didn't help that Miller had to retire due to discomfort in his hand at that stage.

In the 17th over, the momentum was arrested further with Tristan Stubbs run out and Rahul dismissed for 92. Miller hammered Siraj, who went for 23 runs in the 19th over to leave DC to get 13 off six balls.

Earlier, GT posted what seemed a competitive 20/4. After scoring 73 in the last match against Rajasthan Royals, Sai Sudharsan fell early, dragging one back on to the

stumps off Mukesh Kumar.

That brought Jos Buttler to the crease and he looked in menacing touch from the outset. He tore into Mukesh in an over, taking him for 23 runs, including a massive 96 metre six into the top tier of the Gautam Gambhir stand, and surged to a 24-ball fifty. For the first time in three innings this season, Buttler looked had come into his own.

Kuldeep Yadav eventually halted the charge by dismissing Buttler—the fourth time he was dismissing him in T20s—for 52 off 27. There was no respite for Capitals as Shubman Gill and Washington Sundar took over.

The pair added 104 runs for the third wicket with both bringing up fluent half-centuries. Sundar scored his first IPL fifty. For the longest time Gill seemed happy to play second fiddle with both Butler and Sundar on the other end.

He then launched his own take-down of Kuldeep in the 17th over, hitting him for 17 runs. He was dismissed by Lungi Ngidi in the next over and it led to a slight dip in momentum, with GT going 12 balls without a boundary and scoring just 58 runs off the last six overs. But on a wicket that largely played out well, DC had the advantage. That is till the last ball.

Brief scores: GT 20/4 (S Gill 70, J Buttler 52, W Sundar 55, M Kumar 2/55); DC 209/8 (P Nissanka 41, KL Rahul 92, D Miller 41; R Khan 3/72, P Krishna 2/52). **GT won by 1 run.**

Jaiswal's quest to show he is better than the best

Sanjeev K Samyal

sanjeev.samyal@htlive.com

MUMBAI: In Yashasvi Jaiswal, India has a truly world-class cricketer. A batter, equipped to do well in all conditions, against all kinds of bowling attacks. Three years into international cricket, there has been no visible chink in his game. However, despite great success in Test cricket, he hasn't quite had the opportunities in white-ball cricket.

Compared to the 28 Tests he has played, the left-hander has just 4 ODIs and 23 T20s to show. This, of course, isn't about his talent alone but also about the competition.

In ODIs, he contends with Rohit Sharma and Shubman Gill at the top of the order. In T20s, the list of competitors is longer: Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Ishan Kishan are already on the team and capable of opening. Then, there is Gill. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi could also be a wildcard.

Essentially, if he wants to make the T20 team, he needs a special season. Batting is more than skill. It also requires courage, temperament and a sharp cricketing brain to succeed. Displaying these qualities, Jaiswal has held his own on Australia's bouncy tracks, England's moving ball conditions, and the sub-continent's spin tracks.

To maximise the ability, one needs to be focussed. In the ongoing Indian Premier League, Jaiswal's improved focus is evident. He is yet to put a foot wrong in the first

three matches for the Rajasthan Royals, scoring 38* vs Chennai Super Kings, 55 vs Gujarat Titans and 77* vs Mumbai Indians. That's 170 runs at a strike rate of 163.46.

But the beauty of his performances has been that all three knocks took the match situation into account too.

Many players get carried away when they have a batting partner like Vaibhav Sooryavanshi blazing away at the other end.

Jaiswal, however, has shown the calmness to remain unaffected and focus on his own game. In the opening game against CSK, chasing a low total he eschewed all risks and his 38 not out came off 36 balls, the 55 against Titans came off 36 balls and in a rain-shortened game he batted in top gear against MI throughout, scoring 77 not out off 32 balls, at a strike rate of 240.63.

Sooryavanshi is an outrageous stroke-maker and is used to having the spotlight on him. On Tuesday, all eyes were on Sooryavanshi again, especially regarding his contest against Jasprit Bumrah. Jaiswal has been content to play second fiddle to the dashing youngster. Against MI, Jaiswal made a statement that he can step up his strike rate when the situation demands, producing a blitz that blinded MI and overshadowed his teammates.

There's no denying that the dashing approach of Sooryavanshi is rubbing on Jaiswal and he is enjoying batting with the 15-year-old. Providing blazing starts in all three games—75 in 6.2 overs vs CSK, 70 in 6.2 overs vs GT and 80 in 5 overs vs MI—they have powered Royals to the top of the table.

Jaiswal in IPL

STRIKE RATE
RUNS



[BILLIE JEAN KING CUP] ASIA/OCEANIA GROUP 1



India's Sahaja Yamakapalli in action at the BJK Cup.

AITA

After loss to Thais, India beat NZ 3-0

Avishek Roy

avishek.roy@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: India had to produce something special to stay afloat after losing their opening tie against Thailand 2-1 in the Billie Jean King Cup (Asia/Oceania Group 1). After losing to the Thais—the tie could not be completed overnight due to rain interruptions—India swept

The two upset the strong pair of Monique Barry and Erin Routliffe, who is a two-time US Open doubles champion, 6-4, 6-2.

India were already 2-0 up going into the doubles match. Vaishnavi Adkar played fluently to beat young Aishi Das 6-2, 6-4. Sahaja, back on court again, showed more purpose to beat Valentina Ivanov 6-1, 6-3. She crossed a big hurdle as well. In

Madrid beaten by Bayern magic at either end of pitch

Dhiman Sarkar

dhiman.sarkar@htlive.com

KOLKATA: Kylian Mbappe had half wheeled away to celebrate when Manuel Neuer got down to pull off a save that belied age and size. The television cameras caught Mbappe looking visibly stunned.

In the context of a Champions League quarter-final between teams that have 21 titles between them, and 77 quarter-final appearances, it was a save as important as it was incredible. Goals from Luis Diaz and Harry Kane had put Bayern Munich 2-0 ahead and Real Madrid were being carved open. Then around the hour mark the 15-time winners had got a foot in the door.

Mbappe's shot, off a Jude Bellingham pass, came in the 65th minute. Four minutes earlier, Vinicius Jr had broken through on goal latching on to David Upamecano's weak back pass. If Vinicius Jr couldn't score, it was because Neuer's positioning forced the



QUARTER-FINALS, FIRST LEG
REAL MADRID (Mbappe 74) 1-2 BAYERN MUNICH (Diaz 41, Kane 46)
SPORTING 0-1 ARSENAL

after a wonderful bout of passing involving Joshua Kimmich, Diaz and Kane. Had Serge Gnabry managed better control twice inside a minute, Bayern would have put the contest to bed by the 28th minute.

Bayern's passing was as good as its press and it showed in the first goal. Olise, Gnabry and Kane worked the ball slickly before Diaz finished the move running on the outside of Trent Alexander-Arnold. All hopes of Real starting the second half strongly were dashed when Carreras was bundled off the ball and Olise went on a run. He found Kane who was unmarked and scored with his first shot of the night.

Kane's 49th goal of the season was also his first from outside the box in the 2025-26 Champions League. One of the points of interest in Bundesliga is whether he will break Robert Lewandowski's season record of 41 goals (Kane has 31 with six games to go). His xG efficiency in Bundesliga is 10.1.

Shetty upsets Li Shi Feng in Asia C'ships

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: India's Ayush Shetty is quickly making it a habit of beating the world's top players regularly.

Last year he twice beat both former world champion Lo Hsiao Tzu of Singapore and world No. 10 Koki Naraoka of Japan. The 20-year-old also beat world No. 6 Chou Ten Chen of Chinese Taipei during his 2025 US Open title-winning campaign. In January, he beat former All England champion and Paris Olympics bronze medalist Lee Zi Jia of Malaysia in straight games.

Shetty continued that trend on Wednesday as he ousted another former All England champion and reigning Asian Games gold medalist Li Shi Feng of China from the first round of the \$50,000 Badminton Asia Championships in Ningbo, China.

The world No. 25 was in his element as he overcame the fifth-seeded home favourite 21-13, 21-16 in 51 minutes in what was the first



Ayush Shetty.

HT PHOTO

derous smashes—the Chinese had no answers, completely unable to read or react. A truly dominant display.

Shetty has been training with PV Sindhu's coach Irwansyah Adi Pratama, who was also sitting outside, for the last couple of weeks. It was the idea of Shetty's coaches at the Centre of Badminton Excellence (formerly Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy) Vimal and Sagar Chopra to have Shetty train under Irwansyah, who coaches a young group of players alongside Sindhu at the national

aside New Zealand 3-0.

There is a long way to go to secure a playoff berth for the second successive year. India must fight it out against the remaining teams—Korea, Mongolia and Indonesia, which has world No. 41 Janice Tjen.

The tie against Thailand was a jolt as India lost both the singles matches, and the tie. In the morning, Sahaja Yamalapalli lost the second singles to Patcharin Cheaphandaj (6-4, 1-6, 6-4). Up a break in the decider, Patcharin faced stiff opposition from Sahaja but sailed through in the end.

India won the doubles though, the experienced Ankita Raina and Rutuja Bhosale taking Nakto Thasorn and Peangtarn Phipuech 6-3, 6-4. That gave some belief against the Kiwis.

eight singles matches in the BJK Cup across nine ties. It was her first victory.

For Vaishnavi, it is her BJK Cup debut. Outclassed on Tuesday by Thailand's Anchisa Chantana in the opening singles, Vaishnavi showed was a fast learner in the win over Aishi.

"It (Thailand) was the first match in the BJK Cup, so I was very nervous. I did not handle my nerves well.

"Coming on to the court today, I focused on giving my best. The most important thing is to have belief. I know I have the ability and our captain (Vishal Uppal) also told me, 'You have the game'. So, I focused on things that are under my control," said Vaishnavi. "The goal is to not give up and keep fighting in every match."

Brazilian wide. Real Madrid's ability to catch opponents by surprise in Europe need no iteration and the Santiago Bernabeu felt they would witness another comeback. Real grew in the game but ran into Neuer.

At 40, Neuer is older than his coach Vincent Kompany. He wouldn't have happy memories of this cauldron where the roof was closed to amplify the noise home supporters usually make. But if it was the small bunch of away fans who were cranking up the volume—at least till the hour mark—was because of a goalkeeper who has won everything in football but remains hungry for more.

The last time he was here, in 2024, Neuer was responsible for a Joselu goal in the 88th minute leading to another Real comeback. Not everyone gets a shot at

redemption and after 12 Bundesliga titles, two Champions League winners medals and a World Cup, maybe Neuer didn't need one.

But there he was on Tuesday night pulling off nine saves—the most for Bayern since November 2020—which included getting big on Mbappe and diving to his left to prevent a Vinicius Jr curler in the first half. It fetched the player-of-the-match award.

"He (Neuer) makes it look so easy. With great goalkeepers, they make incredible saves at incredible angles look so easy. He is still so good with his positioning. We won't win the competition without more of these kind of performances," said Kompany after his 100th game in charge of Bayern.

LISBON (Havertz 90+1)

The next best is 4.97.

Kane has 54 goals contributed to and he and Diaz have combined to score 72 goals, making them the most attacking partnership in Europe, ahead of 56 by Mbappe and Vinicius Jr. Kane, Diaz and Olise have scored 88 goals in all competitions and have been instrumental in taking Bayern to 100 goals in the Bundesliga. It is one short of the Bundesliga record made in 1971-72, also by Bayern.

This was Bayern's first win at Real Madrid in 25 years and the first against them in a knockout since 2011-12. In a match that had 40 attempts on goal, 17 on target, both teams would have felt they could have won. If Bayern's control edged out Real's counter-attacks, it was because in both penalty boxes, they were better.

contest between the two to advance to Round 2 where he will face Chinese Taipei's Chi Yu Jen.

It was a dominant display by Shetty who made tactical use of his height (1.95m) for steep smashes and net control against the world No. 7. Despite a better start by Lin both games, the Indian youngster overpowered the home favourite courtesy of his proactive game in the front court.

Knowing he had nothing to lose, Shetty employed a high-risk attacking game which rewarded him despite taking some time to find his rhythm early on.

"What a performance by Ayush," Shetty's coach U Vimal Kumar told HT from Bengaluru. "He absolutely blew away Li Shi Feng in straight games with fearless, attacking badminton. The power, precision, and those thum-

camp. "The idea is to ensure these players benefit from the presence of foreign coaches while they are in India, especially since they are being supported well by the government/SAL," added Vimal.

Lakshya out
Lakshya Sen, who reached the final of the All England Open last month, lost 12-21, 19-21 to Hong Kong's Lee Cheuk Yiu. This was Lee's fourth win in six meetings against the Indian. While former world No. 1 Kidambi Srikanth lost 18-21, 9-21, 11-21 to Loh, JIS Prannay managed his first win in three months as he beat Vietnam's Nguyen Hai Dang 24-22, 21-12.

In women's singles, PV Sindhu defeated Malaysia's Wong Ling Ching 15-21, 21-11, 21-19 and will next face world No. 2 Wang Zhi Yi of China.

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Hindustan Times SPORT

NEW DELHI
THURSDAY
APRIL 09, 2026

Vaishali outplays Divya, stays in joint-first place

Susan Ninan

susan.ninan@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Two years ago, Praggnanandhaa and Vaishali strode into history as the first brother-sister pair to ever play the Candidates tournament. This time, one of them is coming to terms with a missed chance, while the other is in contention for first place.

In the all-Indian clash in Round 9, Vaishali outplayed Divya Deshmukh with the white pieces, moving up to 5.5 points and into a co-lead with Zhu Jiner. It brought up Vaishali's third win in four games. Going into Wednesday's games, five players, including Divya, were in shared first place. Now, that group has been trimmed to just two players.

Vaishali, who chose the Reti opening (LNT3) and transposed to the English opening, steadily moved into an advantage on the board and the clock. Time management has been one of Vaishali's major troubles in this tournament. In Round 9, she faced none of it. She was the one blinding out moves and calling the shots, without having to frantically look at the clock. She played a brilliant exchange sacrifice (23. Rxd3), while Divya struggled to come up with answers or counterplay. In their first face-off in this tournament in Round 2, Divya had missed a queen sacrifice, which may have been decisive.

Praggnanandhaa and Vaishali are in a unique situation—as siblings competing at the highest level of chess. Having a strong player right across the room at home to bounce ideas off is a rare privilege. Those exchanges, however, often come with caveats.

"Sometimes you're discussing ideas you want to play yourself," Vaishali told Chess.com, breaking into a smile.

"Se, yeah, well I tell each other, 'OK, this is my idea, you're not going to play it.'... We both have the tendency to work a lot, forgetting to take rest or breaks. So, we have to remind each other to do that."

In the Open section, Javokhir Sindarov may have robbed the



ROUND 9 RESULTS
OPEN
Hikaru Nakamura drew with Andrey Esipenko
Fabiano Caruana lost to Anish Giri
R Praggnanandhaa drew with Wei Yi
Matthias Bluebaum drew with Javokhir Sindarov

STANDINGS
OPEN
7.0 Javokhir Sindarov; 5.5 Anish Giri;
4.5 Fabiano Caruana; 4.0 Hikaru Nakamura, Wei Yi, R Praggnanandhaa, Matthias Bluebaum; 3.0 Andrey Esipenko

WOMEN
5.5 Zhu Jiner, R Vaishali; 5.0 Anna Muzychuk; 4.5 Divya Deshmukh, Kateryna Lagno; 4.0 Aleksandra Goryachkina, Bibisara Assaubayeva; 3.0 Tan Zhongyi

PHOTO: FIDE

tournament of some of its drama and suspense with his insane play but on Wednesday he chose to show he's human after all, missing a winning chance.

The 20-year-old Uzbek let slip a chance to make it to six wins, after going for 24...Bxa4? instead of the winning Queen retreat move, 24...Qb7? allowing Matthias Bluebaum to secure a draw.

"Maybe I could have found it (winning move) if I took time to think, but I played fast... I felt very sad. I need to forget this round and focus on my next games," said Sindarov.

The young Grandmaster has already won the admiration of top players with his dominant show. "My wife asked me, 'have you ever done anything like that?' World no. 1 Magnus Carlsen was quoted as saying, refer-

ring to Sindarov's run in the tournament so far. "I said 'thanks for asking—not really,'" Carlsen won a total of five games in the 2013 Candidates tournament (and went on to become world champion later that year) while Sindarov won five of his first six games.

Anish Giri chose to spice things up in the standings, defeating Fabiano Caruana to take sole second place, 1.5 points behind Sindarov. "I have mathematical chances and they're better than they were two days ago," Giri said, referring to his odds of winning the tournament.

After a shaky start, Giri has been playing impressive chess over the last couple of rounds, while Caruana seems to be struggling—losing two games in a row now. It's these rounds in

the second half that are particularly revealing. It's when players have an idea what they're playing for—first place or nothing. "Gave Fabi 30-40 per cent chance to win before the event but watching the live feed it looks like he's totally given up at this point. Losing to Sindarov totally changed the narrative of his tournament," fellow American Grandmaster Wesley So wrote on X.

Two-time Candidates winner Ian Nepomniachtchi was spotted at the Candidates venue in Cyprus on Wednesday. Ahead of the tournament he had picked Caruana and Praggnanandhaa as favourites for first place and declared that Nakamura has "zero chances" to win the tournament. He must be pleased with one half of his prediction.

India beat Taipei in women's AFC U20

PATHUM THANE: India U20 women's team kept alive their hopes of qualifying for the AFC U20 Asian Cup knockout stage, defeating Chinese Taipei 3-1. Sibani Devi Nongmeikapam (32', 87' p) and Bhumi Devi Khumkham (26') scored for India while Kao Hsin (90+3') pulled one back.

Deepika, Savita back in Indian team

NEW DELHI: Salma Tete will continue to lead India, while drag-flicker Deepika and goalkeeper Savita make a comeback to the 24-member hockey squad for the tour of Argentina later this month. Defender Jyoti and forward Mumtaz Khan also return.

Indian air pistol shooters disappoint

GRANADA: All three Indian shooters failed to enter the final of the men's 10m air pistol event at the ISSF Pistol/Rifle World Cup. Mukesh Nelayalli finished 14th, Ujjawal Malik was 22nd and Pramod 39th.

SPORT TODAY

FOOTBALL

ISL

Jamshedpur FC vs Mumbai City FC 7:30pm

Europa League

Quarter-finals 1st leg

● Bologna vs Aston Villa (12:30am, Friday)

● Porto vs Nottingham Forest

● Freiburg vs Celta Vigo

TENNIS

Bjille Jean King Cup

India vs Mongolia 3:00pm

BADMINTON

Asia Championships

Round 2 from 6:30am

WRESTLING

Asian Championships

Women's rounds 11:00 am

CHESS

Candidates

Round 10 (6:15pm)

BOXING

Asian Championships

Women's finals from 9:00am

C'wealth Sport delegation on Gujarat visit

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

AHMEDABAD: A delegation of Commonwealth Sport began its four-day Gujarat visit to review preparations for the 2030 CWG to be held in Ahmedabad.

The five-member delegation, led by Commonwealth Sport president Donald Rukare, along

with officials from the IOA, began its tour with a meeting with chief minister Bhupendra Patel in Gandhinagar.

CM Patel wrote on X: "It was a pleasure to meet the delegation during their first official visit to Gujarat to review preparations for the 2030 CWG, led by president Donald Rukare. We discussed our time-bound, qualita-

tive and effective planning, inspired by the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, to deliver the centenary edition with excellence through strong teamwork," he added.

The CM assured the delegation that the state government would provide all necessary facilities and infrastructure for the successful conduct of CWG.



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